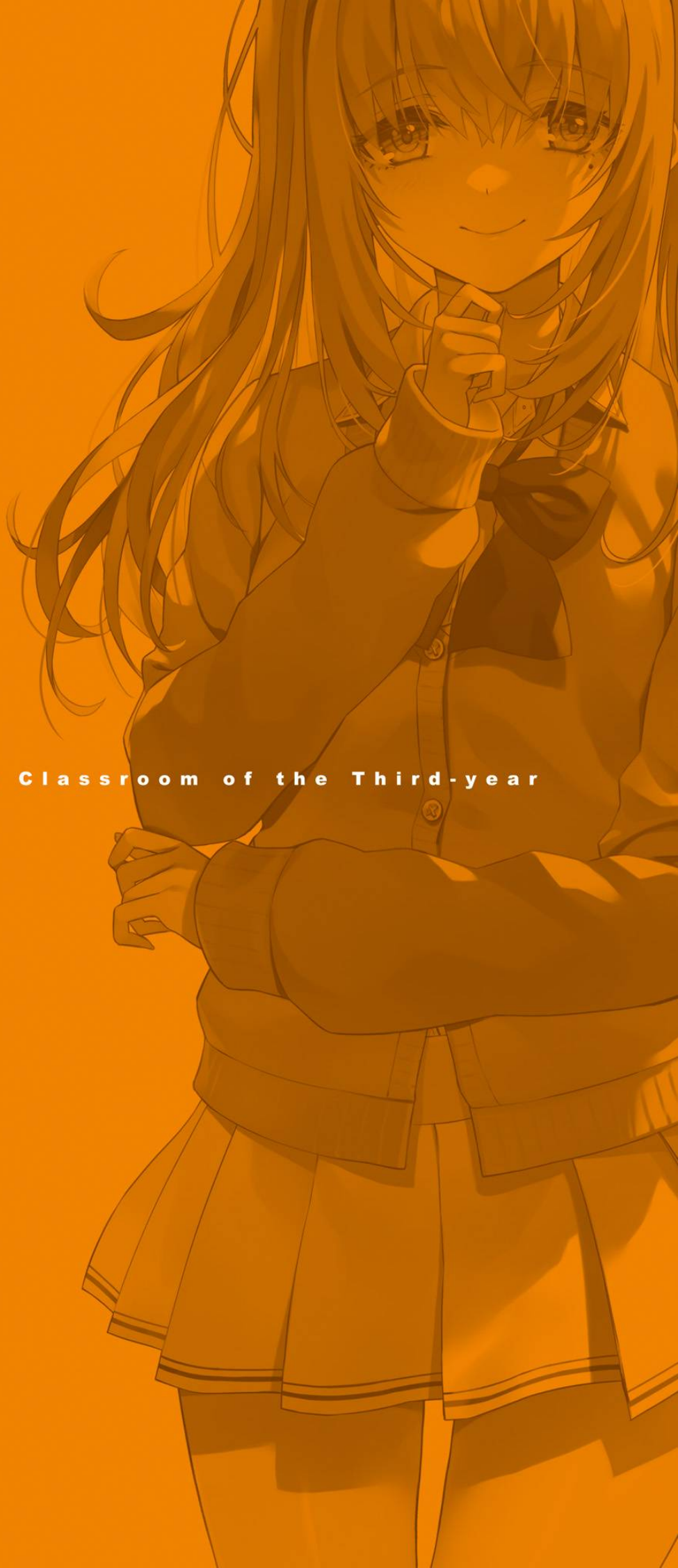

CLASSROOM OF THE ELITE
2
YEAR 3
SYOUGO KINUGASA
TOMOSESHUNSAKU
ART BY


CLASSROOM OF THE ELITE
YEAR 3
SYOUGO KINUGASA
ART BY TOMOSESHUNSAKU
2



Welcome to the Classroom of the Third-year

遺


"You're... not going to forcibly ask me about Ayanokouji-kun, are you, Ryuuen-kun?"
"I just don't think I'd be able to get any useful information out of you even if I did ask, that's all."
"...Is that really all that there's to it?"
"Huh? What do you want me to say? You want me to order you to go dig up his weaknesses by any means necessary?
"-That's..."
遺


"Thank you so much."
"No need to thank me. It's just some self-satisfaction on my part, a selfish token of apology."
I simply wanted to give Hiyori a present.
I genuinely wanted to make her happy.
Acting on that impulsive-like feeling, I gifted her a red poppy flower.
遺


Shiraishi Asuka
Nanase Tsubasa
遺

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Synopsis

“It’s my intention to have you spit out every single one of your secrets today.”

Recognised as the leader, Ayanokouji continues to deepen his relationships with the members of Class C, whom he previously had little interaction, such as Shimazaki, Yoshida, Shiraishi, and Nishikawa.

Amidst this, a new special exam, shrouded in mystery, is announced.

Only two pieces of information were given: ‘A new special exam will begin tomorrow,’ and ‘The details will be announced in one week.’ Class C demonstrates its excellence by immediately discussing the possibilities of various exams and how to respond.

On the other hand, Horikita's Class A is unable to unite, with accumulated damage from Spring causing some to lash out at Chabashira and the such. However, Horikita is isn't tackling the problems related to her class and student council alone, but with the consultation of Karuizawa, Kushida, Ibuki; beginning to show her signs of growth—.

The series is in top form! The second installment of the third-year arc, where the students' feelings are all in turmoil!

Prologue:
Nanase Tsubasa's Monologue

"HOW DID IT come to this—"

I quietly murmured beside him as he laid unconsciously in his hospital room.

"He suffers from a prolonged disturbance of consciousness. That's the diagnosis I received."

The man stated in an unreadable tone, gently stroking the 'Matsuo Eiichirou' written on the name card attached to the bed.

It was a prolonged disturbance of consciousness. To put it simply, a vegetative state.

It meant that although he could open his eyes and breathe, he wasn't conscious and didn't recognize or react to his surroundings.

The doctor said there was a chance he could regain consciousness within a few weeks or months of its onset, but... but... that hope was slim.

"I'm told Matsuo-kun was a very kind-hearted person."

"...Yes... If I... If I'd noticed something was wrong with Eiichirou-kun, this wouldn't have happened, no... I never would have let something like this happen..."

Full of regret and sadness, my tears flowed endlessly.

"You cannot survive in this world on kindness alone. No, in fact, you'll be preyed upon by fiends so wicked they are beyond salvation—"

The man murmured and turned to face me, smiling.

"The world works on give-and-take. You understand that, yes?"

"Yes. I am grateful for your considerable support."

After visiting one hospital after another, he was the one who ultimately found a place that would accept Eiichirou.

If we'd arrived even thirty minutes late, he might not have survived.

"What is it you want me to do?"

"I have brought you an opportunity to exact your revenge."

"...An opportunity...?"

"I will teach you how to get close to the person you should take revenge on."

Saying so, the man placed an 'application form' and a photograph on the portable table.

"What is this...?"

"Attending ANHS is the only way to get close to your target—"

"...I realize I haven't asked your name... Who are you?"

"My apologies. My name is Tsukishiro. I've been well acquainted with you and Matsuo-kun sleeping here, since you were children."

"I've seen plenty of adults approach me, pretending to know things when they really know nothing."

"Is Shirogane-san doing well?"

Upon hearing that name, my body reacted unconsciously, betraying my feigned composure.

He knew us since we were children.

And in an instant I understood that he was telling the truth.

"So you know Shirogane-sensei."

"She took good care of me when I was young."

He looked to be about the same age as Shirogane-sensei. If that were the case, I could easily imagine that his definition of being 'taken care of' was completely different from ours.

"You're not evil. But the inhabitants of the world I live in are nothing but evil, no matter where you look. They're either evil cloaked in the guise of justice, or they're simply pure evil. However, you're different, Nanase Tsubasa-san. You're ordinary, yet excellent. Ordinary, yet immature. Ordinary, yet talented. It's precisely such a person who is sometimes capable of striking down evil. This is a personal philosophy of mine, as one who lives in this world."

"You're Tsukishiro-san, you said. Is this boy connected to that evil?"

The one in the picture was a boy who looked to be about my age.

"He is Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, a key figure who will lead you to the target of your revenge. He has already enrolled at ANHS and is living among the general student body."

"You want me to get close to him?"

"Yes. I will give you instructions as needed. Everything is for the sake of accomplishing your revenge. We shall act according to the circumstances.

However, be careful. That boy, though inorganic, has outstanding, refined instincts. If you approach him carelessly, he will easily see through you."

"Then, what should I do?"

"You must mix lies with the truth. It is, at the very least, an undeniable fact that you care for Matsuo Eiichirou and wish to fight a battle in his name to avenge him. Therefore, you should use that as a foundation to construct a new persona and maneuver in such a way that he cannot grasp your true intentions. He will naturally be suspicious of you, but he won't delve too deeply. That is because he will recognize you as an insignificant being."

"Let me ask one last thing. Why me?"

"It is because you are in a perfect position. Neither clearly on one side, nor the other. It's precisely because it's uncertain which way you will lean that I've decided you're the most suitable person for me to send."

"Then, what if I were to accept Ayanokouji—?"

"That's something we can consider when the time comes."

When he asked me if I would do it, I nodded without a pause.

Even now, I sometimes remember that exchange as if it were a dream.

At that time, in that hospital room, my heart was at least set on revenge.

I'd planned to drag out Ayanokouji Atsuomi, the one who cornered Eiichirou.

But now, things are a little different.

I want to help Ayanokouji-senpai.

I've come to think so from the bottom of my heart.

Because if he graduates from ANHS as he is now, he will go down a path of pure evil.

Victims, like Eiichirou, will end up being created by his hand.

I don't want that.

Then—as the one who knows firsthand of that predicament, I must stop it.

And even today, I continue to search for that small key in the deep forest...

Chapter 1:
Fitting In

ON SUNDAY MORNING, I looked out of my room's window and saw that it was, unfortunately, going to be raining all day.

It wasn't a downpour, but the kind of weather that would make one hesitant to go out even with an umbrella. Despite that, after getting dressed before 10:00 a.m., I promptly grabbed an umbrella and decided to head down to the dorm lobby. When I stepped into the elevator, the wet floor caught my eye. It was evident that students had been coming in and out of the dorms since early morning.

"Yo, mornin'."

The moment I reached the first floor and the elevator doors opened, a male student in a hoodie, standing by the entrance, turned around, raising his hand as he greeted me. It was my classmate, Yoshida.

"Morning."

After we exchanged brief greetings, Yoshida immediately looked toward the sofa.

"Shimazaki came down a little while ago, too."

Having likely heard him, the now-named Shimazaki stood up and removed a white wireless earbud from his right ear. He put it away in a small case he took from his bag—what I presumed to be a dedicated case for the wireless earbuds.

"What were you listening to?"

I asked as I followed Yoshida and walked over to Shimazaki.

"English listening practice for the entrance exams. Personally, English isn't my strong suit, so I want to devote as much time as possible to it now, while I still can."

I supposed he didn't want to waste even the short amount of time he spent waiting for his classmates.

"Huh? You're bad at English? You get better scores than me, don'tcha?"

Yoshida grumbled, looking up at the ceiling as if recalling past test results.

"There's no point in comparing me to you. In reality, it's my weakest subject."

"Yeah, yeah. My bad for comparing us."

Yoshida apologized, albeit with a disgruntled look. Shimazaki possessed the academic ability and grades to naturally rank among the top of his year, but he likely achieved those results because he was aware of his weaknesses and took thorough measures to address them.

The time for third-year students to take their entrance exams was approaching. This level of awareness was just what you'd expect from a former Class A student.

"I thought that was a sarcastic remark, but you're not getting angry at it."

I thought Yoshida was pretty short-tempered, but he didn't seem particularly angry at Shimazaki's comment.

"Well, yeah, it's a little annoying, but this guy's always studying. I'm not that into studying, and it's true there's a gap between us."

That was Yoshida's answer, but it might have also been that the two of them were simply good friends.

"By the way, have you seriously been doing nothing but studying lately?"

"I wonder. I try to set aside at least five hours a day to study, but that's about it."

Of course, that five-hour period didn't include daily courses.

I didn't know how much time the average third-year high school student devoted to self-study, but it was certainly not a small amount.

Yoshida made an exaggerated gesture with his hands, as if to say there was no way he could do five hours.

"The right to graduate from Class A is ultimately just a trump card. To get into a reasonably good university, this much is a given, and it doesn't just apply to me. I'll be stopping by the cram school at Keyaki Mall this evening as well."

"Seriously? How much are you gonna study..."

Come to think of it, there was a cram school in the mall which was provided by ANHS. I had no use for that place, so I'd never stopped by. I'd heard that you could attend it for free, even without Private Points, if you met certain conditions, such as having no behavioral problems and a clear vision for your academic future, like a target university.

"A cram school, huh? How many students actually go there?"

When I asked Shimazaki that, simply out of curiosity, he glared at me for some reason.

"You don't know? Speaking only of third-years, there are twenty of us right now. Even so, the ratio should be quite low compared to a normal high school. But the numbers will probably grow as we head toward summer."

So that was how many students were starting to prepare for the entrance exams.

"Your grades aren't bad either, so wouldn't it be a good idea for you to at least show your face there?"

It was true that Yoshida was inferior compared to Shimazaki, but he still had high academic scores.

If he was considering university, it wouldn't be strange for him to start attending.

Shimazaki probably recommended it with the best intentions, but Yoshida immediately refused.

"No way, not happening. I'm fine with just an average university, just average. I can't stand the idea of being buried in my studies even on my days off when I could be hangin' out with friends. It's suffocating, ain't it? Nothin' but studying," he said, turning down the offer as he glanced sideways at the serious Shimazaki.

"If that's the case, fine. I have no intention of forcing you to study. That's precisely why it's my own business what I do, when, and where, as long as it isn't a nuisance to you."

Shimazaki knitted his brows and glared at Yoshida, perhaps feeling that his attitude toward studying had been criticized.

"O-Of course, it's your own business. Don't be so mad."

In response, Yoshida hurriedly held up both hands, palms open, and offered an apology.

"A-Ahem. So? What's the reason you called me and Ayanokouji out on our day off?"

He cleared his throat once, then asked Shimazaki for the reason, as if trying to change the subject.

It was a precious day off, an important day he would normally have spent studying on his own. Indeed, I was curious as to why someone like Shimazaki had invited us out.

"The truth is, my business is only with Ayanokouji, but we aren't exactly on terms where we can just go out and talk. I figured things would proceed more smoothly if you were here."

Apparently, Yoshida had nothing to do with the matter itself.

The word 'talk' coming up in the conversation gave me a slightly clearer idea of his objective.

"So that's what this is about. Well, people naturally tend to rely on me, after all."

Even though he expressed how much of a pain it was, he narrowed his eyes, looking somewhat pleased.

"Anyway, since you asked, I'll be sure to help you out. Ayanokouji, you better hear Shimazaki out properly."

As if passing the responsibility on to me, Yoshida placed a hand on my shoulder and said so.

"That depends on the topic of discussion. What exactly did you want to talk about?"

Just as Shimazaki said, my relationship with him was by no means a deep one; there was still some distance between us.

There had to be a clear reason for him to go out of his way to approach someone like me for a talk.

Another thing that bothered me was that he'd asked me to bring an umbrella.

If it were just for a talk, there would've been no need to go out on a rainy day; it wouldn't have been difficult to just talk in someone's room.

Shimazaki glanced around briefly before looking me straight in the eye.

"Today, I'm going to make you confess all of your secrets."

"...Secrets?"

"Talking about it here won't solve anything. You'll understand if you just follow me for now."

With that, Shimazaki left the lobby, immediately opened his umbrella, and started walking at a rather brisk pace.

"What the heck? I wonder where he's headed."

"Who knows. He said Keyaki Mall, but—"

After briefly exchanging glances with Yoshida, we decided to follow Shimazaki as well.

Part 1

SHIMAZAKI, WHO'D BEEN walking ahead, made his way straight to Keyaki Mall. Upon arriving, he headed towards the stand for plastic umbrella bags set up at the entrance, pulled a bag free and slipped his umbrella inside. We copied his actions before entering the mall. And when we reached the bookstore, he finally turned to face us.

"A bookstore, huh? Taking a detour?"

Without a word to Yoshida who muttered something, Shimazaki entered the store and headed without hesitation for the student reference section—in other words, the corner where the study guides were displayed.

"This is where I wanted to bring you, Ayanokouji."

It seemed this wasn't just a small detour, but our destination, the end of the line.

"Tell me what kind of study guides you usually use, and how you study."

Hearing those words, I finally began to see what Shimazaki wanted to consult me about.

"So that's what this is about."

"After seeing the results of the last special exam, I know you're ranked higher than me. I don't expect to catch up to your level today or tomorrow. But that doesn't mean I'm going to give up trying."

The reason he'd glared at me when we talked about cram school was likely due to his subconscious sense of rivalry.

He wanted to adopt a more efficient learning style to get even a little closer to my academic ability.

Shimazaki's strong determination came through loud and clear.

"Go on, tell him, Ayanokouji."

Yoshida, acting as the go-between, urged me on, but I didn't open my mouth.

Or rather, it was more accurate to say I couldn't.

I very much wanted to grant his wish, but I didn't have the answer he was looking for. While most high schoolers were currently in the process of tackling and learning new material, I'd completed that process in my childhood. The studying I was doing now wasn't learning, but a complete review, so I couldn't provide the answer he was hoping for.

"Hey, Ayanoko—"

"It's fine, Yoshida. It's only natural that he wouldn't be so willing to teach me this easily," Shimazaki said, furrowing his brows in response to my silence.

"It's a study method you developed on your own. I'm not expecting you to teach me for free. If you need Private Points, or if there's something else you want—"

I cut off Shimazaki, who, wanting to learn my secret one way or another, was trying to start negotiations.

"If this was a problem I could solve, I would've been more than willing to cooperate."

"—'Would've been,' huh? Is it a trade secret when it comes to studying? Or do you need a bigger reward?"

"No, I don't need any reward. In the first place, if your academic ability improves, Shimazaki, it will naturally lead to raising the class's overall level and contributing to it. That's more than enough of a reward for me. Besides, it's not as if I'll have any trouble no matter how much you improve your academics from now on."

I explained as best I could so he would understand, but it probably wouldn't be so easy.

"I see. I understand the logic, in theory. But the fact that you're still not willing to teach me... is it because you want to prevent me from catching up to you, no matter what?"

"That's not it, either. If you think I'm concerned about appearances, you're mistaken. It's not that I want to show off being number one, nor do I want to be."

In this school, there are definitely students who are better than me in various fields.

I wanted it to be that way, and in fact, it had to be.

If someone were to be able to surpass me in the field of academics, I wanted to see it.

"If you're going to say all of that, then tell me what study guides you use. And I want you to tell me in detail about your usual study methods and how you manage your time."

He questioned me without reservation, with a spirit that showed he would analyze everything about me. Then he added a disclaimer.

"Of course, I won't blame you if it's not effective. I'll just accept that the method wasn't right for me, so don't worry."

His sincere attitude toward studying seemed genuine.

And as if to jump on the bandwagon, Yoshida also stood next to Shimazaki.

"Oh, uh, teach me too, just in case. If I can study more efficiently, I'll copy it."

What should I do? The general study method I used for Karuizawa, the sort of normal, student-like teaching style for classmates, probably wouldn't be suitable for high-level students like Shimazaki and Yoshida.

Naturally, the advanced study method I was considering—which was modeled on the White Room training—wasn't something I could realistically put into practice yet.

Knowing they probably wouldn't trust what I was going to say, I figured I'd give them part of the truth

"To be honest, I hardly ever use these kinds of study guides anymore."

"...What? No, but you don't go to cram school either. You were solving problems that were not only difficult, but also in areas we haven't even been taught. How do you explain that?"

"To be honest, a lot of it is just coincidence. I usually pick up my knowledge from the internet. You know how nowadays, there are even sites where people post videos which solve and teach difficult problems, right? I just happened to have seen a similar problem like that in a video I was watching, so I was able to solve it."

"Well, I suppose things like that might happen sometimes, but..."

Perhaps because he was good at studying himself, Shimazaki's suspicion seemed to deepen in some regards, and he trailed off without showing any sign of being convinced. Even though they still had some doubts in me, I made sure to emphasize that I didn't watch only specific sites or channels.

In the end, he would probably take it as me being secretive, but that couldn't be helped.

"However—there was a study guide that I felt was useful."

I visited bookstores quite often. During my visits, I had skimmed through several study guides to see what kind of things were written in them and to what extent. Relying on that memory, it was possible for me to tell Shimazaki and the others which was the most suitable for learning.

"If you're still okay with it, I'd like to offer you some advice."

I wasn't going to teach him nothing; rather, I made it clear that I intended to tell him what I could, and that I wanted him to use whatever he found helpful.

After that, it was up to the recipient, Shimazaki, to decide on what to do next. The matter was in his hands.

Would he write me off as a jerk who wouldn't tell him the truth, or would he choose to move forward from his current situation, using me for his own benefit even while having his doubts about that side of me?

With almost no time to hesitate, Shimazaki nodded in reply.

"Alright. I'll take your advice without any hesitation."

It seemed he decided to start by trusting me, all for the sake of improving his own abilities.

In response to his request, I recommended a study guide that I had a good feeling about.

They both picked it up without hesitation, but Yoshida quickly gave up on buying it. This was because, naturally, the information required in a study guide varied greatly depending on the level and focus of the university one was aiming for. Even if it was a hit for Shimazaki, who was aiming for the top, it might be irrelevant to Yoshida.

And so, after that, we decided to ask Yoshida some questions, and the two of us, Shimazaki and I, would find a study guide that we thought would suit him.

We wandered around the study guide section for about thirty minutes, looking at various books, discussing what would and wouldn't work, and repeatedly picking them up and putting them back. Though some of our exchanges seemed pointless, it never felt like a waste of time; in fact, it was fulfilling and fun. Bit by bit, we started to gradually understand Yoshida's preferences, and finally settled on a study guide for him to buy.

It was a small thing, but I was able to get something close to a sense of accomplishment from working together to create something.

Then, finally, the three of us split up for a bit, browsed to see if there were any other books we wanted to buy, and then regrouped inside the bookstore.

I found a few magazines and novels that caught my eye, but I still didn't have many Private Points to spare, so I decided to pass on all of them for now.

"What are those books?"

Shimazaki pointed out to Yoshida, who'd returned with an armful of books in addition to the study guides that Shimazaki and I recommended.

"Hm, these? It's fine if I buy stuff other than study guides, right?"

The books Yoshida was holding were men's fashion magazines and manga. There were books about appearance and clothing to be popular with the opposite sex, and books about conversation skills and techniques.

"Studying is important, but I wanna take romance seriously, too. We don't even have a year of high school left, you know? You think I can waste my last chance to have a romance with a high school girl?"

Yoshida said as the three of us headed for the register.

"I don't think it's necessarily your last chance, but..."

Shimazaki retorted, a little taken aback, but he was certainly right.


数学Ⅲ·C

Even as a college student or a working adult, the chance of dating a high school girl wasn't zero.

No, if the age gap was too large, that would probably cause other problems.

I was seriously considering this, but there was likely another, bigger reason.

"Is it because you'd feel uneasy if you couldn't see Shiraishi anymore?"

It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say that this was bound by the condition of 'until we graduate from ANHS.'

I didn't mean anything by it, I only wanted to confirm his true intentions, but hearing the name Shiraishi, Yoshida became extremely flustered and dropped one of the books he was holding.

"H-Hey, Ayanokouji, don't say unnecessary stuff like that!"

He looked like he was about to cover my mouth, but the words were already out and couldn't be taken back.

"I was just genuinely curious, so I asked... Was that bad?"

"O-Of course it's bad! I-It's not like I like Shiraishi or anything! I told you that before, didn't I!?"

It was true that Yoshida himself denied it, but his attitude had been saying otherwise all along.

Even Shiraishi was convinced that Yoshida had feelings for her.

It wouldn't be an exaggeration to say he had feelings for her, 99 percent—no, 100 percent of the time.

"...Shiraishi? You like Shiraishi...?"

Shimazaki, who was walking a little ahead, turned back and muttered this as he watched Yoshida pick up his book.

"I told you I don't like her! I'm just... a little interested, that's all...!"

It was an answer that one could safely say meant he did like her. Shimazaki, who registered the blatant reaction, seemed focused solely on his studies and uninterested in romance. Just as I was about to interpret it that way, his expression clouded over for an instant. I wondered if he had something on his mind.

"...I see..."

Seeing Shimazaki's heavy, different attitude from before, Yoshida's expression suddenly became panicked.

In an instant, various thoughts seemed to race through his mind, and he arrived at a certain conclusion.

"D-Don't tell me... you're one of the one hundred guys she's shot down, are you!?"

"Huh? 'Shot down a hundred guys'—of course not."

Sighing in exasperation, Shimazaki immediately denied it. Right after, he showed an angry-looking face.

"Yoshida, do you really like Shiraishi?"

"I-I told you, I don't like her, I'm just... just a tiny bit interested, that's all."

The more he denied it, the more it sounded like he was declaring his love.

In fact, Shimazaki, who was watching his reaction, likely felt the same way.

"Fine, whatever, just listen. That's just a rumor. Don't take something so stupid seriously."

"W-well, yeah, but... they say where there's smoke, there's fire, right...?"

"It depends on how that fire was started. That was a lie Shiraishi intentionally spread herself."

The "100-man-slayer" nickname had been on my mind.

I was surprised to hear it so strongly denied from such an unexpected source.

Yoshida's surprise and agitation seemed even greater; his voice was caught in his throat as if frozen.

After a moment, however, his brain seemed to have processed it a little, and he asked back in a strained voice.

"Huh? A lie? H-how would you know something like that?"

In response to the question, Shimazaki quietly looked around. More cautiously than he had in the lobby.

Fortunately, there seemed to be no other customers, and the inside of the store was quiet.

After confirming this, he came back to stand before Yoshida, lowered his voice, and spoke.

"Do you remember when you first started hearing that stupid rumor?"

"Uhm, I think that was... around summertime our first year... wasn't it? Something about a '20-man-slayer.'"

To 'slay' 100 men, one naturally had to start with one. Unless she'd accomplished it before high school, it was only natural for the rumor to start with a smaller number.

Well, not that it meant much coming from me, as I wasn't too familiar with the nickname.

"To be precise, it was after the uninhabited island exam. At that time, Shiraishi startedgetting close with Nishikawa. It was then, from the second term onward, that such a stupid story suddenly started to surface."

A situation from the first year in Class A that I couldn't have known.

Recalling the scene, Yoshida lightly tapped the corner of a magazine against his chin.

"So you're saying Nishikawa told her to spread that rumor?"

"There's no solid proof, but it's likely. Even if the '20 men' part were true, the '100 men' rumor is an absolute lie. Reaching 100 by adding 80 more people all at once inside this school isn't the least bit realistic. Anyone could figure that out if they thought about it for a second."

I'd also heard the '100-man-slayer' story from Nishikawa. I'd asked out of curiosity if the nickname would become '200-man-slayer,' but the response was that 100 was prestigious enough.

Perhaps they'd spread rumors about how many she'd 'slain' from an early stage, letting it take root little by little.

But for what purpose? That question naturally came to mind.

"B-but, hey, can you... say that for sure? The 20 in middle school might be real, you know."

Yoshida, on the other hand, seemed concerned about something else and pressed Shimazaki.

"I don't know about that. And what if it were true? Is there some problem with you liking Shiraishi?"

As Shimazaki retorted with a sharp, scolding tone, Yoshida seemed to be pushed back even farther than the distance he had closed, taking a spectacular step backward.

"No... that's not it... but..."

"In the first place, there's no way I'd know, not having gone to the same middle school. But I can say with certainty that the current, embellished rumor

is a lie. I've been watching Shiraishi since right after we enrolled, so there's no mistake."

Immediately after blurting that out, Shimazaki averted his gaze from us as if flustered, realizing what he'd said.

A slightly awkward silence fell over the already quiet bookstore.

"...I observe all of my classmates, you know."

Shimazaki belatedly added that as if to deflect, but there was no way one couldn't guess the truth after seeing him act so out of character.

"You—"

Although he'd guessed the reason behind the confident denial and the circumstances behind it, he was probably hesitant to say it directly. I could read from Yoshida's expression the clash between his desire to confirm it and his rationality telling him he shouldn't.

"Don't misunderstand, Yoshida... it's not like that."

"It's not that I'm misunderstanding, or... well... if that's the case, then fine. I mean, it's not like I care about Shiraishi or anything either..."

The two exchanged words while looking in completely different directions.

It seemed that both of them held strong feelings for Shiraishi that they didn't have for other girls. She herself seemed aware of her popularity with the opposite sex and that proved that it wasn't just a facade of confidence.

"Anyway, our business in the bookstore is finished. We'll be in the way, so let's get out of here."

Shimazaki said this, avoiding Yoshida's suspicious gaze.

Indeed, now that they'd decided what to buy, dawdling and chatting would only be a nuisance.

Besides, it was probably best to avoid having other students overhear the conversation.

"...Yeah."

After that, they quickly paid and we decided to leave the bookstore.

Part 2

I THOUGHT WE'D part ways after they finished picking out their reference books, but surprisingly, at Shimazaki's suggestion, we ended up stopping by a rest area.

Perhaps neither of us wanted to leave the somewhat heavy atmosphere hanging between us.

I found myself naturally thinking and interpreting it that way, which was likely proof of my own growing understanding of emotions.

The atmosphere of a place was a difficult thing that could not be physically proven.

However, one's perception of it changed distinctly depending on whether or not one could sense the expressions and tension of those in that space.

In other words, the atmosphere existed for each individual, filtered through their own perspective.

There must have been many times I'd failed to notice and overlooked the atmosphere of a place back when I first enrolled.

Even when I felt I understood, it was only ever on the surface. There must have been many times when I was uncertain.

That was how little knowledge and experience I had with this thing called 'emotion.'

But now, things were a little different.

I was becoming able to clearly feel the emotions of others, as if by instinct.

And unconsciously, at that.

After placing the books they purchased on a bench, Shimazaki started walking toward the vending machines.

"What do you want? It's to thank you for helping me pick out the reference books. Let me treat you."

His voice came from over his shoulder as he stood with his back to me, looking at the vending machines.

"Are you sure?"

"Of course. Besides, from the looks of it back in the bookstore, you're trying to save money, right? I know you used your Private Points to transfer classes."

Since he'd made such a generous offer, I decided to accept it without reservation.

"You gonna treat me, too?"

"You're paying for your own."

"Stingy..."

After muttering that under his breath, Yoshida stood in front of the vending machine next to Shimazaki's with a look of resignation.

"I actually wanted to treat you to the café, but it's too crowded right now."

Perhaps because of the rain, students with time on their hands on a day off were flocking to the café, forming a line. When we'd passed by earlier, a large crowd was already waiting to get in.

In that sense, this was probably a better place to talk, at least for today.

I was handed the can of black coffee he bought for me from the vending machine, and I opened it with a *pssh*. I fiddled with the pull tab for a moment before quietly pushing it in. A faint, aromatic scent rose from the slightly warped aluminum opening.

"Black coffee, huh? You've got good taste."

Shimazaki, who said that, also had the same canned coffee.

"You like it?"

"To be honest, it's not really my favorite, but it's perfect for when I need to focus. It's a powerful stimulant."

It seemed he was more interested in the effects of drinking black coffee than the taste.

Meanwhile, Yoshida was still groaning in front of the vending machine, apparently undecided on what to buy.

"You're taking your sweet time. If you don't want anything, you don't have to force it."

Shimazaki jabbed, looking at Yoshida's back as his fingers hovered before the buttons.

"Well, like... I'm definitely thirsty. But I don't wanna drink *that* much. So, like, in times like that, don't you have trouble choosing between this one and that one?"

Yoshida smoothly slid one step to the side of the vending machine, and turning to us, pointed alternately at two products. One was a 500 ml tea, and the other was a 280 ml tea; they were the exact same product other than the size.

"The 280 ml is enough, but the price difference is only 20 points, ya know? So I really wrack my brain trying to figure out the right choice."

It wasn't limited to drinks; the same could be said for many products on sale. Even with snacks, buying the large bag was cheaper and gave you more, but it lacked the convenience of the smaller, individually wrapped packages.

"You'd normally go for cost-performance. If it's only a 20-point difference, just buy the 500 ml one without thinking."

Shimazaki answered instantly. He probably always did so himself.

"Yeah, I guess... But I often end up not being able to finish it all. Still, you're right, considering the cost-performance is probably—"

"I'd go with the 280 ml one. If you're not confident you can finish it from the start, the taste will degrade over time even if you take it home. Even if tea has antibacterial properties, once you open the bottle and drink from it, bacteria from your mouth will get in. You can't ignore the hygiene aspect, either."

"Ugh...! Y-Yeah, that's true... That happens too, so..."

I thought my comment might have been unnecessary, but after I gave him my take on it, Yoshida began to waver again.

And in the end, the choice Yoshida made was to press both buttons at the same time.

The 500 ml one came out. The look on Yoshida's face as he clutched the plastic bottle wasn't one of satisfaction, but more of a self-questioning: *Was this the right one?* But he probably would've had the same expression even if the 280 ml one came out instead.

Just as Yoshida, who bought his drink after so much hesitation, had finished about a third of his tea on the spot, I noticed him looking restlessly at Shimazaki.

He likely wanted to continue the conversation from the bookstore but couldn't bring himself to start it.

"Shimazaki. About that '100-man slayer' story—"

I decided I should be the one to bring it up, so I asked him directly.

Yoshida immediately came closer and sat down next to Shimazaki.

"You don't actually believe a rumor like that, do you, Ayanokouji?"

"When I first heard it from Nishikawa, I took it at face value, but listening to the story up to this point, parts of it started to feel unnatural. Even if she was in a different class, with a nickname like that, it wouldn't be strange to have heard of it, yet I'd never heard a single rumor about Shiraishi."

"Is that... so? It's true you didn't seem to know..."

Of course, it could've just been that I was ignorant and uninterested in such things, but I'd never even heard Shiraishi's name from another student, let alone her nickname.

"But, even if everything Shimazaki's saying is true, why would she do something so half-assed?"

The idea that it was a pretext to keep the opposite sex away likely already occurred to Yoshida.

While a certain number of people would surely be repulsed by an extensive romantic history, it wasn't a foolproof method, as evidenced by how Yoshida, sitting beside us, hadn't lost his affection for Shiraishi even after hearing the rumor. Furthermore, the fact that they hadn't forced the rumor to spread to other classes or grades also created a strange sense of incongruity.

"This is just my speculation, but... I think Nishikawa has special feelings for Shiraishi. I figure that's what started the rumor. Don't you think she figured that a rumor about being a '100-man slayer' would be convenient for keeping boys away? Sure, there are more than a few guys who'd hear a rumor like that and be happy, thinking she's an easy woman, but it's more likely to make her an object of disgust, right?"

Shimazaki shared his thoughts as a possible answer to the questions floating in our minds.

Yoshida made an awkward face for a moment, but I didn't do something so tactless as to point it out.

"...What're you talking about? Nishikawa's a girl."

"This isn't an age where romance is limited by gender."

"Well, yeah, maybe that's true... but even so, there's no upside for Shiraishi, is there?"

"Is that really the case? Since Shiraishi has no interest in dating boys right now, she might have understood Nishikawa's intentions and gone along with the proposal to keep them away."

After finishing his canned coffee to the last drop, Shimazaki nodded.

It wasn't something I could be certain of yet, but it seemed like a possibility worth considering.

"But still, isn't that going too far? Just to avoid dating guys, wouldn't it be tough for everyone to think you're an easy woman?"

"I think so, too. In which case, another hypothesis comes to mind, right?"

Shimazaki continued, speaking to Yoshida, who hadn't yet formed the hypothesis himself.

"Shiraishi was never interested in boys to begin with. Just like Nishikawa, she's interested in the same sex, and that's precisely why she could make the choice not to be bothered by a rumor that would make her disliked by the opposite sex."

"Wha— S-Seriously...!?"

To appropriately keep boys away, and to accept affection from girls.

This was perhaps the idea to achieve both.

Whether Nishikawa knew of Shiraishi's preferences was currently unknown, but the possibility couldn't be dismissed as zero.

Shimazaki's slip of the tongue—"I've been watching Shiraishi since right after we enrolled, so I'm not mistaken"—also didn't seem to be a complete exaggeration.

But at the same time, the flaws were also conspicuous. I'd heard this '100-man slayer' rumor from Nishikawa's mouth; I hadn't been told about the nickname from Shiraishi herself. That said, it was unlikely the rumor was spreading without her knowledge. As long as it was being whispered about in class, it should've reached her ears sooner or later. Since the first-year uninhabited island exam, it was almost a 100% probability.

And even if Shiraishi liked other girls, the rumor, while serving to keep boys away, also carried the risk of other girls keeping their distance. If the primary assumption was that Shiraishi liked boys, then other girls wouldn't approach her so casually either.

"Like I said earlier, this is all speculation. There's no guarantee that anything is correct, apart from the lie about the '100-man slayer'—no, even that included. I'm just drawing my own conclusions from what I've seen. If you can't believe me, you can check for yourself."

Having finished speaking, Shimazaki took a breath, perhaps because his excitement had calmed down a bit.

He stood up, threw his coffee can into the trash, and came back.

"So, why are you even telling us all this in so much detail?"

"You want to know why?"

"Well... I kinda want to know, but I kinda don't..."

"Relax, Yoshida. I was planning on answering even if you didn't ask."

With that, Shimazaki stood not in front of Yoshida—but in front of me.

"This reference book was a big help. But there's still a lot more I want you to teach me. I figure if I lend a hand here, maybe you'll spill your secrets someday, Ayanokouji."

Apparently, what was important to Shimazaki was neither Shiraishi's situation nor Yoshida's true feelings.

More than any of that, it seemed he wanted to prioritize studying efficiently for now.

"It's also fine if you just told me now, you know?"

"Sorry, but I haven't done anything special besides what I've already told you."

When I gave the same response again, Shimazaki let out a sigh.

"'Searching online and watching videos,' was it? I'm sorry, but such a mundane method doesn't explain a perfect score."

"I told you that chance was a big factor. In any case, I just like to look up extraneous things. I have a habit of looking up what students learn in their third year of high school, or what they learn in university. In the process, I just happened to learn how to solve a problem that appeared on the exam."

As I rattled off my excuses, Shimazaki pressed his lips together firmly, but as if he realized how his own attitude appeared, he immediately relaxed and exhaled.

"Well... I suppose it's not like you can just tell me everything so easily."

Without persistently questioning me, it seemed Shimazaki gave up his pursuit for the time being.

His sharp comprehension and judgment in that area made our interactions efficient and were a great help.

"But information is information. I'll have you pay me back in kind someday."

Since it was a debt that money couldn't settle, it seemed difficult to repay, but it couldn't be helped.

It was certain that the conversation not only eased the feelings of Yoshida, who harbored affection for Shiraishi, but was also meaningful for me, as I had doubts about Shiraishi's way of thinking.

Part 3

A LITTLE WHILE later, Shimazaki said he was going to study and left ahead of us.

Meanwhile, Yoshida, perhaps still unable to sort out his feelings, remained sitting on the bench, his back hunched over as he clutched a half-full plastic bottle with both hands. All things considered, the 280 ml bottle might have been the better choice.

"Shouldn't we head home? It looks like the weather's going to get even worse."

If the downpour got any stronger, our pants would likely get soaked even with an umbrella.

Although I spoke to him, he didn't react—his mind seemingly elsewhere. I watched over him from nearby for a while, but just as I was about to prompt him again, his hunched back straightened up.

"...Yeah, you're right..."

He then gave a listless reply, stood up, and started to walk away sluggishly.

"You forgot your book."

When I handed him the book, which had been left in a paper bag on the bench, he accepted it with another listless reply. Our earlier conversation was clearly weighing heavily on his mind.

"What am I supposed to do if Shiraishi likes girls...? I'm a guy, y'know, a guy!"

"That hasn't been confirmed as the truth yet."

"But still..."

"If you're this shocked at this point, you should probably give up on having feelings for Shiraishi. It's possible the '100-man slayer' rumor is true, that she likes girls, and on top of that, something else you don't want could come up, Yoshida. Am I wrong?"

This wasn't a story limited to just Shiraishi. When trying to get to know someone, discovering an unimaginable past was something one could experience many times in life. If he wasn't prepared for that, then retreating was also a form of courage.

"...Something I don't want, huh."

Whether it was because of the shock or because he'd finally admitted his feelings for Shiraishi, he no longer showed any signs of refuting that point.

"I... yeah, that's right... Who cares about '100-man slayer,' who cares if she likes girls... I have to accept that, or I can't move forward, right?"

To carve out a possibility, he had to walk a thorny path.

He put strength into his arms, and as he hugged the book tightly, the light began to return to Yoshida's eyes.

"Alright—I...!"

"Rather than worrying about the past, the thing you should be most down about right now is that Shimazaki likes Shiraishi. That's an undeniable truth."

"Guh!"

Yoshida, who'd just been getting fired up, made an exaggerated motion as if he were coughing up blood to show how hard he'd been hit.

"Hey, Ayanokouji, are you tryin' to cheer me up or get me down?! Which is it!"

"I suppose my timing was poor, but I only meant to inform you of the situation. It's neither of those."

"Sayin' it's neither is pretty harsh, ain't it?"

Now that he mentioned it, he was certainly right.

"I want to cheer you up."

"Don't say it so artificially... You're that kinda guy, aren't you?"

Just as I was analyzing him in various ways, it seemed Yoshida was analyzing me in a similar fashion.

"I mean, that's the reality of the situation. I can't believe Shimazaki is a rival...*sigh*."

Perhaps because the area just outside the entrance to Keyaki Mall was deserted, Yoshida brought the subject up again. He likely couldn't help but try to get it off his chest.

As we opened our umbrellas and started walking, a heavy rain immediately began to patter against the fabric.

"Does it bother you that Shimazaki is a rival?"

"Well, yeah, of course. For this sorta thing, the fewer rivals the better. Shiraishi's already super popular. Not a lot of guys are makin' a move on her

'cause of the rumors, but if those turn out to be fake, they'll probably all rush her at once."

If that happened, the problem would no longer be just about Shimazaki.

"Still, it didn't look like he was planning on confessing his feelings to Shiraishi for the time being."

Just watching from a distance was enough for him. Depending on one's perspective, it could be said that he lacked the courage to pursue romance, but that depended on how much importance he judged it to have in his future life. Despite his high academic ability, Shimazaki never grew complacent and studied even on his days off to achieve even the slightest improvement. That suggested that his target school was of a very high level. From that, there was no doubt that his first priority wasn't romance.

Even so, with the appearance of an unexpected rival, someone who prioritized romance would naturally feel impatient.

"Come on, people can have a sudden change of heart... If I start goin' after Shiraishi openly, all those feelings he's been holdin' back might just explode out. Ain't that right?"

"That's possible."

Perhaps because he'd admitted his feelings in front of me and Shimazaki, Yoshida no longer tried to hide his true feelings.

Romantic feelings weren't something that could be easily controlled.

Even if I hadn't experienced it myself, I understood it as fact.

"Just to be sure, you ain't gonna say you're after Shiraishi too, right?"

"I believe I already denied that."

"But if the rumors are fake, you might join in, right? Plus, you could have a change of heart, no, your feelings could wander. You do sit next to her, after all."

He seemed to want a verbal commitment, so he persistently sought confirmation.

"I'm not sure if you'll be satisfied with me just saying it's fine, but it is."

At that moment, I held no feelings for Shiraishi beyond that of a classmate.

Yoshida, who'd been looking at me as if to ascertain my true intentions, soon nodded as if to show a certain degree of acceptance.

It was probably something he could only process by accepting it.

"Well, I guess she's not at all like Karuizawa, who you dated. Hey, I don't mean that in a bad way, y'know? There's no doubt Karuizawa is cute."

While quite a few boys saw Karuizawa as a *gyaru*, a frivolous girl, in reality she also had a completely different side to her, and she was different from the type of person others imagined. That said, Yoshida's current statement was, above all, proof that her appearance was at a level others envied.

"I know what you're trying to say."

Just as people had likes and dislikes when it came to food, preferences of all kinds existed for romantic interests.

In fact, Shiraishi and Karuizawa were probably not the same type.

That point seemed to have become a reason for Yoshida to feel a little relieved.

Even so, it was hard to believe it was a coincidence that both Shimazaki and Yoshida, two people who'd closed the distance with her early on, were both interested in Shiraishi. Perhaps a fair number of students in the class were hiding feelings close to love for Shiraishi.

"What I don't quite understand is, is Shiraishi actually a popular student with the opposite sex? Well, of course, I'll admit she has superior looks that draw more attention than the average female student, but—"

While they were few in number when looking at the entire grade, it could be said that female students of a similar level still existed.

"She's undeniably cute. And also..."

"And also?"

He seemed to be implicitly suggesting that it wasn't just about her physical appeal.

But whether he was shy or just didn't want to tell me, he didn't finish his statement.

"May I ask what points you find attractive about her?"

So, I tried pressing him a step further.

"Eh? Well... how do I put it..."

While looking somewhat embarrassed, Yoshida continued his words.

"It's like, that mysterious part of her, y'know, it's what's so great about her."

Mysterious. It was safe to say that Yoshida's description was an accurate assessment.

I also felt something elusive in Shiraishi's way of thinking.

And hearing Shimazaki now declare that Shiraishi's '100-hundred man slayer' moniker was a lie was a factor that contributed to that feeling.

"Mysterious, huh. I sort of get what you mean, but when it comes to being mysterious, don't you think Morishita might be on a higher level?"

When I asked if she was a romantic interest in the same way, Yoshida's eyes immediately widened in irritation.

"Don't be stupid, Ayanokouji. That thing with Morishita isn't mysterious, she's just an incomprehensible weirdo. You've had eraser dust thrown at you from behind as well, haven't you? That's the work of a little devil, don't you ever lump her in with Shiraishi. Shiraishi is full of kindness."

Yoshida also seemed to have been a victim in the past, based on the "as well" and the strong tone he was speaking in.

Perhaps he'd been observing things during self-study, as it seemed he'd clearly witnessed that moment.

"My apologies. Please allow me to offer a sincere apology for that."

I immediately reflected on the fact that I shouldn't have treated her as being in the same category as Morishita.

"...As long as you get it. Hold on, don't tell me you, of all people, are into Morishita?"

"Why would you think that?"

"Well, I thought it was weird when she said she wanted you in the seat in front of her. Plus, she never hangs out with anyone, but she talks to you an awful lot. She'd be cute if she didn't talk, right? It's a rare case where her internal evaluation cancels out her external one."

Although, it was doubtful whether it merely ended at canceling each other out.

That said, it was probably best to stop messing with him so carelessly any further.

After all, she probably wouldn't feel good knowing she was being talked about so freely like this.

"Unfortunately, that's not it. If anything, she should be wary of me. She's the one who's most suspicious about whether I truly intend to help the class."

It could be said that she was the furthest thing from being a potential romantic interest.

"So that's why she's keeping you close, huh. What you said was true, then."

"I struggle every day with her behind me, saying all sorts of things to me."

The expression 'possessed by something evil' might have been a perfect fit.

"I see. At this rate, it doesn't seem like Morishita will become a romantic interest for you. I mean, it'd take a real weirdo for that to happen anyway. Besides, you don't need to bother with someone like Morishita, you're popular with the girls anyway... Honestly, I'm super jealous."

"Am I popular?"

"Don't say it in such a goddamn irritating way. You're good-looking, and on top of that, you're smarter and more athletic than Shimazaki. And then you even transferred from Class A to Class C and became the leader, you know? A normal girl wouldn't just leave you alone, would she?"

That's what it meant to be popular. Apparently, that was how I looked to those around me.

A coward who betrayed his class and hid his true abilities.

I had been doing nothing but things that would make me disliked by boys and girls alike, but for the Class C students who had become my allies, that impression seemed to have faded.

"I wanna go out with Shiraishi!"

He seemed unable to hold back his emotions any longer, and his feelings exploded in a loud voice.

"What if Shiraishi heard you from behind—"

"What, no way!?"

Yoshida threw his open umbrella aside and jumped.

He even dropped his book, but I caught it just before it hit the ground.

"—what would you do, is what I was going to ask."

"What kind of feint was that!? I'm getting soaked!"

He hurriedly picked up the umbrella, but his entire hoodie was instantly dotted with raindrops.

"Well, it'll dry soon enough."

"Easy for you to say...!"

I handed him the book and started walking again.

Yoshida's expression changed constantly, showing his every emotion without reservation.

The common thread in all of it was 'romantic feelings.'

It was an undeniable fact, acknowledged by himself and others, that the Yoshida in front of me was genuinely 'in love' with Shiraishi. On the other hand, I still didn't fundamentally understand that emotion.

I dated Karuizawa to learn about 'romantic feelings,' but we broke up and I still wasn't able to understand them.

All I learned was the form of a romantic relationship between a boy and a girl, but I was unable to analyze it as an emotion.

Falling in love with someone.

Coming to hate someone.

In the truest sense, I still knew nothing.

If not for my goal of bringing balance to the four classes, I could've pursued that for another year.

I might have been able to view Karuizawa with romantic feelings.

But it was too late for that. A meaningless fantasy now.

Watching Yoshida speak so earnestly, I decided to simply say what was on my mind.

"You said you envy me, but I'm the one who envies you, Yoshida."

"Huh? Me? Why?"

"You can honestly say that you're in love with Shiraishi. Rather, I'm honestly envious that you're able to feel that way, Yoshida."

Yoshida naturally surrendered himself to a problem that couldn't be expressed with a formula.

"N-no, it's not like I like her—cut it out... It's just a one-sided, pathetic crush, right?"

He tried to deny it again, but perhaps realizing it was futile, he sighed once before continuing.

"There's nothing to envy. You're being sarcastic, aren't you?"

I wondered if the slight anger he showed, even as he laughed, was genuine.

However, I, for my part, was also speaking honestly.

"It's not sarcasm. I still don't understand romantic feelings. To genuinely fall in love with someone, to want that love to succeed, to not want to be rejected, to not want to be hated. Or conversely, to come to hate someone, to want to break up with them—I don't understand those positive and negative emotions."

"What the hell? You don't sound like you're messing around... but... I mean, you were actually dating Karuizawa, right? And for a pretty long time, too, wasn't it?"

Yoshida confronted me with an undeniable fact.

"...It's fine. Just forget it."

Even if I put my feelings into words, he wouldn't be able to understand.

To Yoshida, I was someone who dated Karuizawa.

It was only natural for him to conclude I experienced all the emotions that came with romance.

However, seeing my words and attitude, it seemed he sensed something, even if he didn't fully understand the reason.

"...Well, I'll drop it, since it'd be rude to push it any further."

After saying that and pausing for a moment, Yoshida peered at me and asked a question, as if there was still something he wanted to confirm.

"So, you don't have anyone you like right now?"

"I don't."

"I see. So there are guys like that, huh."

"That's why I'm envious. Being able to fall for someone for real."

"...Hope you find someone you can really fall for, too."

A member of the opposite sex one could truly love.

My romantic experience with Karuizawa, and my relationship with Ichinose that others couldn't understand—it was certain that I was, perhaps, getting close.

Thinking the other person was cute, thinking they were beautiful.

Physical contact with the opposite sex and my heart rate rising.

I'd gone through those kinds of experiences to some extent.

However, romantic feelings still hadn't sprouted within me.

Or perhaps I simply hadn't noticed, and had in fact already experienced it?

Our pleasant chat as we both gazed at the rain came to a lull.

"Let's just head back for now, Ayanokouji. Looks like the rain's gonna get stronger after this."

That was what I'd just said... but I decided to refrain from making a tactless jab.

We began to walk forward again.

Although it was for a short time, I was able to get a general grasp of their personalities from talking with Yoshida and Shimazaki.

For better or worse, they were straightforward and the type to say what was on their minds.

Yoshida was stricter on the surface but quite caring underneath, while Shimazaki was a person who could interact with classmates and friends from an appropriate distance without getting too close or being biased; I also managed to obtain information about their romantic troubles.

It seemed safe to conclude that my analysis of them as classmates was complete enough.

Both of them were indispensable to the class, and they would continue to function as useful students; if they ever ran into trouble, I would have to support and protect them.

We walked silently through the strengthening rain and returned to the dorms —

Chapter 2:
A Gentle Exam

IT WAS A Thursday, past the middle of May.

Some of the students who had become third-years were tackling their studies earnestly, at a pace unlike last year. Shimazaki, who I had gone to the bookstore with the other day, was one of them.

There was nothing surprising about it. It was the time of year when they began to seriously consider their desired schools and fields of study.

There were many other things to do besides studying. It would also be important to order college brochures and gather information for open campus events.

Normally, the opportunities for students at this school to go off-campus were limited, but third-years were permitted to visit open campuses during summer vacation, provided they applied. There, it became possible to attend mock classes, entrance exam information sessions, individual consultations, and hands-on events. To see and feel firsthand the atmosphere and compatibility that brochures and websites couldn't convey was surely a very important factor.

This wasn't limited to higher education; it was much the same for those who wished to find employment.

As summer approached, they'd to begin preparing to enter the workforce from various angles, with things like company information sessions, workplace tours, and internships. Most students would decide between further education or employment, but some exceptions existed.

For example, there were cases where their futures had already been decided by various factors.

It might have been unofficially decided that they would join a company run by their family or relatives, or they may have chosen to become a freelancer without pursuing further education or employment.

Or perhaps there were also those who couldn't choose either path yet, putting off their decision until the very last minute.

The one thing that could be said for all of them was that they were simply busier than they'd been in the past two years.

"Have you gotten used to the class environment yet?"

Morishita, who sat behind me, whispered as homeroom progressed.

"More or less."

"More or less, is it? If you're acting tough, you can be honest with me, you know?"

"I'm not acting tough."

"Really? Perhaps you ought to think of me as a priest and confess the painful secrets of your heart?"

I wasn't acting tough in the slightest, but I wondered why she was so concerned.

"Could it be that you're worried about me...?"

Her words were so unexpected that I slightly turned around.

Was her sudden asking without any warning her own way of showing concern?

"That's right. I was thinking I'd have a good laugh at your expense if you'd said you hadn't fit in."

"That's not 'that's right' at all. You don't seem worried in the slightest."

Apparently, she just wanted to make fun of me.

I never thought I would end up regretting even the simple act of turning around.

"Oh? Did you want me to be worried about you?"

"Not at all."

I answered from the bottom of my heart, but Morishita, far from believing me, only grew more suspicious.

"Aww, so stubborn. This is why people whose names start with 'A', end with 'Ka', and are ten hiragana characters long are just hopeless. It's no wonder the statistics show as much."

It was a rare case that seemed to hit on an incredibly specific person.

We were in the middle of homeroom, after all; it would be best not to engage with her any further.

"Did you just think it would be better not to engage with me?"

"I won't deny it."

I decided to forget about the student behind me and turn back to the front.

"—It has been decided that a new exam will begin tomorrow."

Mashima-sensei said just as homeroom was about to end.

My classmates wore somewhat dubious expressions on their faces.

They seemed to feel that something was off about the suddenness of 'tomorrow' and the timing of his announcement with only a minute or two left in homeroom. Normally, things that tended to require long explanations, like special exams, were discussed when there was plenty of time.

Did he intend to continue his explanation even if it cut into our break time?

No, in the first place... was Mashima-sensei's current way of speaking, his phrasing, just a coincidence?

Although a certain turn of phrase caught my attention, I first waited for the teacher to continue.

"The reward will be a change in Class Points: plus 50 points for the first-place class, plus 20 points for second place, no change for third place, and minus 25 points for fourth place. The details, including what will happen to the rewards in the unlikely event of a tie, will be announced in one week. Until then, try to conduct yourselves as befitting of students. And this time, I will not be taking any questions whatsoever."

He finished his explanation with just that, without displaying any rules or rewards on the monitor.

That was all. Just as he added the last part, the chime sounded.

And then, without truly accepting any questions about the exam's details or anything else, the teacher left the classroom.

Though it was brief, it was a memorable explanation that left me with a few lingering questions.

The wording could be taken in two ways, the remark about student-like conduct. And then—

The class fell silent for a moment, but Hashimoto pulled back his chair and stood up.

"Looks like this school just loves to dump one troublesome thing after another on us, huh? So, what's the plan, leader? Wanna start the discussion now?"

Hashimoto said, as he turned to look at me, intending to get the discussion started.

"If possible, I'd like to hear my classmates' opinions first. After that, I'll organize the information and then give my own thoughts."

When I said that to the whole class, Hashimoto gave a small laugh.

"Whoops, my bad. I didn't mean anything weird by that laugh. It's just, I was thinking this is the complete opposite of how it was when Sakayanagi was our leader. Our former leader often made decisions on her own without asking for anyone's input, you know."

Sakayanagi was the type to figure out the essence of things all on her own. No, in that sense, I was the same as her, but as luck would have it, I was currently in the middle of gathering information on the class as well.

I wanted to hear what kind of statements the students would make during the discussion.

A brief silence fell over the room, but Sanada soon spoke up.

"For sensei to not mention any details about the exam at all is, of course, a first. The only things revealed were the rewards and that it starts after one week —"

As he brought up Mashima-sensei's words again, Tamiya raised her hand as if to chime in.

Barely five seconds passed since the discussion began. With just a few words spoken, things were set in motion.

"Wait. I thought the week starting tomorrow was the exam period."

Among the scant information we'd been given, it quickly became apparent that there were people who interpreted the exam differently.

"I agree with Tamiya. I took it to mean the exam period starts tomorrow, and the results will be announced in a week."

The next to speak in agreement was Shimizu. He joined the discussion without hesitation.

"Really? Didn't Mashima-sensei say the details would be announced in a week? If that's the case, wouldn't it be more natural to think of the week starting tomorrow as a preparation period for it?"

Immediately after, Motodoi raised her hand and refuted Shimizu, adding her reasoning.

In Mashima-sensei's statement, there were two phrases that seemed related to the exam period: "It has been decided that a new exam will begin tomorrow," and "The details will be announced in one week."

If one took the former literally, the exam would begin tomorrow.

Conversely, if one took only the latter literally, we would be told the details in a week, and the exam would take place then.

It was an expression that could be interpreted in subtly different ways depending on the listener.

"...I see. You're right, what Mashima-sensei said earlier does seem like it could be taken either way. Alright then, let's start by getting a quick poll of everyone's opinions. For those who had a clear interpretation of sensei's words, could you please raise your hand? Who thinks that starting tomorrow is a preparation period, and the special exam will be held in one week?"

Sanada efficiently called for a show of hands. Nineteen students, more than half the class, raised their hands.

"Next, who thought that the special exam period starts tomorrow, and the details and results will be announced in a week?"

This time, it was fewer than before, with twelve people.

The students who hadn't raised their hands for either option were likely either undecided or simply didn't want to answer. Since this wasn't something to be decided by a majority vote, Sanada didn't press the issue.

Next, Shimazaki lightly raised his hand. He was one of the students who believed the time from tomorrow was a preparation period for the exam.

"What's certain at this point is that, either way, the rules probably aren't that complex. The lack of explanation supports that, and the rewards aren't that big. Since the school is the one judging, it means we'll be made to compete in some visible way. If we're thinking in really simple terms, something like test scores. He also mentioned 'student-like behavior,' which I took to mean studying, the fundamental duty of a student."

It seemed Shimazaki had listened carefully to Mashima-sensei's words, as he'd apparently picked up on and focused on the 'student-like behavior' part.

"Another test? You're kidding me, back-to-back?"

Hashimoto voiced his skepticism. Shimazaki was considering the possibility of competing based on simple class averages or total scores, rather than something with special rules like the "Comprehensive Academic Ability Exam' from a little while ago, but Hashimoto seemed to doubt whether the school would really make them compete with written tests back-to-back.

"It does feel a bit weird to think of them being back-to-back, but on the other hand, it seems totally plausible, don't you think? If you interpret it to mean that studying isn't something you do because you're told, but something you're

supposed to do on your own, then the lack of rules makes sense. The possibility of competing via a pop quiz... yeah, I could see that."

Tsukaji, a female student who'd been listening next to Shimazaki, also nodded as if in agreement.

If a test were to be held suddenly in one week, that was certainly a strong possibility.

However, the term 'pop quiz' was also something of a contradiction.

Inherently, a pop quiz was only meaningful because it came without any warning or prior sign.

Once it'd been announced that an exam would take place, its effectiveness as a pop quiz was diminished.

However, that didn't mean one could definitively conclude that a written exam would not be held, which was what made it difficult.

With no information disclosed about which subjects were on it or their difficulty, the students were forced to either study a broad range, narrow the scope on their own, or pick and choose subjects. If that were the case, academic ability alone would not necessarily determine the winner, because if their luck-based predictions were to hit the mark, even Ryuuen's class, with its lower overall academic ability, would have a slim chance of victory.

Although opinions were split between the two sides, not a single person tried to forcefully push the view they supported. The only thing they all had in common was the desire to "win."

That was precisely why they were all contributing their raw opinions, so that they would have no regrets.

Since it was impossible to definitively determine which interpretation was correct at this stage, the discussion continued. I had to genuinely appreciate their proactive attitude as they tried to move forward by breaking down Mashima-sensei's brief explanation as much as possible.

This exam, devoid of any explanation of the rules, contained a clear intent, regardless of its content.

That intent was to see how long they could maintain a state of tension.

People could brace themselves and be highly vigilant against a visible danger.

People could move forward with a clear objective, but it wasn't easy to work toward a vague, undefined goal; it was just that difficult to maintain a state of

tension for so long. In addition to not knowing whether the exam would take place *over* a week or *in* a week, even its content remained unknown.

That was why people tried to establish a 'provisional' goal, and in fact, they had to.

What was being discussed was the creation of a guidepost to move forward without getting stuck.

Just having this discussion would be a good opportunity for growth for those involved.

"I get what you're trying to say, but our approach will be completely different depending on whether we prepare for this week or for a week from now. We should just commit and steer in one direction."

With about half of the break left, Shimazaki, who disliked that the discussion was going nowhere, made that proposal to decide on a course of action.

"What do you think, Ayanokouji? It's about time you gave us an answer."

Thinking this was the leader's time to step up, Shimazaki asked me for the class's direction on behalf of everyone.

"My opinion is mostly the same as the ones already brought up. The fact that the school deliberately didn't explain the rules this time means it must be something that can be understood and established without explanation. Also, considering the short one-week period, the written exams and sports tests that have been discussed so far as extensions of our classes are naturally candidates."

"So, you're saying you think the same as me... that the special exam will be held a week from now?"

"No, I'm just not ruling out the possibility. It's entirely possible an exam could start covertly tomorrow. For example, the exam might be to present the conclusion we reached in this discussion."

I answered as if retracing everyone's discussion, while also mixing in my own opinion.

"...What we prepared for. You mean the school will check that a week from now?"

"Yeah. One class crammed for a test. One class predicted it would be physical and acted accordingly. One class came up with an answer that combined both. This could be the basis for judgment."

"I see...?"

That said, no student was about to confidently give their seal of approval to that idea. What was important was to broaden their perspective and to keep in mind that there were numerous, albeit finite, options.

"A lot of different opinions have been thrown around, but one that I feel is a strong possibility is that our 'attitude in daily life' will be observed for the next week, starting tomorrow."

There were various initiatives in daily life. Delinquency Prevention Week, Disaster Prevention Week, Reading Week, Greeting Campaign Month, Traffic Safety Month, Compassion Month. I could list more if I tried.

"Attitude in daily life...? That's an opinion I hadn't even considered..."

Sanada, who'd been quiet since the beginning of the discussion, muttered with a hand on his chin, a hint of surprise in his voice.

He seemed to have doubts about this opinion being raised as a strong possibility.

"So, you're saying they'd do something similar to what happened in our first year?"

"That's right. That time, the period was one month, but we weren't even notified beforehand that it was an exam. As a result, the former Class D that I was in suffered a major defeat, losing all of its Class Points, but—this time, I think they're trying to test whether all four classes can live upstanding and proper school lives on the assumption they've figured it out. Even if our daily attitudes are unrelated to this exam, there's great significance in just keeping this in the back of our minds."

"I see. Our attitude is just our daily behavior; it doesn't require us to be tied down to just that. It's a given that we should take classes seriously, avoid being late or absent as much as possible, and be prudent in our actions before and after school."

Since it wasn't something that would take up extra time, there was no harm in keeping it as a candidate.

"Still, if all the classes are careful about their attitudes and prepare for that, the judging criteria will become extremely strict. We'll be required to act as role models not just on campus, but outside as well, all the way to Keyaki Mall and our routes to and from school."

The difference between victory and defeat might come down to a truly trivial matter. Walking past a single piece of trash on the ground without picking it up.

Even something like that could lead to a one-point deduction and, consequently, defeat.

"I, uh, also kind of thought there might be an exam about our private lives. I interpreted the teacher's words, 'try to act like a student,' that way."

Nishi also answered somewhat reservedly, as if to agree with my statement.

Several students who had the same idea but hadn't voiced it nodded in agreement. However, there was still some information lacking to be certain of this.

For now, I deliberately didn't touch on Mashima-sensei's words, which no one else pointed out.

It was the fact that he had only said 'exam,' not 'special exam.' The month-long observation of their daily attitudes conducted behind the scenes after enrollment hadn't been under the framework of a special exam, either.

Chabashira-sensei also had a history of omitting the 'special' part when she spoke about the first-year sports festival.

However, I couldn't deny the possibility that it was a simple slip of the tongue, so I thought it wouldn't be too late to act after gathering more information first.

"There's no need to be certain. Or rather, it doesn't change the fact that we should spend the next week operating on the premise that some kind of exam will be held. This is just a proposal to add this to our considerations."

Shimazaki also accepted the possibility of an exam based on their attitude in daily life without denying it.

"If it were something that took up our time, we'd have to choose carefully, but our private lives are an inseparable part of us. It doesn't take much extra effort in and of itself.—I agree with that."

It was something that would have no adverse effects, even if their understanding of the exam was split in two.

And as something everyone could work on equally, all of them readily showed their approval.

Part 1

ON THE LUNCH break of the day the exam was announced without any rules explained, just as I pulled out my chair to stand up, Shiraishi, who sat next to me, spoke.

"Ayanokouji-kun. Would you mind if I took a moment of your time?"

"I don't mind. What's up?"

"If you'd like, would you care to have lunch with me in the cafeteria today?"

An unexpected invitation from my neighbor. As if he'd been eavesdropping on Shiraishi's words, Yoshida, who was sitting a short distance away, spun around and jogged over to us.

"Hey, let's grab a bite to eat, Ayanokouji!"

It was a completely transparent, fake attempt to make it seem like he was the one inviting me all along.

However, his expression conveyed at least the determined spirit of someone aiming for the Best Supporting Actor award.

Shiraishi looked on fondly at the transparent Yoshida, her eyes narrowed.

In this situation, there was probably only one course of action I could take.

"What a coincidence to get two invitations at once. Is it alright if Yoshida joins us?"

If it was about something personal or exam-related, we might need to speak privately, so I decided to check.

"Of course, that's fine. It's not like I was planning on having any particularly difficult discussions. In that case, may I have Nishikawa-san join us as well? I thought it might be more fun with more people."

It soon became clear that it was just a simple invitation to a meal, so I had no reason to refuse either.

"Is that okay with you too, Yoshida?"

"What, Shiraishi and her group are coming too? Well, I guess that's fine."

This, too, was a transparent act, and he couldn't hide his happiness completely. If anything, his desperate attempt to put on a deadpan expression backfired, a grin leaking out, making him very easy to read.

Such a transparent guy, Yoshida must have been irresistibly amusing to Shiraishi—perhaps even cute? She watched him the whole time with a warm smile.

"Morishita-san, would you care to join us as well?"

Just as Nishikawa approached and a small circle formed, Shiraishi turned her gaze behind me.

"I'm quite alright, cock-a-doodle-doo."

Seemingly having no intention of joining the four of us, Morishita refused with that strange turn of phrase.

Hashimoto glanced my way, but perhaps having heard it was just a normal meal, he made no move to join us and walked toward the hallway alone.

Since the exam was just announced, he was probably making a move to gather information and scout things out, trying to use his time effectively in his own way. After that, Morishita also left the classroom by herself.

"Unfortunately, it seems we've been turned down."

"Don't worry about someone like Morishita. Come on, let's go."

Yoshida said to Shiraishi, his eyes turning toward the classroom exit.

"Wait a minute. There's someone else I want to invite, is that alright?"

"Someone else? Ah, you mean Hashimoto?"

"No, Hashimoto already left the classroom."

"Oh, is that right? He's usually the one talking to you. Then who is it?"

I turned my gaze to the back of a certain student who was still sitting in their chair.

The other three followed my line of sight, understood who it was I wanted to talk to, and were surprised.

"Seriously?"

"Dead serious."

After making a grim face, Yoshida looked over at Shiraishi and the others.

"...Are you sure, Shiraishi? If we mix *him* in, things could get ugly."

Fearing it would not be an enjoyable meal, he left the decision up to her.

"Fufufu. Doesn't that sound interesting? I'm all for it."

To Yoshida, who hoped she would refuse, Shiraishi gave her smiling permission to welcome him. Yoshida seemed bewildered by this, but Nishikawa also enthusiastically agreed.

"Sounds like fun. I'm in, too."

"Geez, girls are so gutsy when it comes to this kind of stuff..."

Or perhaps, they were simply enjoying seeing Yoshida flustered.

Watching the smiles on Shiraishi and Nishikawa's faces, I couldn't help but think so.

In any case, I was glad to have received permission. After getting the okay from the two girls, I made my way to that person's desk—Kitou.

Part 2

THE FIVE OF us went to the cafeteria, bought tickets from the vending machines, placed our orders, and after we all received our food, we found an open corner table in the back and sat down.

Yoshida was on my right, and Kitou was on my left. Shiraishi sat across from me. And Nishikawa was in front of Yoshida. I'd actually intended to have Yoshida and Shiraishi sit across from each other, but whether out of reservation or shyness, I didn't know. Still, he avoided it.

He probably thought he was acting naturally, but it seemed Shiraishi and Nishikawa picked up on my intentions and the meaning behind Yoshida's actions. Nishikawa, in particular, was grinning with amusement, not even attempting to hide it.

"Whoa...it's Ayanokouji..."

I heard a voice nearby, and when I looked, I saw Ike and Hondou holding trays and looking our way. It seemed they'd planned to sit in this area since it was empty, but after spotting me, they chose to steer clear and walked away.

"Looks like you've become quite hated, Ayanokouji-kun."

"That can't be helped. From their point of view, I'm a complete traitor."

That was right. If I'd been the one avoiding Ike and the others, it would have been a gross overestimation of my own importance, but the reverse was a normal reaction. Anyone who talked to me in a friendly manner would likely be given strange looks.

"The special exam's about to start, so maybe they don't want to carelessly give away any information?"

"Something like that, probably."

As I listened to Nishikawa and Yoshida's exchange, a similar thought ran through my own mind.

To be honest, I wanted them to have at least that much of a defensive mindset, and if I were to ask for more, I would have wanted them to set aside their personal feelings and sit near an opponent they hated to steal information. Just by having Ike and the others sit nearby, the five of us would be unable to make any careless remarks, and it would simultaneously serve as a form of harassment toward me.

However, Ike and the others showed no such inclination; it was merely a coincidence that they almost took a table near us.

They didn't turn back, and it seemed the two of them had settled at a table far away.

"Oh, right, right. There was something I wanted to talk about. Have you guys seen this month's OAA yet?"

Despite the encounter with my former classmates, Yoshida changed the subject with that question, posing it to everyone at the table.

"No, I haven't yet. Was there something different written on it?"

Nishikawa and I both shook our heads, and Kitou didn't even react.

After confirming that no one had seen it, Yoshida grinned and pointed at me.

"It's this guy's... Ayanokouji's OAA."

He then took out his phone and showed the screen to Nishikawa and Shiraishi.

After that, he turned the screen toward me as well.

Ayanokouji Kiyotaka OAA
Academic Ability A+ (96)
Physical Ability A (81)
Adaptability B (66)
Social Contribution B+ (77)
Overall B+ (80)

Apparently, it was my OAA, displaying the school's latest evaluation.

"Is there something wrong with this?"

"It's not 'what's wrong with this?'! Just look at this overall score. This B+ is top-class among the third-years, top-class! It's proof that your class transfer and the process and results of the last special exam majorly affected your Academic Ability, Adaptability, and Social Contribution, right?"

It was true that I hadn't explicitly held back since transferring to Class C.

I hadn't slacked off on written exams, and I'd tackled assignments in P.E. and other subjects normally. It was probably inevitable that my scores would increase compared to my first and second years.

Regarding the class transfer, depending on one's perspective, it could have negatively impacted my Social Contribution, but it was a rule and system approved by the school, and since I had, of course, transferred legally, it seemed safe to assume that the act itself hadn't significantly affected my evaluation, for better or for worse.

"You're the acting leader of Class C now. Dude, you really were an amazing guy all along."

"You seem awfully happy, Yosshii. Ayanokouji-kun might be amazing, that's for sure, but in the end, it's someone else's grades, isn't it? I'm surprised you can be so happy about something that's not even your own score."

"That's 'cause we're comrades now, you know? Like with famous baseball or soccer players, even if it's got nothing to do with you directly, you still root for them unconditionally like 'awesome, awesome!' because you feel like you're on the same team, right? It's the same kinda thing. That home run the other day and that dramatic comeback goal were electrifying, man. The whole country was celebrating."

Yoshida spoke passionately, but it seemed his fervor wasn't getting through to Nishikawa.

"Is that so? I'm not a fan of sweaty sports like that, so I wouldn't know."

Perhaps fed up with Nishikawa's immediate negativity, Yoshida shifted his gaze to Shiraishi.

"Sh-Shiraishi...? You get what I'm trying to say, right?"

"Yes, of course I do. I am also one of the students who supports Ayanokouji-kun. I am very happy that we were able to welcome such a wonderful talent to our class."

"R-Right? I knew it."

"I'm more jealous than happy, though~. I mean, no matter how you look at it, those are scores anyone would be envious of."

"You're just narrow-minded, Nishikawa."

"I'd call it being realistic, you know? Besides, I think blind faith is a dangerous way of thinking. 'Go with the flow,' 'If everyone crosses on a red light, it's not scary.' Unfortunately for you, I'm not the type to unconditionally root for those kinds of heroes. In fact, I'm the kind of person who gets fed up with one-sided media coverage."

Yoshida's assertion, however, was met with Nishikawa's unabashed negativity.

"You've got a really great personality, you know that."

"Thanks."

In response to Yoshida's undisguised sarcasm, Nishikawa seemed to happily narrow her eyes.

"What are your thoughts, Kitou-kun? Regarding Ayanokouji-kun's OAA."

Shiraishi addressed the boy who'd been silent the whole time, despite having followed them to the cafeteria. Kitou remained perfectly still, his gaze fixed on the lunch he'd chosen, a plate of curry rice.

Would he praise me like Yoshida and Shiraishi, or show disgust and caution like Nishikawa?

It was still easy for me to aim higher given the standard level of this school, and for that very reason, I wanted to grasp in as much detail as possible the effect these fabricated grades had on the class.

If many students thought like Nishikawa and their dissatisfaction was building up, it might become necessary for me to change my pace.

"It's useless, useless. Just a waste of time asking. He'll just say he's not interested and that'll be the end of it."

"I have no interest in other people's OAA ratings."

Kitou answered in a quiet, yet firm voice.

"See?"

"But—"

Kitou's sharp gaze swiftly shot over, glaring piercingly at me.

"...I am interested in the reason why you hid this much ability for two years. And also... why you've started to get serious now."

The OAA was introduced at the beginning of our second year, after Nagumo became student council president.

My stats at that time were certainly mediocre, to say the least.

"Come to think of it, what were Ayanokouji's old OAA stats like? I've looked through all the classes' stats before, but I don't remember at all."

"I don't remember either. Like, I barely even had an impression of you, Ayanokouji-kun. How about you, Asuka?"

"Yes, that's right... I don't recall either."

Apparently, none of the three had any recollection of what my OAA had been.

I didn't answer, instead recalling the data from a year ago in my mind.

Academic Ability C (51)
Physical Ability C+ (60)
Adaptability D+ (37)
Social Contribution C+ (60)
Overall Ability C (51)

They were unmistakably the epitome of mediocrity, with not a single noteworthy point.

That was precisely why my overall growth compared to a year ago was undoubtedly among the top of our grade. It was for no other reason than that I'd been intentionally holding back my abilities, but it was only natural for others to find it strange.

However, it was certainly not something to be proud of.

I wouldn't bring it up here, as it would be a topic about another class—moreover, my former one—but in terms of pure growth, Sudou's OAA was the one truly worth bragging about.

"I imagine your stats were quite average, which is precisely why your current OAA is so compelling. If you demonstrated your current potential from the very beginning, Ayanokouji-kun, Horikita-san's Class A would have surely earned more Class Points by now and been in a higher position. I've digressed a bit, but why did you start to get serious?"

As if intending to let Shiraishi continue her line of questioning, Kitou scooped up a large spoonful of curry and rice and shoveled it into his mouth.

"I don't like to stand out. At first, I wasn't even interested in graduating from Class A. That's why I had no intention of getting heavily involved in the class's ups and downs."

"So you're sayin' your thinking changed before we became third-years? Or after? That's a huge change, if it's true. *If* it's true."

Nishikawa showed strong doubt toward my statement, just like the skepticism she directed at Yoshida.

"I'm aware it's hard to believe, but it's the truth."

"So then, why did someone like you, who doesn't like to stand out and wasn't motivated to be serious, suddenly feel like getting serious?"

"I believe I've already explained this, so it's a bit late to ask. A major factor was that Hashimoto asked me for help, wanting me to do something about the situation where we could no longer win after Sakayanagi left. I decided that if my power could be useful, I wouldn't mind becoming the class leader."

Here, I made sure to re-emphasize that the transfer was Hashimoto's achievement. Hashimoto, who was the subject of great suspicion within the class, had become a figure to be avoided, if anything.

"Hmm. Somethin' about that doesn't add up. You feel that way too, right, Asuka?"

After thinking for a moment, Shiraishi also nodded in agreement.

"Even if your true feelings were a desire to be useful and become the leader, I find it hard to believe that he alone would be enough to make you transfer to a lower-ranked class. If you remained in Class A, you could have led them, Ayanokouji-kun, and things might have proceeded more smoothly, don't you think?"

"Yeah, yeah. There's no need to take a risk and betray your class, is there~."

"Hey, hold on. Don't go blaming Ayanokouji like that. What'll you do if he loses his motivation over this?"

"If he loses his motivation from a little questioning like this, then that's all he's got, right?"

Nishikawa laughed, lightly brushing aside Yoshida's defense.

"Well... but still..."

"It's not that simple. Class A has established Horikita as their leader, and her position is secure. If I suddenly threw my hat in the ring, it would just cause confusion. Besides, if I'm going to be a leader for real, there's no point unless I do something like rebuilding a class from the bottom up."

"...So you're sayin' you wanna get to Class A with your own two hands, even if it's a pain?"

When I answered with a nod, Yoshida nodded back two or three times as if impressed.

"I respect that spirit of yours."

"Are you, like, a glutton for punishment or something? Like, super masochistic? And are you forreal, forreal?"

Nishikawa continued to laugh, but she also kept voicing her lingering doubts without hesitation. My answer probably wouldn't clear up her suspicions here, but it would be better to keep answering her anyway.

However, before I could open my mouth, Yoshida, his expression hardened, spoke up.

"Maybe not all of it, but I think what he's sayin' is true, for the most part."

"The words of Ayanokouji-kun's little follower don't seem to hold much weight~."

"Who're you callin' a follower?!"

"Then should I call you Hashimoto-kun Number 2?"

"Anything but that."

A short, fast rally of words took place, and Nishikawa deftly spun the chopsticks in her right hand.

"So then, what makes you say you think it's true?"

"It's like, you can just tell by lookin' at him. No matter how you slice it, he's a weirdo on the same level as Morishita."

I was grateful that he was defending me, but I was not pleased about being put in the same category as Morishita.

"I haven't been paying attention for a bit, and you've already earned this much of Yosshii's trust, huh~."

"Oh, Nishikawa-san. I also trust Ayanokouji-kun a great deal, you know?"

Shiraishi replied, a mysterious smile on her face just as Yoshida had described.

"Why, why? 'Cause he got results in the special exam? Or... is it a personal preference?"

Nishikawa looked at Yoshida with what could be described as her biggest suggestive smile of the day.

"P-Personal preference...? What the hell is that?"

Yoshida, who took the bait as expected, pressed Nishikawa as he questioned her again.

"You totally know what I mean~. The truth is, you just want Asuka to look at you that way, don't you, Yosshii?"

"W-Well... I mean... n-no, that can't be true!"

During my recent exchange with Shimazaki, the idea that the story of her "100-man slayer" title was a lie had come up.

However, I had to remember that it was strictly Shimazaki's opinion.

In fact, he'd warned me afterward not to tell anyone about his denial.

A careless student might have let it slip, but Yoshida didn't show the slightest hint of it, instead framing his words on the premise that the rumor of her "100-man slayer" title was true.

Or perhaps, even while wanting to deny it, he still wasn't completely convinced by Shimazaki's statement.

"I'm still holding on to my theory that you're an assassin sent by Horikita-san, you know."

Yoshida's expression stiffened even more at Nishikawa, who continued to make such blunt remarks.

"Knock it off, Nishikawa."

"Why? You want me to place my complete trust in him like you, Yosshii? I'm not that easy of a girl, you know."

"Complete trust? Don't be ridiculous. Such a relationship doesn't exist between us in Class C and Ayanokouji yet. We're still in the process of feeling each other out."

"Hmm? And yet, you no longer doubt Ayanokouji-kun's transfer or his future contributions, do you?"

"That's not it. I'm trying to start from a place of trust. At the very least, Ayanokouji earned that right by getting us through the first special exam, didn't he? Or are you going to say that the right thing to do is to constantly doubt him and keep asking, 'Is he useful? Is he really on our side?'"

No longer bothering to hide his irritation, Yoshida spoke heatedly and forcefully to the frivolously smiling Nishikawa.

"That's a bit too cool for you, Yosshii, but—"

At this, Nishikawa, while still facing Yoshida, glanced over at Shiraishi.

"Yeah, well, maybe that's the right way to think about it. I can't do it right away, but I guess I do hope I can learn to trust Ayanokouji-kun as soon as possible."

Nishikawa, who'd been so openly brandishing her suspicions about me, now took a step back.

"I understand how both of you feel very well. So, how about we take this opportunity to dig a little deeper into each other? While visible achievements like the results of the special exam are important, you can't truly know someone without seeing their private life."

Shiraishi brought her hands together as she made the suggestion.

"That might be a good idea. It's true I still don't really know what kind of person Ayanokouji-kun is."

Perhaps because it was Shiraishi's suggestion, Nishikawa readily agreed.

"Since we're having lunch together like this, let's reintroduce ourselves."

The irritated Yoshida had no choice but to accept Shiraishi's proposal... no, the corners of his eyes were already drooping with delight.

"Well then, I shall start. On weekdays, when I'm alone, I usually go straight back to the dorms. When Nishikawa-san or my friends invite me out, I sometimes stop by Keyaki Mall, but that's at most once or twice a week."

Unless they were short on cash, the vast majority of students went home via Keyaki Mall nearly every day. It was the only place where they could enjoy almost every aspect of their private lives, from daily shopping to having fun.

"Asuka, you turn me down quite a lot when I invite you out, don't you~?"

"I'm sorry. If I had to say, I prefer to spend my time alone. But that's precisely why on my days off, I make a point of going out and increasing my opportunities to interact with people. Even so, I tend to take it easy in the morning and get more active in the afternoon. I often go to cafés or general stores."

In order to let us get to know her, Shiraishi shared her behavioral patterns with me in more detail than I expected. As if to match her, Nishikawa also began to speak.

"Okay, my turn~. I guess I'm usually at Keyaki Mall~. I'm there alone a lot, and I go with friends a lot, too~. Like Takanashi-san or Tsukaji-san, you know."

Nishikawa, who began talking cheerfully, continued to speak eloquently even after mentioning her friends' names, going into great detail about what they talked about and what they did.

"Alright, alright. We get it, that's more than enough."

Yoshida, who'd been listening in silence for a while, seemed to have finally reached his limit as her story stretched on for several minutes, and he forcibly cut in to stop her.

Nishikawa looked like she still had plenty more to say, but she reluctantly passed the baton to me.

"Honestly, I don't think I'm that different from any other student. If I had to point out a difference, it would be that I've been showing my face at the gym recently whenever I have free time, regardless of whether it's a weekday or a day off."

"The gym? You mean the one on the second floor? I didn't know any students actually went there."

Nishikawa muttered as if she were looking at something rare.

"Are there any guys from our class who go?"

"Hmm, probably not, don't you think?"

Apparently, no classmates immediately came to mind for Yoshida and the others.

It's not like I go to the gym all that often myself, but I have no memory of any Class C students.

"It's true that it might not be very popular, but there should still be about thirty members from the entire school. I'm sure a few new students will be joining soon, too."

In addition, school staff could also use it, so the total number of members, including adults, was probably around forty to fifty people.

Judging from the gym's floor space and the membership fees, it seemed it would almost certainly be operating at a loss if the rent was appropriate, but it was likely able to stay afloat because the school provided generous subsidies.

"Does anyone want to join the gym?"

"Ugh, that was a terrible pitch, Ayanokouji..."

"A sudden invitation in the middle of this conversation? You've got no taste, you know~?"

Yoshida and Nishikawa looked at me, voicing similar thoughts almost simultaneously.

Just then, Kitou stood up, pulling his chair back a little roughly.

He'd apparently finished his curry, and he then picked up his tray.

"...I'm going back to the classroom."

Leaving only those words behind, he departed from the group.

"In the end, he barely participated in the conversation... Seriously, why'd he even agree to eat with us?"

"Who knows? It's hard to tell what Kitou-kun's thinking. And his face is scary."

I wouldn't go so far as to say Nishikawa was wrong for just blurting out what she thought, but wasn't that last part definitely an unnecessary comment?

In any case, it seemed the distance with Kitou was not going to be easily closed after all.

After that, I continued to eat while I considered what to do after school.

I'd been thinking about stopping by the library soon, but as luck would have it, the exam had been announced today. Since I still lacked the information to narrow down the rules, I wanted to devote my time after school to that.

Tomorrow—I would make time.

I was sure I'd be able to talk with Hiyori more leisurely that way, too.

Chapter 3:
Getting to Know the Opponent

THE STUDENTS OF Class A looked at each other as the bell signaling the end of morning homeroom rang.

It was the announcement of an unheralded special exam, something that had become a regular occurrence, but this time they couldn't hide their bewilderment at the slightly different development.

"W-wait, even if you say that's all, that's not nearly enough of an explanation!"

Ike-kun hastily called out to stop Chabashira-sensei, who'd moved to the door to leave the classroom.

"I told you, didn't I? I will not be accepting any questions this time."

"Yeah, but—!"

With a conspicuous sigh, Chabashira-sensei turned only her head and looked at Ike-kun.

"I'm not being intentionally cold. It's simply a rule that we teachers cannot elaborate on the specific rules of this exam."

Her harsh tone made the expressions of the classmates, including Ike-kun, stiffen even more.

"I want you to stop acting so spoiled and show me you've grown. I'd like you to make me think you're different from when you first enrolled."

Chabashira-sensei declared, as if to drive the point home.

The fact that it wasn't harassment and that she never intended to spend time explaining the rules from the start was something we were supposed to infer from the unnatural timing of the announcement, right before the end of homeroom.

She swung the classroom door wide and left without fuss.

Even after the door slammed shut, the classroom didn't fall silent; rather, the teacher's departure only made it grow noisier.

"She seriously left. How're we supposed to take this on without even hearing the rules?"

"She said she wasn't being intentionally cold, but wasn't she kinda cold?"

"Yeah, she was super cold. Could it be because we lost the last special exam?"

"We did our best, though."

The classmates continued to grumble and complain as they pleased.

"I get why you wanna say that, but calm down, will ya? Kickin' up a fuss ain't gonna tell us the rules."

Perhaps to signal ‘you’re being loud’, Sudou-kun stuck his pinky into his left ear as he chided the restless students.

"Sudou-kun is right. The lack of a rules explanation isn't something to get so worked up about. The other classes are fighting under the same conditions, so there's no advantage or disadvantage at this stage."

In concert with Sudou-kun's strong, resonant voice, Hirata-kun also said as much to soothe the students.

"That's easy for you to say, but we can't do anything if we don't know the rules. Wouldn't it be better to just go in blind a week from now?"

"I think that would've been better, too. This feels like we're just being strung along."

Shinohara-san strongly agreed with the unceasingly complaining Ike-kun.

I could understand what they wanted to say, but the special exam had now been announced.

In that case, all we could do was face it seriously.

To begin with, it was a mistake to assume there were no hints before even thinking about it.

I couldn't just stand by and watch until things got out of hand, so I decided to speak up.

"The special exam doesn't start until tomorrow, so just panicking here is a waste of time. First, we should calm down, brainstorm ideas, and discuss things."

"You say 'ideas,' but what can we do if the rules haven't been explained?"

Here, Hondou-kun, looking exasperated, stared at the large, powered-off monitor that served as a blackboard, re-emphasizing that things were different from usual.

"If we pool our wisdom, it's possible we can get closer to the rules. We just need to imagine what kind of special exam will be held and prepare our options."

"Yeah, well, maybe you're right, but can we really overlook our teacher's attitude? I'm talkin' about how cold she was, you know?"

Shinohara-san seemed to have really disliked Chabashira-sensei's response, as she continued to fixate on that point.

And several other students agreed with her.

I really didn't think it should take priority over the content of the special exam, but...

It was true that Chabashira-sensei had become much softer in her demeanor compared to before. In fact, during the second half of our second year, the frequency with which she showed us a smile increased to the point where she was almost unrecognizable from her former self.

Now in our third year, Ayanokouji-kun transferred, and our teacher was hurt, too.

Sometimes that showed in her attitude. But wasn't that proof that she felt Class A would be forced into a difficult situation from now on...?

...or perhaps she was limiting unnecessary kindness and smiles to a minimum, as a way to make us refocus.

Above all, demanding kindness for free, for whatever reason, was simply out of line.

That was how I took it, but they didn't.

The frustrated gazes of some students were directed at me, Hirata-kun, and even Sudou-kun.

Everyone was suffering, burdened with an indescribable frustration.

When I thought about our history, I felt no small amount of resistance to reprimanding them harshly.

I can't forget that everyone in the class was also a victim, caught up in the discord created by Ayanokouji-kun's departure.

In the end, no satisfactory discussion took place before the first period began, and only time passed.

Part 1

DURING THE BREAKS and lunchtime, I meticulously used that time to speak individually with the anxious students of Class A, requesting a discussion after school and securing their permission.

I wanted to let them blow off some steam, even if just a little, so the students who'd been complaining, led by Ike-kun and Shinohara-san, wouldn't still be agitated when it was time for the after-school discussion.

Sudou-kun said it was an overreaction, but when I saw Chabashira-sensei, who was just as cold as she'd been that morning, I became convinced that I'd done the right thing by acting in advance.

"Horikita. As I told you during the lunch break, you have a matter in the Student Council room in one hour. I don't mind you having a discussion, but don't forget."

"Yes, I understand."

And just as I'd expected, Sensei left the classroom after coming over to me and saying just that, without ever touching on the details of the special exam during the afternoon homeroom. After seeing her off, I made my move. I wanted to avoid a repeat of the morning's complaint session.

As I quickly stepped up to the teacher’s podium, another student began to move.

He was the one person I'd identified as a potential problem but hadn't spoken to.

"That guy..."

Sudou-kun, who muttered quietly nearby, clicked his tongue and turned around.

The student who drew a conspicuous amount of attention, Koenji-kun, stood up from his seat alone and quickly left the classroom.

"Hey, Koenji—"

Sudou-kun immediately called out to him in a reprimanding tone, but he walked away without turning back or even stopping for a moment.

That was normal. He wouldn't interfere with the discussion, but at the same time, he wouldn't cooperate either.

I knew that, so I didn't even try to talk to him before school let out.

I resigned myself to the fact that asking for his cooperation would be more trouble than it was worth and would likely just lead to a fight.

Essentially, Sudou-kun, the only one who called out to him, must have felt the same way.

As if to prove it, he too lost interest in Koenji-kun's disappearing form.

That was fine. We could just start the discussion as usual without him.

The discussion would proceed more smoothly that way, and problems were less likely to arise.

However...

I wondered if it was really alright to keep letting this slide, dismissing it as *normal*.

"Hirata-kun, I'm sorry, but could you get started without me? I'll be right back."

"Yeah, I understand."

I entrusted the room to Hirata-kun, who readily agreed.

Even though I knew it was pointless to plead with him, I hurried out into the hallway to chase after Koenji-kun.

I followed him at a light jog down the hallway, where he was presumably heading for the shoe lockers.

And when I spotted the large back of the person I was after, I quickly closed the distance and fell in step beside him.

"Would you mind waiting a moment?"

I called out, looking up at his tall figure from close by.

"Well, well, Horikita Girl. Is there something I can do for you?"

Koenji-kun glanced at me once, but he didn't so much as turn his head, his face remaining pointed straight toward his destination.

I struggled to match my steps to his long strides as I continued to follow.

"I just want you to at least hear me out."

"I don't mind listening a bit, as long as we're walking."

"That's not it. I want you to return to the classroom right now and listen to the discussion."

It was a modest request.

Koenji-kun didn't react extravagantly, just flashed a smile that showed his white teeth.

"Wouldn't that simply be pointless? My time is quite priceless, you see. Besides, you and I have an established contract. I'm under no obligation to lend you a hand, am I?"

"Yes, I am aware of that. But all I'm asking is for you to listen to the discussion. I'm not asking for your cooperation to win the special exam. I won't even ask you to say anything."

If I were to ask him to use his potential to contribute to our victory, he would obviously refuse. I recognized the fact that he had every right to do so.

"All you have to do is sit there until we're dismissed. It's simple, isn't it?"

"You seem to be making a passionate case, but I'm afraid I don't follow. For what purpose, exactly?"

"It's necessary for the class to unite once again. I don't want you to disrupt that harmony. If even one person breaks the rules, it affects the entire class's morale."

My justification and my appeal. Surely, at least some of it had to have gotten through to Koenji-kun.

The next expression to appear on the profile I'd been staring up at was a scornful laugh.

"Hmph. What a curious thing to say. If the class falls apart simply because I've left, that just goes to show the limits of your own abilities, Horikita Girl."

"This has nothing to do with my abilities. If there's even one student doing as they please, we can hardly be described as 'united,' can we? If even a single piece is missing, the whole thing is incomplete."

"I see. It seems you're capable of a somewhat amusing answer. However, you said 'once again,' but has the class, excluding myself, ever truly been united as one?"

My expression stiffened for a moment at his merciless words, and I stopped in my tracks.

But I knew I couldn't let Koenji-kun walk away with a rebuttal like that, so I immediately resumed walking.

"Saying we've never been united is a bit of an overstatement, don't you think? Over the past two years, while not every time, there have been more than

a few occasions when our class came together as one. That's why we're in Class A now."

We overcame hardships together. It might not have been something to boast about to others, but a fact was a fact.

"You should add 'in your mind' to that."

"And you should add, 'not in yours.'"

Even if it was just a tit-for-tat exchange, I couldn't back down, so I pressed on even if I had to force it.

"Being in Class A is proof of unity? The only reason the class was lucky enough to win was because Ayanokouji-boy was making his moves. Surely you understand that without me having to tell you, don't you?"

"...It's true that Ayanokouji-kun left our class. But we didn't win through his power alone."

"If you truly believe that, then that's quite the comical tale. You talk of unity, of being as one, but aren't you just trying to convince yourself that you can win even without Ayanokouji-boy?"

"That's—"

His merciless words felt like a blade stabbing me in the back.

"There's no point in me returning to the classroom now. No matter how much you struggle, as long as you're the leader, a victory against the other classes is impossible."

He pointed out my lack of ability without sugarcoating it in the slightest.

"I'm... not good enough?"

Ichinose-san, who earned enough trust to unite her class. Ryuuen-kun, who brought his class together through fear and violence. And Sakayanagi-san, who produced results and earned recognition with her exceptional abilities.

Ayanokouji-kun, who'd been accepted by the class in the blink of an eye with his overwhelming ability—

I couldn't deny that there was a difference when I compared them to myself.

"Yes, that might be true. But that doesn't mean it's okay for me to just stand still here, does it? I have to start with what I can do. Precisely in order to strengthen our imperfect unity—"

"I won't deny that, in itself. It is your freedom to do as you please. And, as I have neither reason nor obligation to follow the class's instructions, I am also free to persist in my non-participation."

"You're an excellent student; I know that. But with Ayanokouji-kun now on the enemy's side, our class's position as Class A will be threatened before long. You're fine with that?"

Without his cooperation, we might not be able to graduate from Class A.

I wanted to see if Koenji-kun was prepared for that.

His behavior... So as not to miss any sign that he was acting differently than usual, I focused my gaze from his head to toe.

But even under my testing gaze, Koenji-kun's attitude didn't change at all.

In fact, he just laughed back at me, amused.

"In the end, it seems you're the same."

Without slowing his pace in the slightest, Koenji-kun continued to distance himself from the classroom.

"...The same? What's the same?"

"I speak of this cheap ploy to stoke my sense of crisis and desperately try to make me move."

"...Does that mean someone besides me has already tried to do the same thing?"

Was there anyone in the class now who would blame Koenji-kun for his selfish behavior? Even Sudou-kun would only give him a light warning, and most students avoided even speaking to him. Hirata-kun might have tried to talk to him, but he would never resort to threats.

"Now, who's to say?"

While I was trying to figure it out, I realized we were almost at the school entrance.

"Chasing after me any further is a waste of your time, so I suggest you stop."

"...I'd like to take your advice, but I simply can't."

I would pursue him to the very end.

Until Koenji-kun admitted defeat and said he would return to the classroom.

I certainly felt a new resolve ignite within me, but that flame was extinguished in an instant.

"Advice? What a misguided girl you are. Unfortunately, this isn't advice. It's a warning."

"Hk...!?"

I caught the look from Koenji-kun, and meeting his eyes, I gasped.

It was an irritation from Koenji-kun that he rarely ever showed, tinged with a faint killing intent.

It was a particular glint in his eyes, different from what someone like Ryuuen-kun, who constantly relied on intimidation, would show.

"Are you planning to make an enemy of me too, Horikita-girl?"

He was not an ally, but he was neutral.

This was a warning that if I intended to make him abandon that stance, he would show me no mercy.

"...I have no such intention."

My resolve vanished in an instant, and I stopped. I had no other choice.

Failing to gain his cooperation was one thing, but making an enemy of him was pointless under any circumstances.

He was, for better or for worse, a troublemaker. If he felt like it, he probably wouldn't think twice about letting the class fall apart.

"Good. Well then, I shall be taking my leave."

I felt a gnawing frustration, but ultimately, I was still powerless to stop Koenji-kun from walking away.

Part 2

WITH THE CLASS discussion at a standstill, I left things to Hirata-kun and the others, and hurried to the Student Council room to attend my duties.

I'd hoped to settle on a direction, at the very least, but that wish wasn't granted.

Truthfully, I wanted to discuss it until we were all satisfied...but it couldn't be helped. Having accepted the role of student council president, I had to tackle those responsibilities with the same diligence as the special exam.

When I arrived in front of the Student Council room, Nanase-san was already there and bowed her head.

"Good work, Student Council President Horikita."

"You're quite early."

While exchanging pleasantries, we entered the still-empty Student Council room together. Then, as I took my seat at the president's desk, Nanase-san stood beside me and showed me two printed sheets of paper.

"I just received these materials from Mr. Houjou, the homeroom teacher for Class 1-A."

Each paper contained information on a single student.

One was Kusanagi Minato-kun from Class 1-A. The other was Maki Yuuma-kun from Class 1-D.

"And here is an overview of the incident."

After looking over their profiles, she handed me another sheet of paper.

It wasn't particularly complicated, and a quick glance was all I needed to grasp the contents.

"These two got into a big fight, is that it?"

The date was last Friday, and the location was behind the first-year dormitories.

Maki-kun from Class D called out Kusanagi-kun from Class A, and after a verbal dispute, it escalated into a fight.

Both struck each other multiple times, including blows to the face. Maki-kun's injuries would take about three weeks to heal, Kusanagi-kun's about one. The fight came to light when a third party discovered them as they were

returning from behind the dorms. Fortunately, they've been able to attend school since Monday—

"If it was behind the dorms, then there's no footage of them fighting, right?"

"That's right. It was in a blind spot for the security cameras. It seems a third party who was also returning to the dorms discovered the two injured students as they were about to head back."

Where the cameras are, and where they aren't.

It seems even the first-years, who haven't been here long, are getting a grasp of such things.

"It seems we should ask the school to install more security cameras."

"I agree. I did try to briefly ask Houjou-sensei about it, but he told me to hear the details from the students and didn't elaborate."

"To maintain fairness, I suppose. That's likely the reason they've tossed the judgment of this case over to us in the student council."

Nanase-san, who nodded firmly, seemed to have something on her mind, and began to speak.

"Actually, last year, I was also called to the student council for a similar incident."

"You, Nanase-san? Were you assaulted by someone?"

"No, that's not it. It was a problem caused by a classmate—"

After a slight, wry smile, Nanase-san explained the details.

Before last summer, when Housen Kazuomi-kun of Class D and Utomiya Riku-kun of Class C passed each other in the hallway, a trivial matter led to an argument, and a tense standoff ensued where they glared at each other from point-blank range. Just when it seemed a fight could break out at any moment, students from their respective classes who were nearby started to argue, and a Class C student, having reached their limit, struck a Class D student. Then, riding that momentum, they charged at Housen-kun and tried to punch him, only to be spectacularly countered.

"Just as Utomiya-kun was about to throw a punch, the teachers happened to pass by and the commotion was somehow settled, but afterward, the problem was brought before the student council."

The student Housen-kun had struck, suffered injuries that took about three weeks to heal. However, the Class C student threw the first punch and also hit another student. Deciding who was at fault and how to judge the matter dragged

on, requiring numerous discussions and taking two weeks to resolve. Nanase-san shared all of the details with me.

"Nagumo-senpai must have had a tough time."

"I think so, too."

Though exasperated, I couldn't help but laugh.

"Was it that funny of a story?"

"No, that's not it. It's just that the same kinds of trouble happen everywhere, and I had a similar experience in my first year."

"Is...that so?"

"It was similar to your situation. A classmate of mine got into a fight with one of Ryuuen-kun's classmates."

At that time, my brother was sitting in the very seat I occupied.

Sudou-kun struck a student in the special building and a discussion was held to determine responsibility, such as who threw the first punch. My brother didn't unilaterally take anyone's side, but fulfilled his duty as student council president with an impartial eye. I'm sure Nagumo-senpai did the same last year.

"It's almost become an annual tradition for the new students to cause trouble at least once, and when I imagined it like that, I found it kind of amusing."

"Hearing your story makes it feel more real. I can imagine something similar happening here again next year."

"In that case, it will be your turn to pass judgment as student council president."

"Eh, m-me?"

"If things proceed as they are, that's what will happen. Will you do it?"

"...I hope I'm up to the task... Besides, they say all the past student council presidents have graduated from Class A... and I'm currently in Class D."

Nanase-san answered without much confidence, but she was without a doubt the leading candidate.

"You'd do best not to worry about precedents born from chance. Until now, the student council president could only come from Class A or B, yet here I am, serving in the position despite having started in Class D. And while this is a good example, there's no guarantee that I will even be in Class A at graduation."

The current Class A was also a temporary position.

It was a position we wouldn't have reached without Ayanokouji-kun's help.

"I believe you, at least, are more than qualified to become the student council president. Have some confidence."

"...Thank you very much. For now, I'd like to focus on producing solid results as a secretary."

Though hesitant, Nanase-san accepted my words earnestly, nodding and lowering her head.

"The fact that their fight was brought to the student council is proof that this is a considerable dispute. I'm going to share a few of my thoughts before they arrive. I want you to lend a hand depending on the situation."

One of them was a Class A student. I had the impression that students prone to this kind of violence tended to be concentrated in Class D or Class C, but this time was different. Kusanagi-kun not only had high physical ability of B+, but his academic ability was also a B+. I wanted to consider the possibility that he was quick-witted and take the measures I could.

"Of course."

In the time we had left, I verbally explained a few plans to Nanase-san.

Soon, when the scheduled time came, a dry knock sounded at the student council room door.

"It seems they've arrived. Please, come in."

At Nanase-san's reply, two male students appeared, glaring at each other.

Both had unique hairstyles and an appearance that would make anyone think of them as delinquents.

They showed no signs of remorse whatsoever and seemed to think the other was entirely responsible.

But what caught my eye the most was not their hairstyles or attitudes, but their faces.

"...Those are some... pretty bad injuries."

The injuries were so bad that even Nanase-san couldn't help but comment on them.

The one standing to my left was the first-year Class D student, Maki-kun.

The one standing to my right was the first-year Class A student, Kusanagi-kun.

I'd heard that even minor injuries could be diagnosed as taking two or three weeks to fully heal, but they looked quite battered. They must have really gone

at it, as both of their faces were swollen. Maki-kun's injuries were particularly bad, making it clear who got the upper hand in the fight.

"I assume you both know why you've been summoned to the student council room?"

Nanase-san coaxed them, as if guiding them to explain voluntarily.

"Nah, I got no idea. Why the hell do I gotta get called in here? This guy's the one at fault."

Kusanagi-kun immediately retorted, turning to Maki-kun and baring his teeth.

"Huh? Don't fuck with me! You're the one who threw the first punch!"

"Bullshit! You're the one who came at me first. Well, you missed, though!"

A loud shouting match began over who made the first move and who threw the first punch.

Nanase-san and I exchanged a quick glance and listened to the boys' argument for a while.

We judged that it would be easier later if they blew off some steam first.

At first, they just tried to pin the blame on each other for starting the fight, but it gradually devolved into unnecessary verbal abuse, and eventually escalated to irrelevant topics like height and appearance.

"How childish."

"Childish, indeed."

Even though they were only just first-year high school students, they were starting to cross a line that couldn't be ignored. What's more, they showed no signs of calming down; on the contrary, they looked like they were about to start brawling right there in the student council room.

"That's quite enough noise. I'm going to have to ask you both to be quiet for a moment."

Nanase-san, unable to watch any longer, warned them as such, but they merely glanced at her and didn't stop their tirade.

They were clearly underestimating her because she was a girl. That attitude was plain to see.

But as long as I knew Nanase-san's words reached them, that was enough.

Their complaining was simply a matter of mutual dissatisfaction.

In that case, all I had to do was prepare to hand down a ruling that would be most dissatisfying for them.

I sent a look to Nanase-san.

Our eyes met, and she gave a small nod, having perfectly grasped my intentions.

"If you're going to continue arguing as you please, then this meeting is unnecessary. We may have to impose a heavy penalty on both of you. Is that acceptable?"

As Nanase-san spoke with a cold, dismissive tone, I silently pulled back my chair and stood up.

"Huh? Hold on, there's no way I'm gonna accept that!"

"This ain't got nothing to do with the damn student council, especially not some girl buttin' in!"

"Please use formal language when you speak."

They glared back at my warning, their gazes filled with discontent.

I suppose they think I'll back down because of that.

"This is ANHS, and the student council is vested with a certain amount of authority. This discussion is a precious opportunity to bring the truth to light. If you two insist on trampling all over it, then we have no intention of wasting any more time. Let us compile a report for the teachers, Student Council President."

"Don't you dare end this on your own!"

"You two are quite welcome to leave. Or, if you wish to continue your argument, please do so in the hallway."

Since they only just enrolled, trying to convince them that this wasn't for the good of the class would have no effect.

For those two, the worst-case scenario was that neither of their claims would be accepted. I doubt their cheap pride would allow for that.

But little by little, the two of them began to feel the strange atmosphere in the room.

Since they entered the Student Council Office, I hadn't said a single word to them.

"...Why is the Student Council President just staying quiet? Say something."

I guess because I gave a speech at the entrance ceremony, they do recognize that I'm the student council president.

"You've been watching this whole time, so you get which one of us is in the wrong, don't you?"

Each of them pointed at the other, continuing to insist that they weren't at fault, only the other was.

They'd likely intended to continue until I gave my answer.

But I continued my silence.

I conveyed to them with my silence that the situation was not worth speaking about.

Eventually, my scheme began to bear fruit, and the noisy Student Council Office fell silent.

It was proof they realized they were the only ones making a ruckus.

They still opened their mouths as if to protest, but their words were too quiet for me to hear, and eventually, their lips sealed shut. Both of them, at nearly the same time.

"What are we supposed to do...?"

And then, with a strained voice, he asked for my judgment.

"It seems they have the will to resolve this. What will you do, Student Council President?"

I gave a quiet nod and signaled for Nanase-san to proceed.

"Alright then, first, Kusanagi-kun, would you please tell us your side of the story again? In the meantime, no matter how dissatisfied you may be, Maki-kun, I must ask that you absolutely refrain from speaking. I assure you that you will be given an equal opportunity to speak next. Is that understood?"

Upon hearing Nanase-san's admonition, Maki-kun bit his lip hard and gave a slight nod.

"This guy... Maki was givin' me a nasty look. So when I asked him what his problem was, he just suddenly snapped. After that, he called me out to the back of the dorms. I wasn't gonna back down, so I went, and he immediately came at me swinging. Well, I had a hunch I was stronger, y'know, so I dodged it easily and fed him a counter."

One side of the story. Of course, for Maki-kun, who had to listen, it probably wasn't a story he could accept.

He tried to speak, not hiding his irritation, but his eyes met mine and he stopped himself just in time.

There was a risk that if he interrupted, he would be unilaterally branded the bad guy.

If he stayed quiet, he would be given a chance to explain himself.

It seemed he had instinctively sensed that this was how the proceedings worked.

For a while after that, Kusanagi-kun continued his complaint that Maki-kun was entirely at fault, and when we determined that no further testimony would be forthcoming, we passed the turn to the long-suffering Maki-kun.

"He can just run his mouth all he wants. This guy conveniently left out everything that makes him look bad. In the first place, it's 'cause that bastard Kusanagi called me 'defective' or whatever! I just wanted to make him take it back! And a 'hunch'? No way, I was clearly the stronger one! You think I didn't notice your legs trembling when you took that shot to the gut?"

He yelled near Kusanagi-kun's ear, his voice carrying all the irritation he'd been bottling up.

Looking slightly uncomfortable at Maki-kun's words, he feigned ignorance, turning to look off in another direction to ignore him.

Defective goods. Now that's a rather nostalgic phrase, isn't it.

As first-years in Class D, we were called the exact same thing. I wonder if that part of it, like some vile tradition, had been passed down at the school this year too.

Putting their stories together without emotion—-

First, Kusanagi-kun made a remark mocking Maki-kun, calling him defective. Hearing this, an enraged Maki-kun called him out, went behind the dorms and demanded he take it back. However, Kusanagi-kun refused, and Maki-kun, unable to stand his attitude, couldn't hold back and threw the first punch. The first blow didn't land; instead, Kusanagi-kun's counter hit its mark. From there, it became a fistfight of grappling and punching. As for the outcome, it seemed from the extent of his injuries that Maki-kun lost to Kusanagi-kun, but Maki-kun refused to admit it. He insisted that he'd been the one with the upper hand. On the other hand, Kusanagi-kun said that he won and that he stopped fighting the moment the victor was decided—or so he claimed.

Because their claims were complete opposites, it was impossible to judge either way.

Kusanagi-kun glared again at Maki-kun, who'd just finished speaking, then his expression changed and he looked at me.

"Well, how should I say this... Student Council President, you understand my side of things, right? I mean, we're both in Class A, after all. It was perfect self-defense."

This was the first time he used proper polite language with me, but I wasn't so soft as to let my impression of him improve over something so simple.

"The title of Class A is meaningless on its own. A fool in Class A will be punished, just as someone in Class D will be rewarded for good deeds."

"W-What? But—!"

As if mentally slapping himself for trying to suck up to me, Kusanagi-kun's attitude instantly changed again.

So even Class A has such violent-tempered students this year, huh.

"It may be true that Maki-kun called you out, but that doesn't mean it was right for you to retaliate so thoughtlessly. Especially since you immediately intuited that you were the stronger one, correct?"

"That is...!"

"Well, for someone so convinced of his own strength, you seem to have sustained some rather nasty injuries yourself, haven't you?"

Even if Kusanagi-kun had a slight edge, they looked to be on about the same level.

Though he looked displeased, Kusanagi-kun averted his gaze at the remark.

"'Course you can't answer that. You didn't even win."

"Shut the hell up, Maki. No matter how you slice it, I'm the stronger one."

If they didn't apologize and reconcile as things stood, I would have to assign penalties based on the severity of their injuries—a ratio of four for Maki-kun and six for Kusanagi-kun.

It was just as I'd begun to think that.

"In the first place, I didn't even hit Maki this bad... Shit."

It was a slip of the tongue that escaped his lips unintentionally, rather than something he'd meant for us to hear.

Normally, I would have taken it as an act just to save his own skin, but Maki-kun, standing beside him, didn't object to the remark at all; in fact, he made a gesture as if to ignore it. Given how things had gone up to this point, he absolutely should have argued back.

At that baffling behavior, Nanase-san and I exchanged a brief glance.

"What do you mean by that? When you say you 'didn't hit him this bad'?"

"Nah, it's nothin'."

"It can hardly be *nothing*. Violence is violence, but it's clear that Maki-kun has sustained more severe injuries. Combined with the school's judgment, you may be the one to receive a harsher punishment. If that's the case, shouldn't you explain yourself properly?"

The two of them, who never made eye contact except to glare at each other, momentarily met gazes.

It looked like the kind of eye contact Nanase-san and I occasionally exchanged.

"There's nothin' more to say... What I just said is everything. Right, Maki?"

"Yeah... Still, you're definitely the one who's worse, Kusanagi."

"Huh? Are you seriously still saying that?!"

I supposed this was what one would call being back to square one.

"If no new testimony is forthcoming, we will have to conclude matters here. Are you two really okay with this?"

"I also felt, from what I've heard, that both of you are equally at fault."

When I restated the student council's opinion, both showed their dissatisfaction and retorted, but they gradually fell silent. It seemed they understood that without new information, there would be no progress.

"...Fine, I get it. We just have to take the same punishment, right?"

"Tch... Then fine. This was a complete waste of time..."

Following Maki-kun's lead, Kusanagi-kun also reached that conclusion, albeit with some reluctance.

At the very least, when they first showed up in the Student Council Office, they'd been trying to pin the blame on the other.

It was clear that both sides hoped for a lighter punishment for themselves.

I had Nanase urge them once more to speak if they had anything to say, but their hardened attitudes didn't soften. As the student council couldn't hold them indefinitely, we dismissed them for the day, sent them home, and told them the results would be delivered later.

Part 3

IN THE NOW completely silent student council room, I sighed without reservation.

"If we wanted to, we could end this incident with a fair ruling, but..."

"They don't seem to be denying that they hit each other, but it's clearly strange that they both started to accept punishment after that apparent slip of the tongue, wouldn't you agree?"

Kusanagi-kun said he had the upper hand on his opponent, Maki-kun, and admitted to hitting him.

On the other hand, Maki-kun also said that he had the upper hand.

However, there was a considerable difference in the extent of their injuries, and from what I saw, Kusanagi-kun had the advantage.

But... regarding the damage to his face, which was the deciding factor, an unexpected statement slipped out—that he hadn't attacked hard enough to cause such an injury.

Furthermore, even though it was the perfect opportunity for Maki-kun to claim—even as a lie—that Kusanagi-kun had attacked him excessively to lighten his own blame, he overlooked the slip of the tongue and pretended not to hear it.

"Student Council President, what was your take on it? To me, it looked like Maki-kun didn't want to admit defeat and prioritized his pride."

"I suppose so. That's a possibility, but... at first, it definitely looked like he wanted to pin the heavier blame on Kusanagi-kun. So it's strange that he didn't pursue that slip of the tongue. He could have claimed that he deliberately held back, but Kusanagi-kun didn't stop attacking. Couldn't he have protected his pride that way, too?"

When I answered, Nanase-san closed her eyes as if deep in thought.

Or perhaps... I tried to think about it from another direction.

"Maybe... there's someone else involved in this assault case."

Thinking that, as I recalled their testimonies, I felt as if I was beginning to see a glimpse of the truth.

"But Kusanagi-kun was the one who won the fight, wasn't he? If this was revenge, wouldn't it only make sense if Kusanagi-kun was the one who got the worst of it?"

"It doesn't necessarily have to be revenge, does it? It's possible a third party punished Maki-kun for starting a fight and losing. Not that such a thing should be condoned, of course."

"...I see. That's one way of looking at it. But then it doesn't explain why Kusanagi-kun wouldn't report it. Is it because he's afraid of becoming a target for the person who punished him... perhaps?"

"What I was just imagining is something similar to that."

It was understandable that if Maki-kun had been punished by someone like Ryuuen-kun or Housen-kun, even the winner, Kusanagi-kun, would lack the courage to speak up. But it was hard to imagine that they would go all the way to the first-year dorms just for a trivial squabble between freshmen. Besides, if there'd been such a vicious intervention from an upperclassman, there was no way they would've so brazenly tried to blame each other in the student council room; they would've been instructed to act remorseful and get through the matter without further incident.

Those two showed no signs of anything like that, and what came across for certain was that they were both confident in their fighting skills and very proud. However, they were also unwilling to tell the whole story. I could surmise that much.

"But Student Council President—"

"I know. As far as I'm aware, there aren't any boys among this year's first-years who rule their surroundings with violence and fear like Ryuuen-kun or Housen-kun. That's what you were about to say, wasn't it?"

"Yes. I can't think of a single male student who stands out enough to be ruling his class through fear."

Were they just good at hiding, or was it something else...

I looked through the documents I received from Nanase-san again.

Should I try to hear from the first witness who found the two injured...?

Or should I call in Maki-kun and Kusanagi-kun again, after they've had more time to cool off?

There was also the option of speaking to them individually, but I had a feeling that carelessly wounding their pride wouldn't lead to a solution.

"...Say, Nanase-san. Boys can be a bit childish in the way they think, don't you agree?"

"Hm, yes, I suppose so. I do think they have that side to them, to some extent. In fact, the two of them acted like children the entire time they were in the student council room."

"Yes. The problem is, both Kusanagi-kun and Maki-kun think they're strong. That's exactly why they were only concerned about who won or lost the fight, refusing to back down an inch and trying to pin all the blame on each other, even in a place where they could be punished by the student council."

"Yes."

"What if someone took on both of them at the same time, two boys who are confident in their fighting skills?"

"You mean their pride was wounded because they lost a two-on-one fight? It's not out of the question, but would they really be that tight-lipped about it? Couldn't they have worked together to pin the blame on that single person?"

"But what if their opponent wasn't a boy... but a girl... and just one at that?"

Nanase-san, who was listening beside me, looked at me with a startled expression.

"That could be it. For two boys who are boasting and insisting they didn't lose the fight, I can see why they'd be too embarrassed to admit they lost to a high school girl."

This matter could be closed, since the two boys were accepting of their punishment.

However, if a third party was involved in this fight, that was a clear act of assault.

Considering their future here at school, this was a problem I wanted to correct now.

"Since neither of them is filing a complaint, we have no choice but to investigate. Nanase-san, if you're willing, could you help me uncover the truth?"

"Of course, Student Council President. But being the president is a lot of work, isn't it? You're amazing, Horikita-senpai."

"I'm nothing special. I was told I was exceptional quite often back in middle school, but... Ayanokouji-kun, my brother, Nagumo-senpai... no, Sakayanagi-san and Ichinose-san are the same. Watching them up close, I'm always made

keenly aware of it. To people like them, I'm... undoubtedly just another mediocre person..."

It was pathetic self-deprecation, but I voiced what I honestly felt.

Perhaps it was because the way Koenji-kun so easily brushed me off after school was still weighing heavily on my mind.

For some reason, Nanase-san's eyes widened in slight surprise as she stared intently at me.

"What...?"

"No—mediocre. Even so, I think that's fine. A mediocre Horikita-senpai isn't bad at all."

"Hmph... You know, hearing that repeatedly is starting to get on my nerves."

No matter how I looked at it, it sounded as though she were making a fool of me.

"W-Wha—!? I-I'm so sorry! I think Student Council President Horikita is very admirable!"

Nanase-san lost her composure, looking truly panicked.

"It's too late to try and smooth things over now."

After pretending to be angry, I smiled and gently placed my hand on her shoulder.

"I'll need you to lend me your strength for a while."

"Y-Yes. Of course."

Part 4

I COULDN'T IGNORE the student council's problems, but at the same time, I had duties to attend to as the class leader.

Despite feeling tired, I headed to Keyaki Mall for our meeting before 6:00 p.m.

It was an important exam, no matter how small the reward or the change in Class Points.

And it was scheduled to take place either for a week starting tomorrow, or a week later.

In order not to lose, in order to win, I had to do what I could today.

I spotted a student standing at the entrance of the supermarket inside the mall and jogged over to her.

"Heya. The weather's been pretty awful lately, huh?"

The person I met up with, Karuizawa-san, murmured.

"That's true. The rainy season isn't supposed to start for a little while yet, though."

It rained all day last Sunday, too.

The forecast for now called for a little rain late at night, after midnight.

"Thank you for coming shopping with me at this hour."

"Nah, not at all. I was planning to go to the supermarket myself, so don't worry about it."

We both grabbed a basket and slowly walked from the fruit section near the entrance toward the vegetable section. As I picked up a golden kiwi that was on sale, I looked over at Karuizawa-san.

"Did you have any particular thoughts while listening to the discussion after school today?"

"Hmm, I dunno. Seemed like business as usual to me. Totally disorganized, everyone just says whatever they want... I mean, why are you asking for my opinion?"

She replied with a wry smile, saying that it really wasn't her kind of thing.

It was true that Karuizawa-san wasn't normally the proactive type in serious discussions. She left most of the talking during our meetings to me, Hirata-kun, and the other more outspoken students.

"We can't keep doing the same things as always. That's why I want to take a step toward changing things."

"So that's why you're asking me? Well, normally, people wouldn't bother asking me for advice on an exam, since I'm useless for that, right?"

"No. It's true that I reached out to you because I want things to change. But I don't think you're useless, Karuizawa-san—unlike before."

I spoke those words honestly, prepared for her to get angry.

After all, lying and saying she'd always been someone I could rely on would have been far more disrespectful to her.

"You're really merciless, Horikita-san. But, y'know, I like that about you."

Without so much as a grimace, Karuizawa-san laughed and accepted my true feelings.

She was far more clever of a person than I'd given her credit for.

It was a great takeaway to have that perception corrected.

"Well then, how 'bout the 'super-helpful me' lend an ear? So, Horikita-san, what do you think the main rule for this special exam is?"

Before I could ask a question, Karuizawa-san posed one to me.

I found that strangely funny and I let out a laugh myself.

Although I was only able to join the after-school discussion for less than an hour, several potential ideas came from my classmates.

A standard written exam, a physical fitness test.

In addition, there were oral exams, presentations, a practical music test, and interviews. There was even talk of programming, art, and drawing exams.

In any case, the prevailing view was that some kind of test would be held in one week.

The reason so many people suggested an interview exam was likely due to the major influence of our approaching entrance exams and job searches as third-years.

Considering the one-week preparation time and the lack of an explanation of the rules, that possibility certainly couldn't be ruled out.

However, the opinion also came up that there was no need to hide the rules for that.

That's because if it were an interview, it would be the kind of thing they should tell us about from the start.

In any case, there were suggestions ranging from plausible to unrealistic, but none of them felt definitive yet. Since some of the ideas overlapped, we could be more efficient if we narrowed them down.

Especially for anything academic, the result would likely change drastically depending on whether it covered all subjects or just specific ones.

I told Karuizawa-san a few of my own thoughts.

She listened intently, which she should've found boring, without showing any sign of displeasure.

And so, the conversation moved onto more sensitive topics, the kind I could only discuss with Karuizawa-san.

"This is just my guess, but I think Class C and Class D are connected."

Karuizawa-san brought it up just as we were approaching the condiment aisle.

"Ayanokouji-kun is lending Ichinose-san a hand... So that's what you're thinking, is it?"

"Yeah. I'm sure that's how it went last time, and I think it'll be something similar this time, too."

In a calm tone, Karuizawa-san answered while looking me straight in the eye.

She was the first to suggest that possibility as one of the reasons for our defeat in the last special exam.

Of course, there was no proof of that for now. I'd sensed something strange about Ayanokouji-kun and Ichinose-san growing closer right after his transfer, but I hadn't thought they'd progressed so far as to share information with each other.

"What about you, Horikita-san?"

"...I don't think the possibility is low. From Ayanokouji-kun's perspective, it's only natural that he wouldn't want our class, Class A, to win. Since he can't fight us directly, it's easy to understand why he would give Ichinose-san information to let her win. He knows our class better than anyone else."

While I was unable to function, Hirata-kun and the others took the lead and selected the test members. I was sure that even if Ayanokouji-kun hadn't seen it happen directly, he could've imagined it—what discussions took place and what conclusions they'd reach.

Of course, Hirata-kun and the others weren't at fault. I had a feeling that even if I'd participated in the discussions, the outcome would've been the same, although the process might have been different.

"But this special exam isn't necessarily a one-on-one battle. It's possible Ayanokouji-kun could suffer a disadvantage by giving information to Ichinose-san."

"That won't happen."

"Because he thinks he won't lose even if he gives her information?"

When I asked that, Karuizawa-san gave a small laugh and denied it.

"If his goal in transferring to Class C was to raise it to Class A by himself, that's a bit half-assed, you know? He should've just gone to the bottom-ranked Class D."

"But isn't that because a leader like Ichinose-san is already there? Class C was in a situation where Sakayanagi-san had been expelled, leaving them without a new leader."

"If it were Ayanokouji-kun... he would've gone to Class D, even if it meant getting Ichinose-san expelled."

"That's—that's taking it too far. He might be able to target her if there's a risk of expulsion in a special exam, but... are you saying he was trying to get Ichinose-san expelled during the year-end special exam?"

That special exam wasn't one where you could intentionally get someone from the opposing class expelled. Its rules were structured around whether or not someone from within your own class would be expelled.

"I can't think of how he'd do it, but getting someone expelled isn't just limited to special exams, is it? He might even be able to do it on an ordinary day like today."

Perhaps Karuizawa-san, who dated him, held Ayanokouji-kun in higher esteem than I did. Of course, I had no intention of arguing that she was overestimating him, but...

"Assuming that's true... then why did he transfer to Class C, I wonder."

"I don't know. But Ayanokouji-kun seems to always be thinking of something unimaginable, and he doesn't seem to need Ichinose-san's help to get to Class A. And yet, if he helped her out, I just figured he'd probably do it again this time."

Was this a favor intended to make future exams easier by having the lower-ranked classes join forces?

As long as his objective and the answer remained unknown, speculation was dangerous, but I had to keep it in the back of my mind.

And if we were going to fight based on that assumption, I had to figure out the rules of this special exam, and its solution, as quickly as possible.

A late start the next day would truly be a fatal blow.

I didn't think I would have a sharp flash of insight so easily just because I did something different from usual. But I was certain that taking on new challenges like this would surely be helpful in the future.

Even if some might say it was too little, too late, I wanted to cherish what I realized now.

Part 5

QUITE SOME TIME had passed since Ayanokouji-kun transferred classes, but the wound in my heart hadn't completely healed.

The same must have been true for Karuizawa-san, whom I'd gone shopping with.

But we'd both become able to look forward and move on, more so than before.

I think I'd recovered enough to at least feign composure whenever I saw Ayanokouji-kun at school, at Keyaki Mall, or in the dorms.

Karuizawa-san had been the catalyst for my recovery, but another one was right in front of me—

"For a loser, your color's looking a little better, Horikita."

"It was just past 6:30 PM, and I had just returned from the supermarket. I heard a rough knock, and when I unlocked the door to my room, Ibuki-san's opening words were dripping with sarcasm. It was hardly the attitude of someone about to come into another person's room and be served a meal.

"It's thanks to your wonderful flying kick. I'm so very grateful."

In response to my sarcasm, Ibuki-san proudly puffed out her chest.

"If it happens again, I'll be sure to kick you then, too, so be grateful."

I wondered if, in her head, she'd conveniently interpreted that as praise...

She was making me regret ever having said that she'd helped, even a little, as a catalyst for my recovery.

No, more importantly, to prevent any future victims, it seemed better to explain that this was a real problem, rather than using sarcasm that wouldn't get through to her.

"Kicking someone in the back from behind without warning is an extremely dangerous act, so don't do that again. At the very least, you should never do it to anyone but me."

It was fortunate that I, the one who was kicked, had some knowledge of martial arts and that by chance the damage was kept to a minimum, but if the point of impact had been worse, I could've been seriously injured. I made sure to warn her firmly about that part.

However, Ibuki-san didn't take my words at face value and instead laughed mockingly.

"So it's fine to do it to you?"

"It is not fine. But I won't be kicked by you again. After all, your prerequisite for kicking me was, 'if it happens again,' wasn't it?"

To think the precaution I'd taken would pay off so quickly.

"Hmph. So you're sayin' you've completely recovered, then."

"I can say it."

As if she found that completely unbelievable, Ibuki-san laughed as she kicked her shoes off messily and stepped inside. I picked up the disheveled shoes and rearranged them next to the two pairs that were already neatly lined up.

One pair belonged to me, the owner of this room.

And the other pair—

"What do you think, Kushida? About what Horikita just said."

Ibuki-san called out, turning her gaze to the owner of the other pair of shoes.

"Unbelievable."

She answered instantly, without so much as a glance in my direction, her eyes fixed on her phone.

"That's what she says."

"Like you, she won't readily agree with anything I say, so I pay it no mind."

I let out a soft sigh and moved from the entryway to the front of the kitchen.

Then, while taking the groceries I bought at the Keyaki Mall supermarket out of my reusable bag, I turned back and called out to them.

"Just sit wherever and play on your phone like she is. I don't mind if you watch TV, either."

"Don't have to tell me twice."

Ibuki-san plopped down in her usual spot and then glanced around the room.

Kushida-san, who was watching Ibuki-san out of the corner of her eye, muttered quietly.

"What's with that look on your face? It's disgusting."

"Huh? Whose face did you say is disgusting?"

"There's only one other person nearby, so there's no need to say a name, is there?"

"Could be Horikita. She's got a gross face."

"Oh, right. Yeah, that might be true. I guess that might've been misleading."

I wondered if those two even realized whose room this was...

"But I was talking about you, Ibuki-san."

"Huh? What, what? Why are you trying to pick a fight all of a sudden? You want me to throw a pillow at you?" snapped the always-combative Ibuki-san.

"It's because you had this look on your face, like, 'I'm so happy to be in Horikita-san's room after so long~'."

"Wha—? Wha—? I'm not happy! I just felt lucky I could get a free meal, that's all."

"Isn't that what you call being happy?"

"Absolutely not!"

Casting a sideways glance at the living room, which had suddenly grown noisy with the addition of just one person, I began to cook with practiced hands. The ingredients I bought today cost twice my usual budget.

Still, compared to when I had given up on cooking for myself for some time in favor of simple meals from convenience stores, the expense was low.

The noisy sound of their two voices, something I'd never found pleasant until just a little while ago.

But now, they reached my ears like strangely calming music.

A person's state of mind changed drastically with just a small shift in their perspective and way of thinking.

Even as I chopped the vegetables with a kitchen knife, I reflected once again on the situation I found myself in.

A little while ago, I told Ibuki-san a small lie.

My answer regarding my recovery. My assertion that I could say so with certainty.

That was a clear lie.

I do believe I'd managed to crawl my way from the depths of despair to a much better place.

Nevertheless, my wounded heart is far from fully healed.

A lie told to prevent another victim of Ibuki-san's kicks.

But the truth is, I wanted to lie to deceive myself into believing I was all right.

The reality that Ayanokouji-kun was gone was just that heavy—

Part 6

THE RICE COOKER, which I'd set ahead of time, beeped, announcing that the rice was cooked.

I immediately opened the lid, fluffed the rice with the paddle to release excess surface moisture, and evened it out.

After that, I set the prepared meal down in front of Kushida-san and Ibuki-san.

"A hamburger steak made with domestic kuroge wagyu. Not just black-haired cattle, mind you."

"K-Kuroge wagyu?! Th-This is pretty extravagant, isn't it...!"

Though bewildered, Ibuki-san spread her hands and gave the food an approving look.

"You were the one who hoped to eat something nice, weren't you? Also, your Japanese is a bit strange, so you should be more careful."

Pointing this out with exasperation, I quickly resumed my preparations.

"If you're gonna treat me this well, I wouldn't mind stopping by every day, y'know?"

"I will have to firmly decline. Today is an exception."

"So stingy, Horikita. Oh well, I'll settle for a normal meal from tomorrow on."

I didn't understand why she'd already decided that I would be treating her from tomorrow onward, but I ignored her, as engaging would only encourage her.

At the very least, she seemed to have taken it as a genuine token of my gratitude and welcomed this elaborate meal.

A spread on the dining table, a cut above the usual.

I noticed that Kushida-san, too, had stopped fiddling with her phone and was now staring at the food.

"It certainly is special, perhaps—"

In contrast to the delighted Ibuki-san, Kushida-san grew more guarded.

"There might be a catch to this. If you eat it carelessly, you might regret it—"

It seemed she'd tried to quickly warn Ibuki-san, but Ibuki-san was already in motion, lifting a side dish to her mouth with her fork.

"So fast..."

She ate with such vigor you could hear her wolfing it down.

It was proof of how delicious it was—that once she started, she couldn't stop—and a pleasant sight to behold. As the one who made it, it wasn't a bad feeling at all.

"Savage."

"Who're you calling a savage?!"

Though her mouth was still full, she immediately retorted to Kushida-san's jab.

As I watched for a moment without touching my own food, a beaming Ibuki-san looked up.

"I've been flat broke lately, so a meal like this is an improvement."

I was curious as to what kind of life she was leading, but I had more pressing matters at the moment.

After all, Ibuki-san always left in a hurry as soon as she finished eating.

"I want to hear both of your opinions."

"About the food?"

"No. Regarding Ayanokouji-kun, who has become quite the topic of conversation."

The moment she heard that name, Ibuki-san showed an overt, unconcealed look of disgust.

Kushida-san, for her part, glanced at me once, her expression unchanging.

But her eyes seemed to say, 'I knew it,' having already guessed the intent behind the special meal.

"About him transferring classes? If so, that's old news by now, don't you think?"

As she spoke so nonchalantly, I wondered whether she felt no shock at Ayanokouji-kun's departure, even though the guarantee that we could safely maintain our position in Class A had clearly vanished.

"Ayanokouji-kun is now our enemy... How can we defeat him?... Right now, I can't see a way. I need a hint that will lead to a breakthrough."



"So it's 'three heads are better than one,' huh? If that's the case, isn't Ibuki-san a little out of her league?"

"I am perfectly aware of that."

As I replied to Kushida-san, Ibuki-san, who was still gripping her fork, lightly slammed her fist on the table.

"I get that you're making fun of me. You wanna get kicked?"

"I may be making fun of you, but I'm also trying to rely on you. With regard to this topic, at least, I'm hoping you might come up with some unexpected advice. After all, you've never seemed to like Ayanokouji-kun, have you?"

"Hmph. I get it."

It seemed she'd accepted my convoluted phrasing.

"No, you totally don't get it, Ibuki-san... Oh well, whatever."

Ibuki-san picked up her fork again, shoveled a large amount of rice into her mouth, and after chewing thoroughly and swallowing, she snorted once more. Then she nodded while spinning her fork around impolitely.

"Beat Ayanokouji, huh? That's impossible."

"Giving up so quickly? That's rather unlike you. I do wish you'd put a little more thought into your words."

"I am thinking. He's as strong as a monster and surprise attacks don't work on him. Sure, if he were an opponent I felt I could almost beat, I'd be fired up to get revenge next time, but he's not on that level, and I get that now. That's why I've already given up."

For Ibuki-san, who loved to fight, to say something like that was just what one would expect from Ayanokouji-kun—but that wasn't the issue.

"It seems that when you think of 'defeating him,' you only consider it in a physical sense."

"Huh? Is there any other way?"

Normally, one would assume I meant in terms of intellect, but I decided to positively accept this as another one of those ideas that only she could come up with.

"Perhaps it might not be a bad idea to start by considering things from that angle."

It was precisely because Ibuki-san was here that we could even have this kind of discussion.

"But I gotta ask, don't you know the secret to his strength or something?"

"The secret to his strength...?"

"Neither you nor I could even touch him. Even that Albert guy was like a kid in front of Ayanokouji. In terms of pure power, Ayanokouji shouldn't have stood a chance, but it wasn't even a contest."

The fork that'd been spinning on her fingertips stopped as she gripped it tightly in her hand.

The secret to his strength that Ibuki-san mentioned. When and where had he acquired that abnormal strength?

No, it wasn't just his strength. I had a feeling his intelligence was also clearly different from that of an ordinary student.

"Unfortunately, I don't know anything... Because he never told me anything."

And I was the one closest to him... I muttered such a self-deprecating thought to myself.

"You're useless, aren't ya. And here I was, thinkin' you and Ayanokouji were a package deal."

It was a painfully sharp remark that I couldn't refute in the slightest.

If I could, I would've covered my ears with my hands to hide my pathetic self.

But even so, I was steeling myself for it. I was beginning to accept that it couldn't be helped that similar feelings would be reawakened every time the conversation turned to Ayanokouji-kun.

"I don't really get fighting and all that, but does that mean Ayanokouji-kun has something that makes him better than Yamada-kun, besides just muscle? 'Cause, like, no matter how you look at it, Yamada-kun is way stronger."

"Well, if you put it like that, I guess so, but..."

Ibuki-san trailed off and then looked at me. She was no doubt pawning off the tedious explanation onto me.

"In his case, it isn't a matter of training or martial arts styles; he exists outside of such things."

The path to becoming strong was fundamentally the same for everyone. In a specific field, be it karate or judo, one had no choice but to accumulate training and hone their skills. I explained this to Kushida-san.

"If we could only understand the foundation of his polished technique..."

Even for a genius with exceptional talent, it took many years to grow to the level of a master.

Even if I hadn't seen as much as Ibuki-san, I had been shown a glimpse of his power when he confronted Housen-kun and during the training camp. It was precisely because I too had studied martial arts that my mind refused to comprehend it. I couldn't believe it was something a high school student could achieve.

"I wonder if he learned those skills after he came to this school, or maybe from before?"

"That guy was already a monster back in the winter of our first year. No way he got 'em after he enrolled here. There's no place to learn skills like that here, anyway. You're an idiot, Kushida."

"Listen, my brain isn't made of muscle like you two, okay? It's totally normal not to know about all that barbaric stuff. Get it? So, doesn't that just mean he started taking lessons for that sort of thing before elementary school, or maybe around that time?"

"Martial arts are the same as academics, Kushida-san. Strength isn't something one acquires simply based on the time invested. No matter how much you study, it's difficult to come out on top of the pack, is it not? It isn't as if one can become stronger than anyone else just by training."

I studied diligently through elementary and middle school in order to take first place.

In fact, in middle school, I was proud to say that I was, to put it modestly, in the top three of my grade.

But after enrolling at the ANHS, I was unceremoniously knocked from that perch. Even though I could maintain a high rank, taking first place was no longer easy. When I went to university, I would likely experience something similar. Excellent students from all over the country would gather, and my ranking would naturally drop. It was a cycle. A cruel reality that could not be overcome by effort alone awaited.

"Well then, doesn't that mean there's really only one answer? He's the best at studying in this school, and he's the strongest in this school, right? It's just a simple case of Ayanokouji-kun having the natural talent of a genius, the kind that lets him be at the top."

Yes. If one didn't think too deeply about it, that was, in a sense, an answer in itself.

A person with genuine talent, different from the handful of hard workers and honor students in our grade.

One of the handful of talented individuals who could consistently take the top spot at Japan's most prestigious high schools and universities.

Without a doubt, Ayanokouji-kun was a person who held that qualification.

"It may be blunt to say, but that might be the case. However, it still doesn't feel real to me. I've seen many people more capable than myself, but even among them, Ayanokouji-kun feels... anomalous... as if he alone is clearly standing on a different plane."

—Somehow, I felt as though I was arbitrarily evaluating him on a level close to deification.

For now, I decided to assume he was just such an exaggerated existence. If it turned out that upon getting to know him, he was merely an honor student in the top ten or twenty percent, then my peace of mind would be preserved.

After taking a breath, I recalled a recent event.

"Wanting to know his roots, I actually went to the three-way conference hoping to meet his parents."

Kushida-san, who up to this point seemed almost completely uninterested in our discussion of martial arts, opened her mouth eagerly.

"Ayanokouji-kun's? What were they like?"

"I'm curious about that, too. Did he look strong, like a gorilla?" As if she couldn't wait to hear the rest, Ibuki-san leaned forward.

"You might be disappointed to hear this. It was his father who came for the interview, and while he had a somewhat stern look, he was a calm, ordinary person. He also said he hadn't done anything particularly special regarding his education."

"No way, that's gotta be a lie. It's the only way to explain it, short of him being turned into a cyborg."

She said something outrageous while slurping her miso soup.

"He didn't seem like he was lying, though."

"But we're talking about Ayanokouji-kun's father, right? It'd be kinda weird to think he'd tell the whole truth."

"...Yes, that's true."

It certainly wasn't something that could be acquired through a normal education.

Even with a considerably elite education, it still seemed a distant realm.

Was it simply a lie to avoid actions that would be considered bragging about his son?

"Speaking of parents... I wonder if there are any students at this school from the same middle school as Ayanokouji-kun."

"I wonder about that. When I tried to get similar information out of him a few times before, he skillfully evaded my questions."

"Usually, someone would tell you what school they went to, right? But the fact he won't... maybe that means he really does have a little secret."

Coming from Kushida-san, who desperately wanted to keep her own middle school a secret, it was quite persuasive.

It was certain that it wasn't something one would hide unless there was an inconvenient reason.

"So is Ayanokouji a beast at sports other than fighting, too? I mean, he was fast on his feet."

"I'm not so sure; I don't really know about that. Early on, I didn't question it much, but considering he deliberately avoided high scores on the written exams, it's quite plausible he was intentionally holding back in sports he excels at."

"So even if we found out he was in a club in middle school, he might've been holding back then, too, huh?"

"...That's true. If he possessed outstanding talent in a particular sport, someone would've likely heard rumors, whether inside or outside the prefecture..."

"I just tried searching Ayanokouji-kun's name, but nothing came up. I thought something would pop up since Ayanokouji is a rare last name, but I can't find any trace of him setting records in elementary or middle school. The only other results are for celebrities or politicians who don't seem related."

Kushida-san explained this to us while scrolling on her phone.

Until he enrolled in high school, he wasn't the kind of student who, for better or worse, would appear online.

That in itself was a clue, but we could hardly say we'd made any progress.

Someone with a clue that connected to Ayanokouji-kun...

"That guy seemed like he knew something, didn't he?"

Ibuki-san muttered quietly, as if recalling something.

At almost the same moment, I recalled the person she had called *that guy* as well.

"What was his name again... uh, the one in the year below us..."

"Yagami. Yagami Takuya-kun."

"Yeah, yeah, Yagami. He was a pretty dangerous dude, went on a real rampage. Looked like he beat the crap outta Komiya and his friends on the deserted island, and wasn't he screaming something about Ayanokouji?"

As Ibuki-san and I reminisced about Yagami-kun, Kushida-san, who'd been listening quietly, tensed up at the mention of his name. Cornered in the student council room by Nagumo-senpai, Ryuuen-kun, and the teachers, Yagami-kun was expelled for instigating the assault on the deserted island.

However, at the time, I had a fleeting thought that someone else might have been pulling the strings. A suspicion that Ayanokouji-kun had orchestrated the entire thing. But with no evidence, it was nothing more than a hunch. Now, however, that same suspicion was beginning to resurface.

"Amasawa showed up at the end, too. And a bunch of weird adults stormed in."

"That's right... I believe they said they were mutual associates of Yagami-kun and Amasawa-san. My own memory has faded quite a bit, but I'm certain I heard that."

Yagami-kun and the others had been trying to get Ayanokouji-kun expelled.

It seemed Ayanokouji-kun had summoned that very same Yagami-kun by setting a trap in a letter.

The connection between Yagami-kun and Amasawa-san was the only solid fact.

But any connection to Ayanokouji-kun remained unconfirmed.

"Yagami, Amasawa, and Ayanokouji... maybe they were from the same middle school, or they've known each other for a long time? The possibility is definitely there, right? Why don't you try searching for Yagami and Amasawa, too?"

"No luck, I'm afraid. I just tried."

It seemed Kushida-san had already begun her search, as she turned her screen toward us to show the results.

At that moment, I remembered something I had forgotten until now.

"Wait. Now that I think about it, Yagami-kun... he went to the same middle school as me—"

"Huh? Seriously? Then doesn't that mean he has nothing to do with Ayanokouji? How could you not remember something like that?"

"It couldn't be helped. I never knew him back in middle school. But you're a different story, Kushida-san."

Kushida-san, who'd been listening in silence up to this point, quietly placed her phone on the table.

"Kushida-san, you're from the same middle school as me, and you also knew Yagami-kun. Is that right?"

"Then it's your fault, you idiot Kushida. Hurry up and say it."

"Yagami... I see."

After murmuring quietly, Kushida-san continued.

"Well, Ayanokouji-kun has transferred classes and there's no point in hiding it here anymore, so I'll tell you. Yagami-kun and I aren't from the same middle school."

"—Huh?"

"Huh? What's that? What do you mean? I'm getting totally lost here."

Ibuki-san was confused. At the same time, I also felt a sense of confusion.

Right after last year's first-years enrolled. I remembered that when Yagami-kun visited the second-year classrooms, they certainly had a conversation stating they were from the same middle school.

It was something I believed unconditionally, without a shred of doubt. That fundamental premise was suddenly shattered.

And then, Kushida-san told us the reason why.

The students from her middle school days who knew her true nature. Although she had no memory of a kouhai named Yagami Takuya, he clearly acted as though he knew her. She was worried that if she acted like she didn't know him, it would lead to a difficult situation where he might carelessly expose her past, so she impulsively lied that they were from the same middle school to go along with his story. She did it to probe and see for herself just how much Yagami-kun knew. And the result had been the worst possible one. Despite not being from the same middle school, Yagami-kun knew the details of Kushida-san's past, and in exchange for not revealing it, he demanded various

forms of cooperation from her. It seemed Amasawa-san had a hand in that affair as well.

"W-Wait a minute. That's so much bombshell information, my head can't keep up. You knew that Yagami-kun was smart, too... Was he really not your kouhai?"

"I only remembered a little because it was right after I saw the new students' OAA. He had an A in Academic Ability, so it stuck in a corner of my mind. It'd be a pain if a kouhai from my middle school showed up, like you did in my case, Horikita-san, right? That's why I checked the faces and names of all the first-years the moment we got access."

She confessed that she'd skillfully used that 'A in Academic Ability' part to pretend they were acquaintances.

"I don't know how sure you guys were, Horikita-san, but the one who got Yagami-kun expelled was definitely Ayanokouji-kun."

Kushida-san cut into the one area where Ibuki-san and I had been unable to find a definitive answer.

"I asked Ayanokouji-kun directly after Yagami-kun was expelled. He said he 'took care of' Yagami-kun to save me from being used. It seems Yagami-kun and Ayanokouji-kun went to different schools, but he said they were acquaintances. Same for Amasawa-san; he said she lived nearby."

"You should've said that sooner. Really, you idiot Kushida."

"It's my sealed-away past, you know. This is a story I really wouldn't want anyone to hear."

"Jeez, to think there was someone who knew what I wanted to know this close by."

"Indeed... I sympathize with your circumstances, but this is a perfect example of it being darkest under the lighthouse."

It felt like the building blocks I'd painstakingly stacked on my own had been forcefully knocked over by a hand from the side.

"Ayanokouji-kun said he earned their resentment a long time ago. Did Amasawa-san forgive him? Was the misunderstanding cleared up? It seemed like something like that, but he said Yagami-kun wouldn't forgive him. The story was that he probably dug up my past in order to get revenge on Ayanokouji-kun... I think."

Kushida-san spoke, recalling that conversation from what was likely last year as best as she could.

"I thought I'd never tell this story to anyone else, but you never know, I guess."

Kushida-san, laughing self-deprecatingly, took a sip of water.

Perhaps her throat was dry from having spoken the truth she had hidden until now.

"I may have made you recall unpleasant things, but this is a huge piece of information. Though we'll need to reorganize everything from the beginning... you know."

The person known as Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, whose background was a mystery.

But it was a fact that even a person like Ayanokouji-kun had mutual acquaintances in Amasawa-san and Yagami-kun. Furthermore, both of them also possessed extraordinary abilities. What could be deduced from this was that their relationship was likely more than just being mere acquaintances.

He earned the resentment of his two kouhai somewhere—

"Were they in the same environment since middle school, or perhaps even earlier, since childhood—?"

And there was some trouble... In my mind, I began to reconstruct everything from scratch.

"I don't know anything about martial arts, but there are probably famous karate or judo dojos known nationwide, so isn't it possible they attended a place like that?"

"Idiot Kushida. Their strength isn't something you can get that easily."

"I did preface my statement by saying 'I don't know anything about martial arts,' didn't I? Just because my idea is different from your perception, Ibuki-san, could you stop trying to attack people for it? You're just embarrassing yourself. Also, could you stop calling me an idiot over and over? With our grades, it wouldn't even be a contest between you and me."

Kushida-san added with exasperation that she'd merely offered one opinion from a layman's point of view.

"Hmph. Knowing about martial arts is just common sense, isn't it?"

"I don't have that kind of common sense."

"Don't fight. But it's true that you can't easily acquire skills like Ayanokouji-kun and the others just by attending a famous dojo... Conversely, yes, perhaps as a result of their skills, they were invited to a famous dojo or something, and that's how they met... That line of thought might be possible."

The adults who came to pick up Yagami-kun when he went on a rampage in the student council room.

If they were also people related to his origins, then the connections would gradually start to become visible.

"I wonder if I should try asking Amasawa-san directly soon?"

"You think that little devil would tell you anything?"

"That may be true... What will you two do?"

"I'll pass."

"If I see Amasawa's face, I'll want to punch her, so I'm not going."

The two of them showed their refusal almost simultaneously.

But it was true that making careless contact would likely yield no progress.

It might be better to start by just observing the situation.

Part 7

IBUKI-SAN, HAVING EATEN her fill, left first. About two minutes later, Kushida-san went to the entryway and put on her shoes.

Just as I thought she would leave the room without so much as a glance back —

"Thank you for the meal today. I appreciate it."

"...You're not so bad, I suppose. Unlike a certain someone, you can actually say thank you."

"It's not just about you, Horikita-san. I don't really want to thank anyone else either, but I guess it's just a habit. I make a point of putting it into words, so it just comes out unconsciously."

Kushida-san nonchalantly stated that her previous remark was also an unconscious one.

"I see... Well, regardless of your true feelings, words are important, aren't they?"

In truth, there was a certain satisfaction to be had even from those words of gratitude, however superficial.

When I thought she would leave, she immediately turned back toward me for some reason.

"By the way, how are things with the special exam? Have you been able to predict what kind of rules it'll have?"

"I'm narrowing down the possibilities. I intend to report a few potential strategies to the class tomorrow."

This sort of discussion was impossible with Ibuki-san around.

I wondered if that was why Kushida-san had deliberately chosen to leave a little later.

"So you're even wary of her, of Ibuki-san."

"Honestly, she's not really at a level where I need to be cautious, you know. But just in case, I was on my guard, thinking she might try to probe me about our thoughts on the special exam rules during the meal. But there was no sign of that, or rather, I guess the thought never even crossed her mind."

There was no doubt she'd stopped by the room purely for the meal.

Still, Kushida-san avoided the topic just in case.

To be honest, it was a helpful consideration.

"It's a special exam and we don't know the rules, but do you still plan on winning?"

"What a thing to ask. Of course, I do. The conditions are the same for every other class, you know."

"But Class C has Ayanokouji-kun."

A sharp gaze and words that struck at the core without any reservation.

It was as if she were testing my mental state all over again.

"It's strange, isn't it? When we first enrolled, I never would have imagined it, but now, just hearing his name makes my body instinctively tense up and feel intimidated, and I can no longer see him as an opponent I can defeat."

I acknowledged the undeniable fact and sighed at my own weakness.

"Even so, I'll fight with the belief that I can win. Isn't that the bare minimum attitude to have?"

"Perhaps," Kushida-san answered, averting her gaze from me for a moment.

"I thought I'd get to bask in a little bit of bliss once we made it to Class A, but now we're in a position where we have to run for our lives. We're like rabbits being chased by a lion, you know? It'd be pretty uncool if we keep losing like this, I think."

With her great pride, Kushida-san continued to play the part of an honor student and was extremely concerned with appearances. Though she never put it into words, there was no doubt she'd been deeply irritated about being placed in Class D and having to content herself with being in a lower-ranked class.

Then, during the Unanimous Vote Special Exam, her true nature was exposed to the entire class, and her circumstances changed.

She now had to interact with people she despised, like me, and was forced to keep fighting, even as she was being wounded.

The status of Class A, which she finally, painstakingly obtained.

The fact that it was now facing the threat of being toppled in an instant must have been causing her considerable mental anguish.

"Either way, it doesn't look like you can do it by yourself, Horikita-san."

"...Even if I wanted to, I can't deny it."

"For now, if you figure out anything that could be a hint for the special exam, let me know. I'll try thinking about it my own way from there."

"Yes, of course. Even so..."

Kushida-san, who showed her willingness to cooperate even as she unreservedly voiced her complaints.

"I never thought I'd hear you declare your support. You do have a genuinely kind side to you, don't you?"

I praised her frankly. In response, Kushida-san scoffed, then looked at me with a fixed smile, her eyes unmoving.

"I just love the cute me who pretends to be kind. It's because I'm aware I have an awful personality that I can afford to treat even you with an angelic attitude, Horikita-san. So then, I expect your strength isn't just for show."

With that, Kushida-san gave a small, mocking laugh, opened the door, and left.

"I see... I guess that means I'm still a poor judge of character."

Far from being exasperated, I found myself inadvertently impressed.

I'd been shown Kushida-san's way of life—one that was endlessly concerned only with how she presented herself to others.

Her final words echoed in the back of my mind.

'*I expect your strength isn't just for show*.'

“—I am expecting that of myself, as well.”

After the door closed, I let out a breath and returned to the living room.

A new special exam would begin the next day.

But I had things to do, so it wasn't yet time to rest.

“Well then… I suppose I should clean up.”

Suppressing my slight reluctance, I turned my gaze to the table.

Kushida-san always ate gracefully, but Ibuki-san was the surprising one.

While it wasn't uncommon for people to leave rice grains in their bowls, she'd eaten every last one.

However—

“I can praise her for that, at least, but everything else is as hopeless as ever.”

Spilled miso soup and bits of side dishes weren't only on the table, but also where she'd been sitting.

Her uniform skirt must have been stained as well.

“I wish she'd have at least some awareness that her daily conduct and manners are being observed—”

Just as I was about to reach out, I stopped.

A thought suddenly occurred to me.

"I see... That sort of thing is certainly plausible, isn't it..."

The school imposed a week-long special exam with no explanation of the rules.

Did it refer to this one week, or to the time after this one week?

The answer hadn't been obtained.

Therefore, every class must have been racking their brains.

"—The possibility is by no means low."

Chabashira-sensei's words, actions, and attitude.

What if they were, in a way, the best hint she could give us?

She wanted us to make her think that we were different from when we first enrolled.

Such cold words reflected the true feelings of our teacher, who'd been watching our immature class.

If the idea that surfaced in my mind was correct, I had to take action immediately, within the day.

This was because whether or not I could control that person by tomorrow was directly linked to victory or defeat.

Part 8

I RUSHED OUT of my room just after 8:00 p.m. and first headed downstairs in the elevator.

And then, standing in front of Sudou-kun's room, I suppressed my impatience and knocked with some reservation.

After hearing footsteps pattering toward the door, it opened a little roughly.

"Who the hell is it at this hour—"

Sudou-kun appeared, still in his school uniform with only his blazer removed.

The sight of him wearing glasses, which I rarely saw, felt a little refreshing.

"I apologize for visiting without notice. I have something I'd like to talk about."

"S-S-S-Suzune!? Wh-what are you doing here? I mean, uh, it's not a problem or anything!"

A mechanical pencil was clutched in the hand of the flustered, gesticulating Sudou-kun.

"Oh? Horikita-san?"

From behind the bewildered Sudou-kun, Onodera-san poked her head out as she spoke.

I glanced at the entryway and saw two pairs of shoes. Even I had my suspicions, however slight.

"Was I interrupting something?"

"N-No, you're not interrupting anything at all! We were just studying together, that's it!"

"Studying?"

Indeed, there were Sudou-kun's glasses and the mechanical pencil in his hand. More importantly, both of them were still in their school uniforms.

As the student council president, there seemed to be no problems to point out.

"...Well, y'see, about this special exam. They said we don't gotta study yet, but it'd be bad if there was a written test, right? So I figured we should prepare, even just a little."

Even though I hadn't yet told them our plan for tomorrow, he'd already begun to prepare countermeasures. I doubt anyone could have predicted seeing him like this back when we first enrolled.

"That's admirable, but make sure you get Onodera-san back to her room safely before curfew, all right?"

"O-Obviously! So what do you want, showing up without any notice?"

He tried to shoo Onodera-san toward the living room with his hand, but I stopped him. Since there was a guest, it would be faster to explain it to both of them at once.

"May I come in for just a moment? This is something I'd rather people from other classes not overhear."

"Yeah... of course you can."

I stepped into the entryway and closed the door.

Then I beckoned Onodera-san, who was watching me with curiosity, over to the entryway.

"The special exam that starts tomorrow. I can't say for certain, but I have an idea about the kind of rules it might have."

I lowered my voice slightly and explained it to the two of them.

"Seriously? What kinda rules d'you think they are?"

"When Chabashira-sensei announced the special exam, her attitude was colder than usual, wasn't it?"

"Kanji and the others were complaining about it, yeah. Sounded like they were trying to figure out why."

"It's not that she was being cold because she couldn't afford to be otherwise; I believe she was actually being curt on purpose."

"Huh? On purpose? What's the point of doing that? She'll just make people hate her, right?"

"I interpreted that attitude as the only hint the teacher could give us... I think she wanted to make us remember the time shortly after we enrolled."

"You mean back in our first year, right? Yeah, she was pretty damn cold back when we enrolled."

Sudou-kun glanced back to meet Onodera-san's eyes, recalling the past, and they both nodded in understanding.

"Do you remember the first special exam we took as first-year Class D?"

"Hmm? The uninhabited island exam... wasn't it?"

Onodera-san, who'd taken a few more steps forward to stand beside Sudou-kun, murmured as she tried to recall.

"Your guess isn't technically wrong, Onodera-san. However, right after we enrolled, we were put through a certain month-long test without any explanation of the rules—the root cause of all our struggles for the past two years."

As soon as I said that, Sudou-kun immediately remembered, and Onodera-san followed suit.

"Oh, right. They were checkin' stuff like tardiness, absences, and our attitude in class. That's how our Class Points went to zero, wasn't it?"

A surprise from the school that gave the children who'd just become first-year high schoolers points equivalent to 100,000 yen every month. Repeated tardiness and private conversations. The teacher simply continued to watch over us quietly, without a word of warning.

Class D, who enjoyed and reveled in it all without a single thought for what was behind it.

The price for that was steep, and it led to the two years of hardship I just mentioned.

"So it's that exam again this time?... Come to think of it, she did say somethin' like, 'show me you've grown.' Guess she meant for us not to make the same mistake again."

Sudou-kun, who'd been properly listening to Chabashira-sensei's words, picked up the pieces of her statement himself.

"That's how I interpreted it. That's why I thought it might be a special exam with the same rules."

"That seems totally plausible. Actually, now that you mention it, it almost feels like that's the only possibility."

Onodera-san heard my idea and I could tell from her expression that it clicked.

"Of course, I can't completely rule out the possibility of an exam with some kind of unrelated rules. But our classmates studied intensively for the last special exam, and a fair amount of frustration has built up. Continuing this way doesn't guarantee we'll get good results."

There couldn't have been many students who could maintain such high motivation, like these two.

"This whole 'prepare for anything' approach, honestly, it's not a good fit for our class."

"It's certainly easier just focusing on one thing."

"Of course, it will be a gamble. If it's announced on the day that it's a written exam after all, our chances of winning might disappear. However..."

"I don't know what you think, Sudou-kun, but I'm on board with Horikita-san's plan. Studying isn't a bad thing, but you get less efficient if you overdo it. As a strategy for the class to win, I think a simple one is more effective and not a bad idea."

"Yes. I want to share this with the entire class today and have them lead a thoroughly disciplined life starting tomorrow. A single case of tardiness could be the difference between winning and losing."

Ayanokouji-kun's class and Ichinose-san's class had many honor students to begin with.

They could maintain a high standard for their usual perfect attendance and general conduct without even trying.

A mistake on the first step meant we had absolutely no chance of winning.

"Then we gotta make damn sure no one finds out about this. If Kanji and his crew go blabbing to other classes, we're screwed."

"You're absolutely right. Whether or not we can get a head start on the first day is a crucial factor."

However, putting the other classes aside, there was no way Ayanokouji-kun couldn't have figured out something of this level. Class C must have already factored this possibility into their plans. And that meant... just as Karuizawa-san feared, the information might be passed to and shared with Class D...

"...Ayanokouji's probably figured it out."

Even without me voicing my thoughts, it seemed Sudou-kun had gotten the picture.

It was proof that he now fully understood that Ayanokouji-kun was a formidable opponent.

"Even so, the other classes may not know. Will you cooperate?"

"Yeah. I've even got an idea how to make those guys stick to the rules and keep their mouths shut."

He thumped his chest with his fist and puffed it out. He looked very dependable.

"But just keeping Ike-kun and the others in line won't be enough. Our class has one major obstacle."

"An obstacle?... Ah, I see. Is that why you came here, Horikita-san?"

An image of the problem child who never listened to anyone came to both Onodera-san's and Sudou-kun's minds.

"He isn't a student who is normally late or absent without reason, but his classroom attitude and private life are highly problematic. If he alone were to drag us down, our class would have absolutely no chance of winning."

To win the special exam, getting his cooperation became our most important task.

"But that's impossible, ain't it? Gettin' that guy to do what he's told."

"Simply asking him will likely be impossible. However, I have an idea. To that end, I am thinking of visiting Koenji-kun's room, but I've never been there before. Therefore, I would like a classmate to accompany me, just in case."

"Koenji's room? Right now? Yeah, that does sound a little dicey. If that guy goes feral, even I wouldn't be able to stop him easily. Nah, you made the right call not goin' alone."

That wasn't the sort of thing I was worried about, but...

I didn't feel like pressing the issue, so I let it slide.

"So, that's the situation. Would you mind if I borrowed Sudou-kun for a bit? I believe I can have him back in ten or twenty minutes, at the earliest."

"If that's the case, be my guest. Well then, I'll just hang around and wait."

Sudou-kun readily agreed on the spot, and after he quickly put on his shoes, the two of us stepped out into the hallway.

Part 9

WHEN WE ARRIVED at Koenji-kun's room, Sudou-kun stepped forward and took the lead for me.

There was no response from inside the room.

"I wonder if he hasn't returned yet...?"

I thought he would be in his room at this hour, but maybe that was wishful thinking...

"Who knows? That guy seems like he'd just ignore anything he finds annoying, so I can't say."

With that, he knocked repeatedly on the door with brute force. It was very helpful that he could do something I would hesitate to do without a second thought.

After the sound echoed in the surrounding area for a while, the door, which had long been silent, finally opened.

"Yo, Koenji. So you were in there after all."

"Oh my, oh my. To think the fools at my door were none other than my own classmates."

"I apologize for showing up unannounced so late at night. I have a simple request for you."

"If you wished to make an appointment with me, I should think you would have used your cell phone."

"Using a cell phone with no guarantee of reaching you would be a problem if this waited until tomorrow. Besides, I determined that you wouldn't listen to my request unless I came to speak with you in person. It's about the special exam."

"I wondered what this request could be, but are you still not giving up, Horikita-girl? I was under the impression you'd seen the light during our discussion this afternoon."

"You don't have to participate in our discussions. And you don't need to shoulder anything for the class by yourself. But that's not it... If this were a request that would benefit you, wouldn't you have room to consider it? If you hear me out, I'm sure it won't be a bad deal for you."

I didn't want to overuse the tactic of dangling a carrot in front of an unmoving horse.

But it was also true that I couldn't afford to say such things when dealing with Koenji-kun.

"Hmm. In that case, I suppose I shall hear you out."

As he said that, the door swung wide open before we could say anything else.

"It would be difficult to talk with our voices echoing outside, wouldn't it?"

Perhaps having realized something when he heard the words *special exam*, he welcomed us into his entryway.

"Never thought I'd see the day I'd be stepping into your room."

"Fufufu. You should be purely delighted, red-hair-kun. You are the first man to have ever set foot in my room."

"Not happy about it at all..."

After making a gagging gesture, Sudou-kun crossed his arms and stood a half-step in front of me.

"Now then, shall you let me hear this story of yours? Something about it being beneficial to me?"

"Yes. Starting tomorrow, I want you to simply come to school as usual, without being late or absent, and to refrain from idle chatter during class. On top of that, for one week only, I want you to correct all the behaviors that are considered problematic: your posture and habits in class, and any actions that disrupt discipline at Keyaki Mall and other places."

Up to this point, it was merely a request from our side. It was obvious that Koenji-kun would not nod his head in agreement for that alone. So I immediately got to the part that would benefit him.

"If you exhibit no problematic behavior whatsoever, just like the other classmates, I will pay you 200,000 Private Points."

Essentially 200,000 yen just for being mindful of the rules for one week. This was undeniably an exceptional reward.

Sudou-kun gave me a look that said I was paying too much. But without this level of impact, Koenji-kun wouldn't budge. Besides, I was prepared to pay up to 300,000 points in the unlikely event he complained it was not enough.

"So, you believe that following the rules is the basis of this exam, do you, Horikita-girl?"

"Yes."

"Coincidentally, that is precisely what I was thinking, myself."

"That is... a coincidence. I would very much like you to tell me how you arrived at that conclusion."

"Most likely the same way you did. From our teacher's attitude."

Unlike me, who'd just had a flash of insight, Koenji-kun may have realized it at a much earlier stage. I wanted to ask for details, but I decided against it.

"However, the world is full of various happenings. As it stands, the probability of this being an exam that requires discipline is about 70%. In the event that it is an entirely unrelated exam, or if we lose due to factors other than myself, I will still expect to be paid the full amount in Private Points. Is that acceptable?"

"Hey, that ain't fair!"

"There is nothing more expensive than something free, you know. If you cannot accept this, then I can offer no cooperation whatsoever."

"I expected you would say that. I don't mind accepting those terms, but you will have to avoid any action that could result in even a single point deduction."

"Fufufu. Then our negotiations are complete. For one week, starting tomorrow—I shall sell you my discipline. For the exceptional price of 500,000 Private Points."

"...You're asking for quite a lot, aren't you? I can hardly believe that's an amount you're willing to negotiate."

"Even this is me showing considerable kindness, you know? Not being able to check my bangs with a hand mirror during class when I am so concerned with them is painful for one such as myself who pursues beauty. Besides, I am the type who prefers to conclude negotiations in one fell swoop rather than probing each other's true intentions."

That last remark was his way of saying he'd seen through the fact that I hadn't set 200,000 Private Points as my upper limit. He hit me where it hurt, just like he did after school.

"That's way too much. Just because you're takin' advantage of our weakness, you think you can get away with—"

I stopped Sudou-kun, who was on the verge of grabbing him, cutting him off.

"Forcing your own arbitrary sense of what's normal is also out of the question, I trust you understand that?"

"Of course. It will be a sad time from tomorrow, not being able to take in the sight of my beautiful, long legs upon my desk, but I suppose it can't be helped."

"...Are you sure about this, Suzune? Five hundred thousand Private Points is just—"

"The deal is done. And don't speak of this contract to anyone."

It was a gamble. Just as Koenji-kun said, there was no guarantee that obeying school regulations was part of the special exam rules, and a 70% chance would've been more than enough. But for now, I had to act with the belief that I could seize that probability; I wouldn't be able to defeat the other classes without shouldering that much risk.

Above all else, Koenji-kun would never act in an ordinary way. Had my request been something no one else could imitate, such as asking him to get a high score on an exam or take the top spot in sports, there would've been no room for negotiation at all.

But this time, it was the opposite kind of request: for him to simply do nothing.

Although it was a large sum, he accepted my proposal of Private Points.

"Well then, it is about time you took your leave. Today will be another long night for me. Or perhaps, Horikita Girl, would you care to accompany me for this long night? I promise you won't regret it."

"Like hell! We're leaving, Suzune."

Sudou-kun took my arm and, as if he didn't want me to linger for a second longer, opened the front door and stepped out into the hallway.

"Damn that guy... Spouting such nonsense..."

As we were leaving, Sudou-kun quietly cursed in front of the elevator.

"It was a foolish joke, so pay it no mind. Besides, the negotiations were concluded successfully."

"But still, isn't five hundred thousand just for doing nothing way too steep?"

"If the other students heard about this, they'd no doubt complain. But rest assured. I have no intention of burdening anyone else in the class with the cost."

"That's not what I mean... Before we even get to whether you're paying for it yourself, don't you think there'll be people who won't be convinced if they find out about this proposal?"

"That's right. That's why I asked you to accompany me. You won't tell anyone else about this negotiation, will you, Sudou-kun?"

It was a request to keep it 'confidential' while avoiding a direct statement.

Sudou-kun looked a little bewildered, but he nodded firmly as he reached for the elevator's up button.

"W-well... If you're asking me to keep my mouth shut, then I won't tell anyone."

"Thank you. Oh, the down button is fine."

I reached past Sudou-kun's slowly extending arm and pressed the down button.

"I'm going to take the stairs back. Well then, you were a great help today for agreeing to my sudden request. Good night."

After thanking him, I turned toward the emergency exit door.

"Suzune!"

A voice called out, stopping me.

"What is it?"

"I—I, um..."

I wondered if he hadn't decided what to say, or if he had, but the words wouldn't come out.

Seeing him so flustered, his voice catching in his throat, I tilted my head slightly.

"If you have something you want to say, you can tell me. Did you disapprove of my methods?"

"That's not it. It's not like that... I... I might not be a replacement for Ayanokouji, but..."

Ayanokouji. At his name, I found my eyes widening slightly in surprise.

"I'm not strong like him, and I'm not smart either... But still, I'll always be on your side, Suzune. So—whenever you're in trouble, make sure you rely on me like you did today."

Sudou-kun told me so, his eyes, filled with strong resolve, fixed on me.

"You held the class back quite a bit during our first year, so for this next year, I'll need you to do your best until the very end."

"Ugh—"

In response to my merciless words, Sudou-kun gave a wry smile, as if he'd broken out in a cold sweat.

"The elevator is here. Say hello to Onodera-san for me."

"Oh, uh, yeah. Well... see you tomorrow..."

"Yes, see you tomorrow."

I watched Sudou-kun step into the elevator, then headed for the emergency stairwell.

"...Thank you, Sudou-kun. Your words made me very happy."

The reason I couldn't thank him honestly was because I couldn't help but feel a warmth spreading through my chest. I had allies. I had reliable classmates. I couldn't remain in despair forever just because Ayanokouji-kun had left.

I knew I had to live up to the expectations of those who supported me, no matter what.

Chapter 4:
The Quest for Knowledge

IT WAS THE morning after the exam was announced. This day marked the start of the week-long exam period—or rather, the preparation period. But I did nothing out of the ordinary. I just woke up in the morning, went to school, paid attention in class, spent my free time after school and prepared for the next day.

I'd given my classmates one instruction, but otherwise, they were free.

They could carry on as usual, or they could study more. I left it all up to their own discretion.

It was still quite early for school, but with nothing else to do, I decided to keep up my early departure routine for a little while longer. I turned off the TV, put on my shoes, and stepped out into the hall.

When the elevator arrived and its doors opened, five girls and one boy were already inside.

This wasn't an unusual sight, as the elevators were often crowded on mornings before school.

Considering the capacity, I could've squeezed in, but the three Class A girls who happened to be riding—Shinohara, Matsushita, and Inogashira—were staring at me with somewhat cold eyes.

There was no point in forcing my way on, so I decided to let it go and wait for the next one.

The stairs were an option, but I chose to wait for the next elevator.

This one also had three girls on it, but there was still some room.

However, my feet felt a little heavy, and for a moment, I hesitated to get on. But there was clearly space, and it would've been unnatural not to get on. With that thought, I stepped forward. I turned around inside the elevator to face the doors, and it soon arrived at the first floor.

As the last one to get on, I was naturally the first to step out into the lobby. I took a few steps and stopped, and the two girls behind me immediately walked past.

"...Good morning."

One girl remained. She spoke to me from behind in a small voice, careful not to startle me. It was Hiyori, who'd been in the elevator with me. I'd seen her nearby or passed her in the halls several times like this, but we'd never had a proper conversation.

"Good morning."

"Have you been...well?"

"Same as always."

It was a brief exchange. For some reason, I struggled, unable to keep the conversation going.

I'd envisioned going to the library, first apologizing about my class transfer, and then maybe talking about books... I wondered if it was because we were in such an unexpected place.

No, that was just a flimsy excuse. In this small community, I never knew when or where a coincidence like this would leave us alone together. It could've happened yesterday or the day before. It was something I should've been able to anticipate from the start.

—And yet, I couldn't find the words to say. That never happened before.

Feeling a strange sensation, we started to walk together.

It was only a short, few-minute walk to school, but I was sure a conversation would arise naturally as we went.

Or so I hoped.

However, at times like this, unexpected events tended to pile up.

Just as we stepped outside, looking for the right moment to speak, I noticed a trio standing a short distance from the dorms, watching the lobby: Hashimoto, Morishita, and Shiraishi. It seemed I was their target, as Hashimoto approached me alone, acting as their representative.

"'Yo, good mornin'. And mornin' to you too, Shiina."

Hashimoto offered his morning greeting with his usual casual demeanor.

"'Wanted to check on somethin' related to our class before we get to school, y'see."

I always welcomed contact from Class C students, but the timing of this couldn't have been worse. But Hiyori, either reading the mood or wanting to get away quickly, greeted the three of them and started walking to school by herself.

"'Whoops, was I interruptin' somethin'...? My bad."

He apologized for form's sake, but considering he was using it as a convenient way to drive away an outsider who wasn't his classmate, it was clear his choice of words was deliberate.

"It's fine."

If I wanted to have a proper talk with Hiyori, the issue could be resolved simply by heading to the library as I'd originally planned.

I'd known that for a long time. I kept procrastinating, but considering what happened today, I knew I had to go and properly clear the air soon.

"Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, you certainly don't discriminate, do you? Are you trying to make a move on Shiina Hiyori, too?"

"Why would you think that?"

"That's what you say, but I wonder what the truth of the matter is."

"What's wrong with that? It doesn't matter how many cute girls he gets close to. Besides, setting your sights on Shiina-san... I'd say you have excellent taste. I think it shows a wonderful eye for beauty!"

I could see Shiraishi's eyes sparkle as she watched Hiyori walk away. It brought back memories of my recent conversation with Shimazaki and Yoshida.

In any case, there was no point in continuing this pointless conversation, so I prompted Hashimoto to move things along.

"'Bout that special exam plan you sent out yesterday. I wanted to confirm it with ya."

"I was curious about that as well. Since Hashimoto-kun appeared to be waiting for Ayanokouji-kun, I decided to take the opportunity to join you."

"And Morishita, you too? You seem surprisingly interested—"

"I am merely an onlooker."

The onlooker declared curtly.

"You laid out the instructions for the special exam in the group chat last night, right? When I saw that, I was impressed, man. Thought you were finally gettin' serious about leadin' us."

I posted in the group chat that I once again believed it was highly likely the school was making our daily conduct part of the exam. I conveyed some finer points, such as recommending that students who weren't confident in their

actions shouldn't leave the dorms, as weekends couldn't be taken lightly in addition to our weekday behavior.

"I bet you'll manage the class more stably than we could ever imagine. Things were a real pain in other ways back when it was Sakayanagi. You think so too, don't you, Shiraishi?"

Hashimoto tossed the topic to Shiraishi, seeking her agreement, but he received an unexpected reply.

"Well, I hold our former leader, Sakayanagi-san, in high regard. It's true that she had a habit of making decisions on her own as she pleased, but she maintained our position as Class A for two years without ever once letting it fall."

In reality, if an irregular existence like mine hadn't been there, she likely would have maintained control of the class for three years without issue and led them to graduate as Class A.

"I, too, agree with that statement. Only Hashimoto Masayoshi seems oddly negative, despite having been by her side."

"What's with that suspicious look...? I'm just sayin' it was a huge pain precisely because I was her aide, you know? Besides, in the end, it was Sakayanagi's fault we dropped to Class C as a result of her doin' whatever she wanted."

Hashimoto spoke with an attitude that suggested he was completely without fault.

"Oh? I don't believe so. Shall I specifically elaborate on the reason for you?"

"...Nah, I'll pass. Just listenin' to your crazy talk is exhausting."

"That would be wise, traitorous Hashimoto THE *Righteous*."[1]

"What's with 'THE'? What do you mean, 'THE'?"

To this incomprehensible nickname, Hashimoto retorted like a comedian.

"Oh my, what do you mean by 'traitorous'?"

"Don't mind it at all. That's just Morishita sayin' whatever comes to mind, like always. More importantly, let me get us back on topic."

Just as Hashimoto got the conversation back on track and was about to return to the topic of the exam, Kondou and Komiya from Ryuuen's class emerged from the lobby and approached us. Their timing was so perfect it seemed planned.

"The new class leader and his cronies, huh? Scheming somethin' evil this early in the morning?"

Kondou circled around us, glancing at everyone.

"Long time no see, Kondou. Looks like you've been keepin' your distance from our class lately."

"Well, things are different now. We're Class B, and you guys are Class C. We're only ever on guard against the classes above us."

Even as he said we weren't worth his time, his words were contradicted by his attempt to make contact, and above all, a faint, unconcealable tension leaked from Kondou's voice.

"Then you could've just ignored us today, too, you know?"

"I just thought you might get lonely if I didn't mess with you a little."

It'd been the same the other day when Ryuuen came into our classroom, but the usually fussy Morishita became abnormally quiet, like a mouse. At that moment, she was staring at the trees with a feigned air of ignorance.

"Besides, I figured if you were havin' an interesting chat, you could let us in on it."

"Unfortunately, we were just lamentin' the start of another boring day."

It was almost certain that Ryuuen had ordered Kondou and his group to decipher the exam rules. Perhaps they were just trying to get any hint they could. Or perhaps, like us, they'd already pinpointed the exam's rules and sent Kondou and the others as agents.

In the end, Kondou and his group, who stuck to our side, continued to apply silent pressure without saying or doing a thing, right up until we entered the school building and went our separate ways in the classroom.

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[1]: Hashimoto's given name Masayoshi (正義) means justice/righteousness, Morishita is jokingly saying "the" in english here to emphasize how his last name means righteous even though he's a "traitor."

Part 1

WHEN SCHOOL LET out, Hashimoto immediately approached and spoke to me before I could make a move.

"Can I assume you're free today? Let me continue what we were talking about this morning."

"I'm sorry, but I have plans, so I must decline. Please try not to cry, even if you're hurt."

Morishita, who sat behind me, rejected Hashimoto's invitation.

"I'm not asking you... I'm talking to Ayanokouji, Ayanokouji."

I expected this would happen ever since our conversation was interrupted this morning, but at this rate, the opportunity to head to the library was slipping further away.

Should I turn him down once and prioritize meeting Hiyori?

No... we already entered the exam period.

If that was the case, for the sake of sound class management, I should probably put off showing my face at the completely private library. There was a chance I could still meet her after this discussion was over.

"Shall we change locations?"

"That sounds like a good idea. Seems like a troublesome phantom's latched onto your back, Ayanokouji."

I followed Hashimoto, who urged me to get up from my seat, and we headed for the hallway.

Shiraishi, who'd been there in the morning, was now talking with a girl named Nakajima, perhaps planning to spend time with her after school. She seemed to notice us, but right after, the two of them left the classroom side-by-side.

"The café at Keyaki Mall is good, right?"

I had no particular reason to refuse, so just as I was about to give a brief reply—

"That will be on Hashimoto Masayoshi's treat, correct?"

"It's not that I wouldn't treat you if you're telling me to... but hey, why are you coming along?"

"Since you called me a phantom, I thought I would make good on your words for the sake of consistency. For the honor of phantoms."

I wasn't sure if it was necessary to be consistent or protect the honor of spiritual beings, but she probably didn't approve of Hashimoto and I talking about various things by ourselves.

"Jeez. Do you intend to monitor me so thoroughly?"

"It's a path that cannot be avoided for the sake of sound class management. Well, I won't be asking for anything too expensive, so please rest assured. I'm a woman who is kind to wallets, you know."

"I said I'm not treating you."

"You'll treat Ayanokouji Kiyotaka but not me? Is this... gender discrimination...?"

I couldn't tell if her face was one of astonishment, but Morishita's eyes widened as she muttered.

"I shall post on social media and request an all-out assault from my comrades."

She promptly took out her phone and began to tap her fingertips on it over and over.

"Ah, geez, whenever you show up, the conversation never moves forward."

"If you wish for the conversation to proceed, why not graciously pay the price for some tea? It's a small price to pay for things to go smoothly."

"Agh, damn it, fine. I'll treat you, so at least be a little quiet while we're having a serious discussion. That's an order, got it?"

Perhaps those words were the deciding factor, as Morishita gave a small nod and immediately closed her mouth. Then, she pressed her left thumb and index finger together and made a small sliding motion from right to left across her lips. I supposed it meant she was zipping her mouth shut.

After confirming that she'd actually gone quiet, we started walking again, and Hashimoto looked at me and began to speak.

"I spent all day yesterday looking into the other classes."

"Did you get any results?"

"Unfortunately, there wasn't anything you could call a real find. I guess it's no surprise that it's hard to make a move in a special exam with no rules explained. All three classes were quiet. Or rather, I should say they're no different than usual."

This probably wasn't the main topic; Hashimoto continued while lightly reporting on it and moving on.

"Those instructions you gave us last night, or rather, your idea... did you tell Ichinose about it too?"

"Of course. As allies, we need to share information."

"...Is that so? Well, it's more convenient for us if Class D ranks high right now anyway. If we take first place and Ichinose takes second, then there's nothing to complain about."

It wasn't that he was completely without complaints, but for now, it was probably just a confirmation to be safe.

"If the exam is just like you predicted, Ayanokouji, then Ryuuen's class is very likely to lose again. If Horikita's class is even one step too late in noticing these rules, it'll be irreversible. And even if there's an unexpected exam waiting for us, we won't lose if it's a battle of academics. I think we've got this one in the bag."

"The moment you let your guard down is when the rug gets pulled out from under you. Besides, Horikita's no fool. She already realized as of yesterday the possibility that 'school life attitude' is being watched, just as I told you."

When I told him that with conviction, he stopped walking for a moment and looked back at me.

"...Huh? Is that right?"

Then, after sensing from my demeanor that my statement was true, he started walking again.

"How can you say for sure that she's figured it out?"

"It just means that getting a class to unite isn't that simple."

When I told him only that, Hashimoto must have understood something, as he let out a short whistle.

"You must have a skilled scout, or maybe you've got a spy planted in there—either way, you're skillfully extracting the situation."

Normally, the inquisitive Hashimoto would probably want to pursue the matter further, including whether I was already using Yamamura, but he didn't. He understood instinctively that it wasn't a wise move to carelessly dig too deep here and worsen my impression of him.

Part 2

AS THE THREE of us headed toward a cafe in Keyaki Mall, a female student standing by the entrance spotted us and gave a light wave. After Hashimoto and I exchanged a glance, we approached her.

"I thought I would join you all."

The one who answered was Shiraishi, who I thought had left the classroom earlier with Nakajima.

"Where's Nakajima?"

"We were just chatting for a bit, then we parted ways. You're well aware that I was with Nakajima-san, right?"

"Well, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka is always ogling Shiraishi Asuka from afar, so it's a piece of cake for him. Right?"

Morishita patted my shoulder and gave me a firm thumbs-up.

"Could you not make me out to be a pervert?"

"Are you afraid of being disliked? Even though you're being hated by everyone in your previous class?"

"Whoa, whoa, just 'cause it's true doesn't mean you have to say it out loud. Besides, he's got us now. I mean, as a guy, I totally get wanting to stare at Shiraishi," he said, patting my other shoulder and giving a firm thumbs-up.

"He may be like this, but please try not to hate him."

No matter how I looked at it, Morishita seemed to be leading the effort to make me disliked.

If I were to say, at that moment, that I was just trying to keep track of the entire class, it would only be taken as an excuse.

"Oh my, I'm actually very happy. It's quite the honor to have someone you're interested in keep their eyes on you."

"For real? Good for you, Ayanokouji. Sounds like you've got a shot."

This probably wasn't the first time he'd heard that kind of reply from Shiraishi. Hashimoto also played along, knowing it was half a joke.

As for me, I was at a loss for how to respond either way, so I just let it slide.

"You get it, right, Morishita?"

"I'll be quiet for the discussion, so rest assured. Just make sure you treat me."

Now a group of four, we each placed our orders and took an empty table.

It was what you'd call 'our usual spot'.

It was a strange thing, but people have that sort of natural habituation, like a routine.

They feel a sense of security in places they've been before, and they subconsciously choose seats that meet detailed criteria, such as the view from the seat, the way the light comes in, or the distance to the next table.

It was likely influenced not only by physical aspects, but also by the consolidation of memory.

Positive factors, such as having a pleasant time with the people you were with, an enjoyable conversation, or coming up with a good idea, couldn't be ignored. Conversely, if one had bitter memories associated with that seat, there would be a tendency to avoid it.

A rational psychological mechanism. I could guess that Hashimoto and Morishita had a similar feeling.

Shiraishi joined us, but I couldn't see any change in the atmosphere, for better or for worse.

Shiraishi was good at blending into the atmosphere; that was the impression she gave.

"Jeez, you really made me buy you an expensive drink. You know my financial situation, yet you still ordered the most insane thing without a second thought..."

As payment for her silence, Hashimoto treated her to a new frappé made with a generous amount of strawberries. Just at a glance, it looked like it contained about five whole strawberries. While most cafe drinks were between 500 and, at most, 800 Private Points, this strawberry frappé was 1,300 Private Points.

"My mother taught me to go all out when someone else is paying. I was simply following her teachings faithfully."

She answered nonchalantly with a statement that was exquisitely hard to judge, though I figured it was probably a lie.

"To be honest, my instincts were telling me I just wanted a regular caffè latte, but... *sigh*."

She added those words with a look of distaste and unenthusiastically plunged her straw into the strawberry frappé.

"Then you should've just ordered the caffè latte..."

While watching their exchange out of the corner of my eye, I had a sip of my coffee and took a breath.

I moistened my throat in anticipation of the upcoming discussion with Hashimoto.

"Alright, time for a serious discussion."

Upon hearing that, Morishita mimed zipping her lips from right to left.

It was probably a signal to reassure us that her lips were sealed tight.

"You seem fired up, but to be honest, I don't intend to be particularly concerned with winning or losing this exam," I stated quietly, as all three of them turned their gazes toward me.

"What do you mean by that?"

Hashimoto—no, almost every student—intended to win every single exam for the coming year.

That was why his question, laced with suspicion, was a normal reaction to hearing I wasn't concerned with the outcome.

"This was true for the last special exam as well, but the changes in Class Points weren't exactly astounding, and they didn't have a major impact. As for this exam, the reward is only about half of the previous one."

"Well, yeah, it's true that even if we were to lose this one by some chance, the damage might not be that bad. But what do you mean you're not concerned with winning or losing?"

He greedily aimed for even a single rank higher.

Hashimoto looked disgusted by my statement, which went against that stance.

However, I had no intention of taking a harsh stance on this exam.

"To be precise, it may be more accurate to say that it's not that I don't care about winning or losing, but rather that I can't."

Perhaps finding some sense in that simplified explanation, Shiraishi smiled and nodded.

"I believe I have some understanding of what you wish to say. You think that the information you shared with us, Ayanokouji-kun, is what's most likely the real focus of the exam, correct?"

The details of the exam were kept hidden. Therefore, all the third-year students had to spend the week considering several possibilities for the exam's content. Some of those possibilities, such as a written test, were directly tied to one's abilities, so normally, one should"ve adopted Hashimoto's mindset of wanting to win and taking action to increase their odds. Simply studying for a week would have brought one closer to victory.

But the exam I considered most likely was based on 'everyday conduct'.

"You can avoid obvious demerits, but you can't earn merits. The only thing we can do is wait for the other classes to make a mistake. That's why I think it's pointless to get all worked up."

"So you don't think this'll be a battle of academics or athletics, huh? But if that's the case, wouldn't it be better to let everyone know that from the start? There are plenty of guys gettin' all worked up so they'll be ready for whatever exam comes, y'know?"

"It's fine to let them put in the effort. Since the rules are unclear, it's not like they can overdo it by focusing on just one thing."

Hashimoto's expression remained somewhat stiff, as if he was still unconvinced. Morishita was silent as usual, so I thought our conversation about the current exam was coming to an end, but Shiraishi unexpectedly took an interest.

"May I ask a small question? You've concluded that the exam is based on our everyday conduct, Ayanokouji-kun, but what would you say the probability of that is?"

"Over 90%. At least, that's my assessment."

"...Damn, that's crazy high. Guess I should be more on board with this, then. The day this turns out to be right is the day my faith in Ayanokouji goes through the roof."

"What led you to determine that probability? It's impossible to clearly tell if this week is a preparation period or the exam itself, which is exactly why everyone is speculating on all fronts. It seems you based your judgment on Mashima-sensei's comment to 'try to act in a way that befits a student,' Ayanokouji-kun, but I feel that alone is insufficient grounds for such a conclusion."

It seemed Shiraishi was demanding to know the basis for my assertion of over 90%, given the few hints we had.

"If it was only Mashima-sensei's comment, the probability wouldn't even have reached 50%."

"But were there any other remarks that caught your attention? We didn't miss anything, right?"

Hashimoto sought confirmation from Shiraishi and Morishita as he recalled his exchange with Mashima-sensei from the previous day.

"I can't think of anything."

As Shiraishi denied it, Morishita also nodded, her lips sealed.

"In reality, no other hints were given. Not from Class C, that is."

"Whaddya mean by that?"

"For this exam, what some students latched onto was Mashima-sensei's phrasing, 'try to act in a way that befits a student.'"

"Yeah, that stuck out to me too. But we can't be sure if it's actually related to the exam, can we?"

"If it's ambiguous and unclear, then we should verify it. What I focused on was the next step: whether or not those words themselves held any meaning. And if they did, the next thing to investigate is whether that statement was common to all classes. If the school instructed them to convey the message without changing a single word, then you can be confident that the words themselves are meaningful."

"You mean what the teachers of the other three classes said—is that it?"

"That's right. We have no information on Sakagami-sensei, but Hoshinomiya-sensei apparently said, 'You'll be fine as your usual selves.' Chabashira-sensei supposedly said, 'I want you to show me that you're different from when you enrolled.'"

If one added Mashima-sensei's statement to those, the rule being used for the exam became clear. The three others present would likely be able to figure it out as well.

"A single statement shouldn't have been enough to narrow it down, but adding the information from the other classes feels like it's removing all the static."

"No, you're dead on... At this point, I can't even imagine the rules being about anything other than our conduct."

Hashimoto let out a breath with a wry smile, making no attempt to hide his admiration.

Horikita's class, which lost all its Class Points at the start of the year due to their poor conduct.

Ichinose's class, which, despite receiving a certain number of demerits, had steadily produced results.

And Sakayanagi's class, which had been more stable than any other.

One could interpret them as pieces of advice from the teachers that corresponded to their respective results.

"By the way, how I procured information from the two classes is a trade secret."

Hashimoto and Morishita could probably guess that the information about Hoshinomiya-sensei's statement came from Ichinose, but because Shiraishi was also here and because it also included information about Horikita's class, I kept the sources hidden.

As for the alliance, I could just announce it when the time was right.

"Everyday conduct is something you practice all the time; it can't decide the outcome. So that's why you're not hung up on it this time—it's all startin' to make sense."

"I'm glad you seem to understand. More than that, I want the three of you to focus, not on this current exam, but on the *next* special exam."

"The next one? You think the next special exam is likely to be a huge battle?"

"Yes. Considering the last exam and this one, it wouldn't be strange for a high-stakes one to come next."

"Are you considering the possibility that someone might be expelled?"

"I can't say for certain, but I wouldn't be surprised if that was included in the rules with a fairly high probability."

"Sure, not every exam is gonna be risk-free, but aren't the high-stakes ones supposed to be rare?"

Hashimoto posed the question, wondering if it was really something to be so cautious about.

"No, I wouldn't say that's necessarily the case. It was clear from observing the upperclassmen over the last two years that the third-years' risk of expulsion is higher compared to the other grades."

The one who offered a reply was Morishita, who'd properly remained silent up to that point.

Her tone suggested she understood what happened with Horikita Manabu's and Nagumo Miyabi's generations.

"Come to think of it, last year, didn't a pretty big number of students get expelled by the time the second term started?"

"That's correct. About fifteen students were expelled. Nagumo Miyabi did as he pleased, you see. Even if that was an extreme case, it's unlikely that this year alone will see everyone pass through unscathed."

"Getting expelled during a time like this would seriously suck, but damn, you've got a good memory."

"This is merely common sense. Common sense."

Hashimoto kept several sensitive antennae tuned to information about his own grade, but it seemed he paid little attention to the other years.

"Hey, I thought you were just gonna listen quietly? What happened to zippin' it?"

"Oh? When did I ever say such a thing? At what hour, what minute, what second, and after how many of the Earth's rotations?"

"Huh? What the hell is that supposed to mean? The Earth's what-now...?"

"Good grief. Do the youths of today truly not know the statements conceived by the great figures of the past?"

I was confident that my knowledge of great historical figures and their statements was fairly comprehensive, but I had no memory of that one.

The Earth took about twenty-four hours to make one rotation. More precisely, the twenty-four-hour day was defined based on the time it took to make one rotation. With that as a premise, the Earth was about 4.5 billion years old. If I were to start calculating that out, with 365 days in a year plus leap years and so on—no, this was a completely useless calculation.

"If you're truly that dissatisfied, I shall return your drink."

"Return it, you say?... It's empty!"

That was because while she wasn't talking, she'd been silently and diligently drinking her strawberry frappé by herself.

I wondered if she chugged it all just so she could start talking.

Part 3

AFTER THAT, I focused on Hashimoto and Shiraishi to get information about Class C.

I asked about personal matters that couldn't be understood from the OAA or written exams alone, like who was on good terms with whom, and who wasn't. Although Hashimoto knew a lot about the class, there seemed to be many things that only girls could see, and I was able to hear a few useful stories that made me nod in agreement.

About an hour passed since we started chatting, and the café gradually grew more crowded as evening approached.

Just as I started to consider wrapping things up—

"Crap... Ayanokouji again...?!"

A voice exclaimed, and the pair who arrived at the next table turned to us with a look of dismay.

It was Ike and Hondou, whom I ran into at the school cafeteria yesterday afternoon.

"We're fated to meet."

At my reply, he narrowed his eyes, his displeasure obvious.

"What do you mean, 'fated to meet'?! Don't act so familiar, you traitor."

Disgust oozed from his expression. I thought they would immediately move to another table, like at the cafeteria, but with few empty seats available, the two of them sat down reluctantly.

Seeing the Class A students, Hashimoto deliberately chose to act casual.

"We're in different classes, but we're still students at the same school, so let's get along, eh? Or are you planning to complain every time you see his face?"

"It's not like I mean to... but you can see why I'm pissed, right?"

Ike and his friend, not wanting to direct their frustration at Hashimoto, glanced over and glared at me again.

"Why're you so bent out of shape about it? It's not like Ayanokouji transferred from C to A. Just changing classes had no effect on your Class Points. It's not like it cost you anything out of your own pockets. And besides, you guys are the almighty Class A, aren't ya?"

Though it was a struggle, he tried to flatter them to somehow reduce their pointless frustration.

"Yeah, we're Class A, but Ayanokouji hid how smart he was. That's pretty much like betraying the class from the start, ain't it? And then the second he transferred, bam, a perfect score. I've never seen such a nasty move."

I produced proper results in the latter half of my time in Horikita's class, but perhaps for Ike and the others, that was also part of the problem.

"And besides—"

Seemingly with more to complain about, Ike averted his gaze from Hashimoto and looked at me.

"I'm hearing all sorts of nasty rumors, y'know. That you intentionally set up both Sakura and Maezono to get expelled from the very beginning. Don't tell me... You didn't get Haruki expelled too, did you?"

A former friend of ours. The name of a student who'd been especially close to Ike and Sudou came up.

"Haruki? Who's that?"

As if the name didn't ring a bell, Hashimoto looked blankly and tilted his head a little to the left.

"Yamauchi Haruki!"

He slammed his hand on the table and shot to his feet. The cup shook from the impact, but thankfully, it didn't tip over.

Ike had been complaining but remained calm until now, but it seemed that was an unexpected landmine.

"Yamauchi... Oh, ahh, right, there was a student with that name. My bad, my bad. He was in another class, so I totally forgot about him. But I remember now. Anyway, Sakayanagi was the one who did that, right? Ayanokouji had nothin' to do with it, man. It's way outta line to blame him for every little thing."

Apologizing for having genuinely forgotten, Hashimoto hastily tried to calm him down.

"I'll never let a guy like you get me expelled, you hear me!"

"Hey, I said calm down, Ike. No need to go raising such a huge death flag for yourself. Nobody wins if we start trading barbs here."

Seeing Ike's increasingly heated and uncontrollable attitude, even Hashimoto started to panic. He probably couldn't care less about what Ike and Hondou were feeling, but he knew this commotion wasn't good for his class.

He had to have heard about one of the possible rules for this special exam from Horikita, but I wondered if he really understood it. On the other hand, if this was all an act—a strategy to drag down Class C—then it might be worthy of praise, but it wasn't a clever method, as it also increased the risk of their own defeat. If he raised his voice any further and continued his belligerent attitude, he would inevitably be noticed and without a doubt be subject to a penalty.

"Okay... Maybe I was overreacting a bit, but we in Class A have the right to complain this much. Just how much did they pay you to betray our class?"

Their frustration built up considerably, partly due to their defeat in the last special exam.

That wasn't a problem that could be easily resolved by trying to smooth it over like Hashimoto did.

It seemed it would be better if I just took the brunt of it and let them vent their anger.

"Who can say. It might be twenty million, it might be thirty million. Unfortunately, I have no intention of revealing the exact figure to you here."

It was important for me to maintain a cold and detached response.

By doing so, Ike and the other guy could direct their hatred toward me without any hesitation.

And by bringing that back to their class, they could rally together, firmly united against a common enemy.

Above all, if I got worked up here, Class C would only be at a disadvantage. Even if the school was monitoring the situation with cameras or external observers, I wanted to paint a picture where Class A was the aggressor, and Class C was trying to settle things peacefully.

It was unclear if the school was monitoring us that closely, but even if our daily behavior was unrelated to the exam, it was important to act with discipline like a proper student, as it had a small, yet not insignificant, effect on our monthly Class Points.

The teachers' words to each class would surely be a good opportunity to make our classmates re-evaluate the importance of sticking to the fundamentals.

"Don't you come crying to us later, regretting your decision and wanting to come back to our class."

After voicing his complaints one last time, the pair slightly distanced themselves as they returned to their seats.

They just sat down. I didn't want to make their café time uncomfortable.

"Shouldn't we head back soon?"

I called out to the three of them, picked up my nearly empty cup, and stood up.

"Yeah, good call. We've said what we needed to."

Hashimoto replied in agreement, and Morishita and Shiraishi followed suit.

Then, after we left the café, Hashimoto turned and glanced back toward Ike's group.

"All that complaining... Ike's completely getting worked up over nothing. The way he blames every little thing on Ayanokouji tells me the atmosphere in their class is still pretty damn heavy. They need to get their heads on straight already."

"Logically speaking, that may be so, but I believe it would be better to cut them some slack. After all, if I were a student in Class A, I'm sure I would be on edge in their current situation as well."

"Maybe so, but still. In the first place, Ayanokouji, was it really okay not to deny taking the money? That guy's gonna go around spreading all kinds of rumors, true or not."

"It doesn't matter. It's already being whispered about as a rumor, anyway. The situation won't change just because it seems a little more plausible."

"So you don't care what other people think of you, huh? Still, connecting it to the Yamauchi incident... that's a bit of a leap, to say the least."

As Hashimoto looked on, exasperated, Morishita turned a suspicious eye toward me.

"You never know. With a man like Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, you can never tell what he's doing behind the scenes. It's a long shot, I know, but he might have had a hand in it."

"Nah, that's going too far. But if, on the off chance, it were true, that'd make him one hell of a reliable ally. The stronger your allies are, the better, after all."

No matter how things turned out, Hashimoto was determined to see it in a positive light.

"If you overestimate me, you'll only be more disappointed later."

"Then I'll gladly overestimate you."

I wanted to hedge my bets just in case, but it seemed he wasn't going to let me.

Part 4

BY THE TIME I left Keyaki Mall, it was past five in the afternoon.

The sky was still blue, but the evening sun would soon begin to peek through.

"Sorry, but I'm gonna take a little detour on my way back."

"A detour? Where to? I was thinkin' we'd all walk back together."

Hashimoto asked, looking disappointed, as if he had assumed we would all return to the dorms together.

"To school. I was thinking I'd stop by the library."

"Ah, Shiina, huh? Now that ya mention it, it seems like I interrupted you two talkin' this mornin'."

Having prioritized his own plans, Hashimoto wore an expression that said he couldn't argue with that.

"If that's the case, I'll gracefully see ya off today. Let's head back, Morishita, Shiraishi."

"I'd rather not. Why should I have to walk home holding hands with Hashimoto Masayoshi?"

"No one said anythin' about holdin' hands. What kinda leap in logic is that?"

"Even if we weren't holding hands, I still wouldn't walk back with you. I'm going to browse around Keyaki Mall for a bit before I head back. So, if you'll excuse me."

With a graceful turn, Morishita went back inside the mall.

"It seems Morishita-san dislikes you more than you imagined, Hashimoto-kun."

"I don't care if she hates me. It doesn't bother me one bit if she does. Well then, Shiraishi, shall we go together—"

"I'm also going to take a small detour on my way back. Let's walk home together some other time, Hashimoto-kun."

"Tch... I see. That's a shame."

He seemed genuinely unconcerned when Morishita turned him down, but being rejected by Shiraishi as well must have been unexpected. Hashimoto's shoulders slumped in disappointment as he walked back alone.

"Would you mind if I walked with you part of the way?"

"Do you have some business at the school?"

"No. I just thought I'd like to chat with you a little longer, Ayanokouji-kun."

"With me? I'm not as interesting as Hashimoto, you know. Are you sure?"

"That's just you being modest. You're a very interesting person, Ayanokouji-kun."

It was hard to feel like I was being complimented, but even if it was just flattery, it didn't feel bad to hear her say it.

Shiraishi fell into step beside me and we began to walk slowly toward the school.

At our pace, it would only be a few minutes before we reached the entrance.

"Come to think of it, this is only the second time we've been alone like this."

The first time was the day after I transferred to Class C. It’s been since that day that I came to school early in order to observe my classmates.

"Fufu, that's right. It hasn't been that long since then, though."

"...I suppose you're right."

I made it a point of coming to school early ever since that day, but Shiraishi was no longer the first to arrive in the classroom. Now, my impression was that she tended to come in later. She'd mentioned she woke up unusually early that one time, so her habits were probably different from the start.

"What kind of impression do you have of me, Shiraishi?"

"Oh my, that's quite direct of you."

"Eh?"

"I thought you were a more reserved person. I must say, that was a bold question."

"No... Ah, I see, it could be taken that way. My apologies."

It might have sounded like a question related to romance, like whether she liked or disliked me.

"What I meant to ask was about me transferring into the class. I could tell you were welcoming from early on, but wouldn't people normally be more suspicious?"

"Why do you think that is?"

She turned the question back on me.

"I don't know... I'd never even spoken to you during our first two years. I assumed that students who only saw me from the outside would have a rather negative impression."

After successfully navigating the first special exam, I managed to gain acceptance from my classmates, but Shiraishi seemed to place her trust in me even before that.

There was no sign that Hashimoto or Morishita gave her a special explanation early on.

"You're the person who transferred to Class C after Sakayanagi-san left, aren't you? Moreover, Hashimoto-kun was certain you would be a great asset. While I'm not surprised some people were doubtful, I think there were actually quite a few who, like me, wanted to hold onto hope and believe in you."

Rather than give up on Class A, they would bet on that last chance.

It wasn't difficult to say in words, but convincing one’s own heart was a different matter.

In the future, for the sake of Yoshida and Shimazaki, I wanted to avoid creating opportunities to be alone with Shiraishi as much as possible. That was precisely why it might be okay to press a little further.

"It may be conceited of me to say, but wasn't Shiraishi watching me, to some extent, before I transferred classes?"

It was the same kind of observational gaze she'd shown in the karaoke room.

It seemed a bit excessive, going too far for someone she practically just met.

It was also somehow different from the sense of distance she kept with Yoshida and the other boys.

"Ah—"

Her lips parted slightly, and an ambiguous sound, like a breathy word or a sigh, escaped them.

And then Shiraishi, who stopped walking, looked directly at me from a few steps ahead and met my gaze.

"Ahh... that just won't do."

"'Won't do'? What's wrong?"

I asked quietly, but Shiraishi only continued to smile without answering.

After a few seconds of silence, in which it felt as if time had stopped—

"I'm Shiraishi Asuka," she said.

We already introduced ourselves long ago, and even spent time together during lunch breaks and on days off.

And yet, for some reason, Shiraishi now introduced herself all over again and held out her hand.

"And you—who are you?"

I wondered what the intention behind her words was.

Or perhaps, was she simply teasing me?

"I'm Ayanokouji Kiyotaka."

Prepared to be laughed at, I accepted her words and her outstretched hand, grasping it in return.

I felt the touch of her slender fingertips, which were a little cold, but certainly held a gentle warmth.

"For some reason, you using your full name reminds me of Morishita-san."

"True..."

It seemed Shiraishi laughed, not because I was teasing her, but because of the resemblance to Morishita.

Comparing her to Hashimoto and Morishita, or Yoshida and Shimazaki, made it clear just how little my understanding of Shiraishi had progressed.



The Shiraishi that Yoshida saw and the Shiraishi that Shimazaki saw.

By combining both of their impressions with my own, as her neighbor, I made some slight progress.

I thought I would be able to get a better grasp of her.

In reality, however, the mystery only deepened.

Her mysterious eyes couldn't be confined to the simple label of 'classmate and neighbor.'

Or perhaps this was simply her mysterious personality and atmosphere.

"Well then, I'll be going. Please give my regards to Shiina-san."

In the end, Shiraishi never answered my question.

Was there no reason, or was there one she simply didn't want to give?

Either way, she didn't seem harmful for the time being.

From there, I wanted to delve a little deeper to understand what kind of person she was.

After that, I made my way through the school and arrived at the library.

However, that was just how things went; when the timing was off, it was completely off.

Hiyori was nowhere to be seen in the spacious library and when I asked the familiar librarian, I was told she left before five o'clock.

Since it was a Friday, it wouldn't have been unusual for Hiyori to have a plan or two.

And so, day by day, my visit to Hiyori kept being pushed back—

Chapter 5:
Yamamura's Courage

AFTER SCHOOL ON Monday, it'd been four days since the exam was announced over the weekend.

I didn't know how many times I hesitated, but the days truly started to feel like they were passing quickly.

It was still bright outside the window, but the world would soon be dyed the color of sunset.

I wondered if it was what one would call a sentimental mood—it wasn't bad.

"Ayanokouji Kiyotaka. I must ask you to lend me your face."

The moment Mashima-sensei left the classroom, that listless voice came from the seat behind me, pulling me back to reality. Yes, just as if my hair were being forcefully pulled from behind.

Tug, tug...

Tug, tug...

But, it wasn't 'as if,' it was actually being pulled with considerable force.

"Are your ears working properly?"

"I can hear you, so stop pulling my hair. And your choice of words is questionable."

Reluctantly, I turned around and asked what she wanted.

"It appears Yamamura Miki wishes to see you now."

"Yamamura?"

School had only just ended, but while I was gazing outside, Yamamura vanished.

She must have slipped out into the hallway in an instant, leaving behind neither sound nor presence.

And then delivered a message to Morishita.

"I suppose she could have just told you herself, but for her to approach the current Ayanokouji Kiyotaka directly would make her stand out in a bad way, even with her presence being as faint as shrink wrap. Yes, I admit my

magnificent metaphor may have missed the mark a little. Do you have a problem with that?"

"I didn't say anything, though..."

She played the fool, acted as her own straight man, then quietly got defensive all by herself.

I intended to go to the library today for sure, but I could probably make time to see Yamamura.

More than anything, if I missed this chance, I didn't know when she would reach out again.

"What should I do?"

"You would do well to follow me. I shall guide you. And you'll owe me for this, you know?"

She stood up smoothly and struck a pose with a thumbs-up, like a sidekick.

I wouldn't have minded going by myself if she'd just told me the location, but she unilaterally put me in her debt... Oh well, refusing would be a hassle, so I figured it was fine.

It might have been that Morishita wanted to come along as well.

I glanced around the classroom to see who was still there.

Shiraishi and Nishikawa were chatting with a group of a few other girls, while Hashimoto and Kitou were already gone from the classroom.

Part 1

FOR THE MOST part, when I met up with students, it was inside the Keyaki Mall.

This was no exception for Yamamura, who did her best to conceal her presence, but the designated location wasn't a café or the like, but rather a bit unusual.

"My? It appears she isn't here."

I was brought to a rest area on the second floor with a row of vending machines, but Yamamura was nowhere to be seen; instead, several first-year students were gathered and chatting on a bench.

No matter how faint Yamamura's presence was, if there were several people gathered nearby, and she were hiding next to a vending machine, she would surely attract an unusual amount of attention if discovered.

"It would appear she saw the group of first-years and fled."

"Seems like it. But if she's not here, where could she be...? Did you try her phone?"

Without answering my question, Morishita motioned with her chin for me to follow, crossing her arms and heading toward the side of the vending machines. Then she placed the palm of her right hand on the floor.

I had no idea what she was doing, but I watched to see what would happen.

"Hmm... She must have been sitting here until just a moment ago. It's still faintly warm."

"Is that so?"

Even if she'd been sitting on the floor, it seemed like it would have returned to its normal temperature in a matter of seconds, or a few dozen at most, after she stood up…

"If you doubt me, you should try touching it. You'll be able to indirectly feel the warmth of Yamamura Miki's butt."

It was a rather unpleasant way to put it, but I was curious if it was actually warm, so I touched it with the palm of my hand. Instead of warmth, a chilly sensation came through.

"Ugh, you actually touched it. What an outrageous pervert."

"But you're the one who told me to touch it, Morishita..."

"Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, if someone told you to grope them, would you just obediently do it?"

"No... I wouldn't..."

"That's right. You mustn't be so easily swayed and deceived by the words of others. From now on, let's learn to judge for ourselves what's right and what's wrong. Is that clear?"

She was admitting that she deceived me herself.

I wanted to point that out, but the bigger problem was the first-years watching me with curiosity from a distance as I was getting scolded by a petite girl.

And they probably also heard words like 'butt,' 'warmth,' and 'pervert.'

It was a misunderstanding from beginning to end, but I probably wouldn't be given an opportunity to explain myself.

"In any case, we're moving. I'm told Yamamura Miki moved to just outside the south entrance."

With that, she turned her phone screen toward me, showing me a message she received from Yamamura.

['I'm sorry, but please allow me to change the meeting place to just outside the south entrance. I'm truly sorry.']

It certainly seemed she received such a message, but the timestamp indicated it arrived five minutes ago.

"I want to ask, just to be sure, but when did you notice this message?"

"I noticed it as soon as it arrived, but what of it?"

Five minutes ago would've been right around when we were approaching the Keyaki Mall entrance.

She indeed made a gesture as if to take out her phone... so she really did receive a message then.

"So, the fact that Yamamura isn't here, and that the floor is already cold...?"

"Yes, of course. I was aware of all of it."

It was a completely pointless trip—or rather, a pointless act.

"Now, let's hurry to the south entrance. If we keep Yamamura Miki waiting too long, her existence might just vanish from the world, you see."

Despite being the one to cause the grand delay, she turned back the way we came without showing the slightest bit of remorse.

Part 2

WE BOTH LOOKED around at the same time after exiting the south entrance.

"Oh? She isn't here either."

"Looks like it."

Since the dorms were a fair distance away and the area wasn't very crowded to begin with, I thought we would find her right away, but we didn't. I glanced toward the roadside trees, but there was still no sign of her.

"She's quite a handful, isn't she? Leading people around like this."

"Aren't you one to talk?"

We looked around here and there, but we couldn't find a trace of Yamamura, let alone Yamamura herself.

"This is like a real-life *Where's Waldo*. What a waste of time."

"Are you one to talk—never mind."

No matter how many times I interjected, it was probably meaningless by now.

"And yet, you'll still interject next time. That's what it means to be the straight man in a comedy duo."

"Don't go making us a comedy duo without my permission."

If we headed straight for the south entrance, we would've arrived a good ten minutes earlier. Then Yamamura would've been standing there quietly, waiting for us—or maybe not.

In the hushed space, the cell phone Morishita held in her hand vibrated faintly.

"'If you can find me, then come and try'? How provocative of her!"

Yamamura sent a message like that? Thinking so, I peeked at her phone screen from the side, but it seemed she only received a notification for new economic news.

"Please don't peek at my phone without permission, you rude person."

My impulsive action might have indeed been a bit rude.

"I suppose there's no other choice. Shall we try contacting her?"

"It's not that there's no other choice. Shouldn't we have done that from the start?"

"Radio waves are bad for the brain. I try to avoid using my phone as much as possible."

I had no idea what she was talking about, but for some reason, I felt it was better not to press the issue.

Just as Morishita put her phone to her ear and started to make a call, I felt a faint breeze from behind me.

"Ah, um..."

"Whoa, you appeared so suddenly, Yamamura Miki. Please don't startle me like that."

"S-Sorry."

Yamamura, who had appeared without a sound, bowed her head slightly in apology for being scolded.

This probably included an apology for changing the meeting place as well.

"Morishita told me you had something to talk to me about. Is that true?"

It was sad that I had to start by questioning that part, but it was unavoidable, thanks to the wonderful relationship of trust I built up with Morishita.

"Y... Yes. Since you transferred classes, Ayanokouji-kun, we still... haven't said a single word to each other... so..."

About a month already passed, and if you included greetings on the way to and from school as conversation, it wouldn't be an exaggeration to say she was the only student in the class I hadn't spoken to.

"Right. I was being considerate because you dislike standing out. Were you unhappy about it?"

"N-Not at all. I mean, I was grateful... for it..."

The way Yamamura stammered out her words, she might have seemed even more fidgety than when we first met. To the untrained eye, it might look like she'd regressed, but in reality, that wasn't the case.

Up until now, Yamamura had quietly erased her own presence and made herself inconspicuous.

I took that image of her desperately trying to speak as a sign of evolution, a phenomenon seen in the process of breaking away from her past self.

However, given Yamamura's life so far, it was a difficult task to ask a person who lived 99% of their life passively to suddenly become proactive.

She tried to somehow advance the conversation on her own but couldn't make any headway.

Morishita probably didn't know this flustered side of Yamamura either. A passive person has a passive way of speaking, and until now, she likely engaged in dialogue with that stance.

"Um... I-I, therefore..."

So I would just watch over her for now. If I anticipated her and said, *'Is this what you want to do?'* or *'Is that what you want me to do?'* it would only encourage her passivity.

"Ah, and... so..."

Yes... watching over her was important—

And so, what felt like a minute passed with her fidgeting, unable to continue her sentence.

Should I prompt her a little to make it easier for her to talk?

No, for her own growth, I supposed I should wait as long as it took for Yamamura to speak of her own accord.

"So... what I want to say is..."

The conversation wasn't progressing at all.

There were quite a few students who were bad at communicating and I couldn't deny that I was one of them, but I was struck by how many different types there were.

There were people like me, who couldn't think of what to say in the first place, and then there were people like Yamamura, who had things they wanted to say but had difficulty voicing them.

While I was prepared to wait patiently, Morishita, next to me, apparently lost her patience and went to stand beside Yamamura.

For a moment, I thought she was going to subtly give her some support, but —

"Fwooh!"

Then, quite forcefully, she puckered her lips and blew into Yamamura's ear.

"Wha-a-a-aah!?"

Yamamura, who'd been looking in my direction, but not actually at me, hadn't noticed Morishita approaching her face. A scream, louder than any she'd ever let out before, echoed all around.

"Wh-wh-wh-what are you doing...!?"

"Hmph. That's the *Ear Gun*. All those who're caught unaware are startled, you see."

"You probably based that on 'air gun,' but isn’t that... still just an air gun?"

"Now that you mention it, that is true indeed. I shall praise you, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka."

That might have been the moment in my life I was most praised, yet felt the least happy about it.

I worried that Yamamura's tension might have broken, just as she'd been working up her resolve.

Morishita, showing no signs of remorse, wore a smug look on her face and lightly pinched Yamamura's cheek.

"Wh-What!?"

"How about it, Yamamura Miki? Don't you feel a little less tense now?"



"Eh? Ah... I suppose... that might be so."

"In all things, tension and relief are essential. That's the secret bestowed upon the masters of comedy."

"C-Comedy...?"

"Well, that is of no consequence, so you would do well to tell Ayanokouji Kiyotaka at once."

Her expression, which had been rigid, certainly relaxed and the redness in her cheeks subsided a little.

Although it was rough and nonsensical, Morishita's actions seemed to have had a positive effect on Yamamura.

Her gaze, which had been fixed around my nose, finally met my eyes.

But perhaps that hurdle had been too high, as her gaze immediately darted back down.

"...Today... I called you here because there's something I wanted to tell you..."

She was able to speak much more clearly than before and without faltering.

"I want to change. I want to have more self-confidence, to be able to smile in front of others. I really, truly think so."

Yamamura composed her breathing and did her best to string her words together to convey her feelings.

I wondered how much courage she must have mustered to expose her innermost thoughts—the pathetic, embarrassing parts.

She couldn't maintain eye contact, but it was a commendable effort.

The desire to change sprouted within her, and she approached me with resolve.

"Please let me... help with getting to Class A, too."

"You have good grades, Yamamura and you're already helpful to the class."

"I want to do more... much more. Because I believe... there's something... that only I can do."

"You understand, do you not, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka? It should be your role here to meet Yamamura Miki's expectations."

"I suppose so. Then there's something I'd like you to do for me right away."

"Y-Yes!"

First was a task suitable as a starting point to see just how useful Yamamura could be.

"I want you to find out about Shiraishi Asuka."

"Sh-... Shiraishi-san, you mean...?"

She was probably prepared to conduct any kind of espionage, but she would've assumed it would be against the other classes.

She surely hadn't expected to be told to investigate her own class.

"So the man who came to save the class was just a common lecher... I see. What has the world come to."

"That's quite the imaginative interpretation, as always."

"Am I wrong? Shiraishi Asuka is the class's secret idol. Is it possible that you, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, have also fallen into her trap? Why don't you let your heart be as honest as your body? Well? May I have your answer?"

Saying that, she made a fist and pressed it insistently against my cheek.

Apparently, she was pretending her hand was a microphone, but it hurt nonetheless.

"I'm currently struggling to raise my understanding of the class. In the process, I feel I'm making progress understanding people like Yoshida and Shimazaki, but with Shiraishi, it feels like I'm getting nowhere. I can't spend forever on my neighbor, which is precisely why I want to ask for your cooperation."

"You certainly have a convincing way of putting things. However—I suppose I can feel a bit of sympathy for the part about you struggling to understand her."

"Is... that so?"

"I suppose you wouldn't understand, Yamamura Miki. You always use your faint presence to investigate students from other classes, or untrustworthy students like Hashimoto Masayoshi; you wouldn't watch a student like Shiraishi Asuka, who seems harmless on the surface."

"Yes... If you're okay with it, Ayanokouji-kun, I think I can... try to investigate Shiraishi-san in my own way... I can't, um, promise at all that I'll find any useful information, though..."

"Of course, I'm aware of that. Whether or not she has a side she doesn't show to me or our classmates—anything you learn, no matter how trivial, will be fine. Look into it."

Investigating students from other classes came with some trouble, but since this involved a classmate, the possibility of it developing into a major problem was likely low.

Of course, if Shiraishi recognized Yamamura's presence, it could become a source of conflict, but any dissatisfaction or anger would be directed not at Yamamura, but at the person presumed to be behind her. If she was the kind of student who would instead assume Yamamura was acting alone, then that was the extent of her abilities. Even if parts of her personality remained unclear, it was safe to end the analysis there.

I hadn't had this much contact with Yamamura since transferring. Strictly within our class, our relationship wasn't apparent to any student besides Morishita.

Part 3

IT WAS RIGHT after I received Yamamura's agreement and finished telling her about Shiraishi.

A single student popped up at the south entrance, where we hadn't seen anyone.

He then spotted us, shook his head as if to say *'good grief'*, and approached with a smirk.

"Kinda cold, isn't it? Not inviting me to what looks like a pretty important chat."

"How did you know we were here, Hashimoto Masayoshi?"

Morishita, not even trying to hide her wariness, bluntly asked him for his reasoning.

"Process of elimination. I had to run frantically around campus and Keyaki Mall. I was wonderin' where you and Ayanokouji were going and well, I imagined you two were in a relationship you couldn't speak of."

"Please limit your jokes to your face."

"Now that's just hurtful. I'm actually pretty confident about my looks, for your information."

It was almost impressive that he hadn't followed us immediately after we left the classroom.

He'd properly taken into account the risk of us spotting his tail.

"I'm on your side, you know? You don't have to be so guarded."

Hashimoto said that as he closed the distance with Morishita, who frequently and openly avoided him.

"If you so much as lay a finger on me, I'll let out a maidenly scream that could tear silk, you brute."

I had a feeling that 'tearing silk' and 'maidenly' didn't really go together.

However, since I couldn't imagine what kind of scream Morishita would let out, my interest was piqued just a little.

"Well, I guess I can kinda see why you wouldn't want me involved this time, though."

Saying that, he shifted his gaze from Morishita, with whom he was making no progress, to Yamamura.

Yamamura, now the subject of his gaze, looked uncomfortable, took a step back, and averted her eyes.

"Are you making Yamamura your aide, Ayanokouji?"

"That's not what this is about. For me, this is still Class C, which I've only just entered. There aren't many people I can rely on. However, Yamamura and I were together for the school trip and the training camp, and I believe we've formed something of a bond. And I've judged her to be a trustworthy person. It's not a matter of me *adding* Yamamura; I'm hoping she'll *join* me."

This reversal of roles was an extremely important distinction.

"Well, well, looks like you've really earned Ayanokouji's trust, eh, Miki-chan?"

"Uh... Mi-Miki..."

"Calling a girl by her first name without permission is rather inappropriate, wouldn't you say, Hashimoto Masayoshi?"

"Hey, you're one to talk, calling people by their full name. And while we're at it, why don't you try getting along with me too, Ai-chan?"

"I absolutely refuse."

"Harsh. What'll it take for you to trust me?"

"Trust isn't built in a day. No, in your case, perhaps I should say: it takes years to build trust, but only a moment to lose it."

Morishita sharply thrust her index finger right in front of Hashimoto's face.

"Even if Ayanokouji won't back me up, at least Miki-chan might—huh?"

In the instant his gaze was stolen by Morishita, Yamamura once again silently departed from the scene.

"As expected of a ninja's descendant. It seems the talent is passed down through the ages."

I was pretty sure she didn't have any ancestors like that.

"I will be leaving as well. Please don't follow me again."

"Don't worry, I won't chase after anyone but Ayanokouji."

"My condolences," she said to me as a parting shot and without heading back to Keyaki Mall, Morishita seemed to be walking home from outside.

Once it was just the two of us, Hashimoto's shoulders slumped in an exaggerated fashion.

"Am I really that untrustworthy?"

"Do you think you are?"

"...I don't."

"Then you'll have to be prepared for people to keep secrets from you or avoid you to some extent."

"The truth hurts."

Hashimoto wasn't an idiot. He understood and accepted that his past actions made his classmates give him the cold shoulder. And yet, he'd gone out of his way to chase me down. It seemed like an action that could only bring him harm, not benefit.

"Is it strange? That I'd show up even when I'm being told to stay away."

"It'd be a lie to say I wasn't wondering about it."

"Hah... Of course I want to get to Class A. I'm the guy who was willing to betray his own class to make that happen. I tried every trick in the book to cozy up to the other classes. But now, I've decided this class can win. The fact that I threw away my Private Points is proof of that, right?"

He'd actually lost a large sum of Private Points, making it nearly impossible to buy a ticket to escape should his class sink. For Hashimoto, that was proof of his resolve to go down with his current ship, even if it meant being swallowed by the raging waves.

"You're an amazing guy, you know. I feel like you'll win to some extent even without my help. I know it'd be a smarter move not to show up like this and make myself disliked. And yet, the reason I can't help but stick my nose in... is because I want to do everything I can to help get us to Class A."

After he said that with a serious face, he immediately reverted to a joking expression.

"Not that I expect you to believe me, though. But I'm gonna keep pestering you anyway."

It seemed he intended to stick to his guns, fully aware of the criticism he would receive for being unable to suppress his true nature.

"Do as you like. Though I think you'll be hearing endless complaints from Morishita..."

"That's my one and only headache. She's so loud. So? You heading somewhere now?"

"I'd like to, but I'm stopping by the school."

"The school? The library? Didn't you get to see Shiina on Friday?"

"No, she'd already left for the day, so I couldn't meet her. So you could say this is me trying again."

"...I see?"

Although he let me go without any issue on Friday, Hashimoto's expression turned slightly suspicious, perhaps because he thought I was using the same line again as an excuse to turn him down.

"Listen, you—"

Hashimoto started to speak, but then he let out a short laugh, exhaled, and shook his head.

"It's nothing. If you want to see Shiina, I'll graciously step aside today, too. Well then, I'm off."

He turned his back and walked into Keyaki Mall.

I was a little concerned about how Hashimoto was acting, but it was getting late again.

I decided I should hurry to the library.

Part 4

AFTER PARTING WITH Hashimoto, I returned to the school.

The time was just past five o'clock. Most students had already gone home and the majority of those remaining were in the middle of their club activities.

Shouts could be heard from the fields and the sound of squeaking shoes from the gymnasium.

I was heading to the library to meet Hiyori, something I'd been putting off for a while.

We exchanged greetings on Friday, but didn’t get to talk beyond that.

The invitation to transfer to Class B.

I refused it and, for my own purposes, transferred to the unrelated Class C.

It wasn't that I regretted it.

But the reason I still felt a lingering pull was probably because I, too, had wanted to transfer to Class B, where Hiyori was waiting.

As an ordinary male student of the Advanced Nurturing High School.

A year spent without being tied down by things like being a leader or a strategist.

A future that might have been.

A future I could've chosen.

I recalled the end of our second year, when Ishizaki led me to hold hands with Hiyori.

"...Am I regretting this?"

Seeing my own faint reflection in the windowpane, I stopped walking.

My feet, which stayed away from the library under the pretext of personal matters.

It was true that many things often overlapped at inconvenient times.

But it wasn't as if I couldn't go to the library at all.

I should've been able to find a gap in my schedule and make enough time to at least show my face.

Does that mean I was unconsciously avoiding going there?

Why?

I probably already had the answer to that question.

Because I didn't want to see the sadness on Hiyori's face, if at all possible.

Because, even though I knew it was wrong, I betrayed the smile of the girl who invited me with all her heart.

But that wasn't rational.

The more time that passed, the more the relationship deteriorated and the sadness grew. If I was the one at fault, I should've gone to see her immediately, apologized, and repaired the relationship.

Knowing it was pointless, I posed the question to myself once more.

No answer comes back. Of course not. The answer was already in my head. The act of asking myself questions while pretending not to know... it felt unsettling somehow.

I decided to move to Class C and rejected Hiyori's invitation. Therefore, I would apologize for it.

Why couldn't I just get on with such a simple process?

I could also tell her via a call or a message, so why hadn't I even considered that as an option?

In the first place, Hiyori wasn't the only one saddened by my transfer.

My classmates, like Horikita, who were aiming to graduate from Class A, were the prime victims of that.

So why am I—so concerned only about Hiyori...?

I averted my gaze from the windowpane and started my halted feet moving toward the library once more.

I had no basis for it, but I felt like I'd understand if I went and saw her.

That was the feeling I had.

"Ah..."

Just as I steeled my resolve and started moving again, Hasebe appeared from the hallway that led to my destination. There didn't seem to be anyone else around right now, but I wondered what she was doing all by herself at this hour.

I was a little curious, but we weren't on the kind of terms that we could casually call out to one another. So, I figured we would just pass each other by and that would be the end of it.

Indeed, Hasebe seemed to notice me right away, but she averted her gaze, her eyes downcast.

And so, we passed each other without exchanging a word.

However—

"Hey... hey..."

It was a faint, small voice, so much so that I thought I might have imagined it for a moment.

But it definitely came from Hasebe.

When I stopped and turned around, Hasebe did the same, though she kept her gaze averted.

"I... I wanted to talk for a bit, if that's... okay?"

It would've been easy to refuse, but I could see a hint of resolve in Hasebe.

She'd approached me in the same way at the end of the school year, but Amasawa's interference at the time meant I was ultimately unable to hear what she had to say.



If I brushed her off again here, she might never approach me again.

That was before I changed classes. And now it was after I'd changed classes.

What she wanted to talk about might have changed, but it seemed I needed to hear her out.

"Yeah. I couldn't hear you out when you came to talk to me before."

"You remembered."

"It was just the other day."

"That's true... In the meantime, you changed classes, Ayanokouji-kun... but... could that be my fault? Because I came to talk to you—and you got sick of it?"

"It's completely unrelated, so you can rest easy. I'd been getting offers from students in the current Class C since before the end-of-year special exam. Sakayanagi's expulsion just made it a reality."

It was a lie I made up on the spot, but there was no problem with it.

It didn't matter whether there was one reason or a hundred for my transfer, for my betrayal.

"Oh... I see."

Whether she believed my words or not, she let out a breath as if relieved, or rather, as if she were a little happy.

"I would've thought resentment would come first."

"Resentment...? It's not like I have the right to feel something like that... It's like, conversely, with you changing classes, Ayanokouji-kun, I feel like we've found a more appropriate distance between us. Of course, I'm going to be in my current class forever, so I think I understand that part."

A distance that was uncomfortable as an ally. A distance that was comfortable as an enemy.

So that was how Hasebe was taking it.

"So, if it's not about resentment, what'd you want to talk to me about?"

"Oh, yeah, well, actually—it's..."

While answering my question, Hasebe hurriedly searched for something on the phone she was holding.

"I just really wanted you, Ayanokouji-kun, to see how hard she's been working—"

From Hasebe's flustered phone-fiddling and fragmented words, I figured out what she wanted to say.

The one who left the school. The student named Sakura Airi and what happened to her afterward. Hasebe must have some information about that. I'd briefly heard that she'd passed an audition, but that was just a piece of information I'd acquired. Until a short while ago, I wouldn't have had any interest in it.

However, through my contact with Tsubaki, I had developed a slight curiosity about what happened to those who dropped out.

Still, that was only in comparison to before.

It certainly wasn't something worth stopping and turning back for.

Hasebe's anxious eyes, staring at me.

All I would gain by refusing was the small amount of time that wouldn't be wasted afterward.

"Is it... not okay?"

When I didn't answer, Hasebe whispered, clutching her phone anxiously.

"That's not true. I'd like to hear it."

"Eh—r-really?"

"Yeah. I didn't have the courage to look into it myself, but to be honest, I've been wondering about her all this time."

The students of Horikita's class were becoming more and more wary of me.

Although there were still some cracks, it would probably become difficult to extract information from them from now on.

In that case, I just needed to try a new angle of attack.

Precisely because I put myself in a difficult position by abandoning everything and betraying my class, I couldn't pass up an opportunity to test how to win them over, or how to create a breakthrough.

Hasebe, her eyes sparkling, held out her phone to me.

"She's started to appear on TV bit by bit, though it's in a late-night slot."

"On TV? That's amazing."

Sakura was expelled at the beginning of the second term last year. The fact that she made it onto TV in less than a year since then was genuinely surprising.

I imagined her simply starting a new school life as a student at some other school.

It seemed she had actually wanted to invite Miyake and Yukimura to talk about Sakura at the end of the school year, and I confirmed that what she wanted to tell them was exactly the same.

Our standing conversation went on longer than expected and the scenery outside began to take on a reddish hue.

"Oh...! Sorry, Ayanokouji-kun. I got carried away talking... Didn't you have somewhere to be?"

"It's fine. I enjoyed talking with you, Hasebe, it's been a while. And I was happy to learn more about Sakura."

"R-Really? To be honest, I could talk about Airi forever... but I'm glad."

"If you don't mind, let's make some time to talk again somewhere. Or, if you're worried about drawing resentment from Class A, we could talk on the phone."

"Of course! I'll make sure you become Airi's number two fan, Kiyopon."

It seemed she didn't realize it herself, but she unconsciously called me by my old nickname.

After that, I parted ways with Hasebe and arrived at the library before six o'clock, but Hiyori was already gone; the same librarian from the other day told me that she left about ten minutes earlier.

There were two main routes from the library to the entrance, and it seemed I picked the wrong one, a fifty-percent chance.

The librarian asked if I wanted them to pass on a message, but I declined the offer.

"I'll try again another day."

There was no need to rush; the time to know the answer would surely come soon enough.

Part 5

AT 7:40 P.M. on Monday, Kaneda, having finished dinner in his dorm room, arrived in front of the karaoke parlor where they were to meet at 8:00, looking restless.

He occasionally looked around, let out small sighs and paced about the area.

That strange behavior came to an abrupt halt with the appearance of a certain person.

"T-Thank you for coming today, Shiina-shi."

With a nervous expression, Kaneda bowed his head, quickly adjusted his crooked glasses and offered a stiff smile. Then, he let out a long breath as he looked at Shiina in her casual clothes.

"The pleasure is all mine, Kaneda-kun. This feels somewhat refreshing, doesn't it?"

"Yes, it really is. I wonder what Ryuuen-shi is thinking."

Together, the two of them looked up at the karaoke parlor, which was brilliantly beckoning customers.

But Kaneda, out of the corner of his eye, burned the sight of Shiina into his memory.

He arrived much earlier than the meeting time because he anticipated that Shiina, who now stood beside him, might also arrive early. And that hunch was correct.

That meant they would have nearly twenty minutes alone together at most.

"We still have a little time, what should we do? Personally, I think it would be best if we went inside to wait—"

Just as he was about to suggest that, a loud voice echoed through the mall.

"What the heck?! I thought I'd be the first one here, but you two already beat me to it!"

With an exaggerated reaction to something not particularly surprising, Ishizaki arrived.

"...Hello, Ishizaki-shi."

Whether he was put off by his attitude or for some other reason, Kaneda greeted him with a somewhat displeased look.

"You're here early. I had the impression you were the type to be late."

"You look pretty bummed, Kaneda. Don't tell me you—"

As if he'd an inkling about Kaneda's suspicious behavior, Ishizaki grinned slyly.

"W-What is it...?"

"It's my job to greet Ryuuen-san, got it? I'm not gonna let you look cool!"

"I see... So that's why you arrived early, Ishizaki-shi."

"The three of us got here at pretty much the same time. There's no first or last place here, so remember that."

"Rest assured, I don't place any importance on such things."

"Man, I wonder what Ryuuen-san's thinking. He said he's not just callin' you, Kaneda, but that Tokitou guy too. They ain't got the rank to be called to a meeting, right?"

"I don't know about Tokitou-shi, but I have regular meetings with Ryuuen-shi, so I would appreciate it if you didn't lump us together."

Kaneda pointed it out sharply, pushing up the bridge of his glasses with his middle finger.

In reality, Kaneda did have regular conversations with Ryuuen while the exams were underway, but a large portion of those cases involved them speaking one-on-one.

"The strategy for the special exam's already been decided, right?"

"Yes. We haven't received any additional orders as of now. Or, it's also conceivable that this is a meeting to report on some other possibility he's discovered..."

"Or maybe he needs our power. Like, we all get together and come up with some amazing ideas."

"I understand what you're trying to say, but that doesn't mean just any talent will do... Don't you agree, Shiina-shi?"

It was just a proverb, after all. Kaneda added that simply having more people wasn't enough and was about to ask for Shiina's opinion.

At that moment, however, Ryuuen appeared and the atmosphere instantly grew heavy. Ishizaki also put on a tense expression, bowed his head deeply in greeting and immediately began to move inside the karaoke parlor.

The four of them were led to a room in the back that'd been reserved in advance.

Ryuuen slid a menu across the table and had the other three order food and drinks.

"It seems Katsuragi-shi and Tokitou-shi haven't arrived yet. Is that all right?"

"They let me know they'd be late. More importantly, Kaneda, have you heard anything from that Hashimoto guy?"

Without even looking at him, Ryuuen asked the question, and Kaneda slowly shook his head from side to side.

"No, I have not. We were in frequent contact until just before we became third-years, but since Ayanokouji-shi's class transfer was finalized, he's been ignoring my messages."

Upon hearing that report, Ryuuen closed his eyes and the left corner of his mouth curled up slightly.

"So he's made up his mind, huh?"

"It seems he holds Ayanokouji-shi's abilities in very high regard. Of course, I've also been observing the recent developments objectively and have had to revise my own evaluation of him two or three times—but even so, I thought Hashimoto-shi would leave open the possibility of transferring to another class."

"Well, Sakayanagi probably would've found Hashimoto's two-timing diplomacy amusing, but with Ayanokouji, you never know how things will turn out. If he makes a clumsy move to secure his own escape route, he'll be cut off without mercy. Even he doesn't have the guts to cross that bridge."

Either risk it all and keep his ties to other classes, or commit fully and go down with Ayanokouji. Ryuuen answered that it was the decision he made after weighing those options.

"...You truly do hold him in high esteem."

Kaneda acknowledged his ability, but he still didn't rate him as highly as Ryuuen did.

Because he'd only ever seemed like an ordinary student, Kaneda perceived him as having some kind of weakness and failed to sense the sharpness—the kind that made one feel they would get hurt just by touching him, like with Sakayanagi or Ryuuen.

Ryuuen turned his gaze to Shiina, who hadn't said a word since entering the room.

"What's your read on Ayanokouji right now?"

"Me?"

"His actions since transferring classes. Including what the hell he's aiming for."

A little surprised, Shiina recalled how he'd been when she ran into him in the elevator the other day.

"I wonder... I can't really give a good answer."

"That's impossible, Ryuuen-san. It's 'cause Shiina sees Ayanokouji through a filter."

"A filter? What do you mean by that, Ishizaki-shi?"

Kaneda retorted to the strange expression.

"It's a special filter, man. A special one. The kind ya call the Ayanokouji Filter."

At Ishizaki's answer, Kaneda's facial muscles tensed slightly and his expression grew grim.

"I—"

Even Shiina, who was dense about such things, understood what Ishizaki was trying to say and looked down awkwardly.

Ryuuen, on the other hand, didn't change the way he looked at Shiina in the slightest.

"I don't give a damn what kind of feelings you have for Ayanokouji. But as long as you're a member of my class, you need to work to make us win. Got it?"

"Yes, I understand."

"Anyway, you managed to talk to Ayanokouji after he transferred, right? Tell us about that."

"No... Actually, I haven't been able to speak with him properly yet."

"Huh? How come? I definitely told him to go see you."

As Ishizaki tilted his head in confusion, Shiina's spirits sank at the mention of Ayanokouji.

"I'll get in touch with Ayanokouji right now and—"

"That's enough out of you. Just sing."

As if to say there was no need for any more pointless talk, Ryuuen gripped the microphone and tossed it.

"W-Whoa, r-roger that!"

Ishizaki, who caught the mic to keep it from falling, seemed to think he'd been appointed to liven things up, grinning determinedly as he psyched himself up. Then, after he selected a song, the introduction began to play.

Just as he began to sing, the door to the room opened, and Katsuragi and Tokitou appeared in the karaoke room.

"Sorry for the wait."

Immediately after Katsuragi spoke, Tokitou cut in and confronted Ryuuen.

"What do you think you're doing, calling even me out here?"

"I figured I'd listen to a useless guy's opinion for once. It's just a whim."

While Ishizaki belted out his song, sparks already flew between Ryuuen and Tokitou.

"Now, calm down. First, why don't you tell us why you've gathered us here today? I was under the impression our policy for the current special exam had already been decided."

"Tearing down Ayanokouji and the next special exam. Figured I'd touch on that."

"...Hoh. That sounds like a rather interesting topic."

"Got any new information on Ayanokouji?"

"No, I don't. I haven't really been able to speak with him lately. There's always someone from Class C by his side, starting with Hashimoto. I've been avoiding any careless attempts at contact."

Beside Katsuragi as he answered, Tokitou also averted his gaze, responding with silence.

"Um, Ryuuen-shi. If you would permit me, would you allow me to look into Ayanokouji-shi? Since I haven't tried to get close to him before, I might be able to learn something new."

"Do as you like."

Ryuuen replied without expectation, and then, the moment Ishizaki finished his song, the conversation shifted to the next special exam.

"In my opinion, the results of the current special exam aren't that big of a deal. However, judging by the lackluster rewards, it wouldn't be surprising if the

next special exam causes a major shift in Class Points. We absolutely cannot afford to fail that one."

As if agreeing with Kaneda's assessment, Katsuragi nodded firmly.

"I'd say so. Even though we're Class B and Horikita's is Class A, that doesn't mean we're in a safe zone. Our last loss narrowed the gap and now we're under heavy pressure from the classes below. If we suffer two or three consecutive losses, we'll inevitably be neck-and-neck with them. And if that happens, many of our classmates will see it not as being on equal footing, but as falling into a disadvantage."

"The outcome of that special exam is our class's final line of defense, isn't it?"

It was still only May. Assuming the next major special exam would be held in either June or July, the worst-case scenario might await them before they even reached the halfway point of the year.

"If there is any silver lining, I suppose it's that we can assume the probability of an academics-centered special exam is not very high. While studying is an inseparable part of being a student, if we're constantly forced to compete in that area, our class has no chance of victory from the outset. I'm sure the school wouldn't be so consistently unfair."

At the time of class assignments upon enrollment, many honor students were placed in Class A.

While one could accept that as a large head start, if that alone were to decide everything, there would've been no need to make them compete from the very beginning, as it would've been entirely superfluous.

"If the rewards are worth it, we should use anything at our disposal, including the Private Points we saved last time. I don't want to recommend it, but that includes acts that border on breaking the rules."

"So you're finally starting to get it, Katsuragi. But I have no intention of fighting within the rules. Fouls, whatever, I'll use any means necessary to win."

"I understand. But I will stop you."

Katsuragi didn't change his stance of strictly adhering to the rules.

They continued their fruitless discussion, and a silence fell between them.

It was a disconnected moment, especially as other students were getting rowdy in the next room.

"Ryuuen-kun... you're not trying to force me to talk about Ayanokouji-kun, it seems..."

"It's just that I don't think I'd get any useful information out of you anyway."

"...Is that really the only reason?"

"Huh? What do you want me to say? Do you want me to order you to 'find his weakness by any means necessary'?"

"—That's..."

Ryuuen already had the answer to that question.

What Shiina felt for Ayanokouji went beyond mere friendship.

"I'll make damn sure you're useful. Not for Ayanokouji, but for this class."

Even if it meant exploiting those feelings, Ryuuen envisioned a future where he defeated Ayanokouji.

"Yes. That resolve—I intend to form it."

Ever since the transfer, she hadn't been able to have a proper conversation with Ayanokouji.

Because of that, Shiina was trying to come to a certain resolution.

To Ayanokouji, she was just a friend, or perhaps even less than a friend.

If that were the case, even her faint feelings would become heavy shackles.

Kaneda quietly continued to watch Shiina, whose sorrowful profile looked as if she might vanish.

It was the first such experience for a man who'd lived his life devoid of any fighting spirit.

Chapter 6:
Fortune and Misfortune Are Intertwined

THE DAY STEADILY drew to a close and before I knew it, school was over. It was almost the end of the fifth day since the exam was announced, but not a single major change had occurred. As far as my brief investigation showed, every class maintained a perfect record of no tardiness or absences and the student body was leading a quiet, more serious school life than usual. I also heard no rumors of any trouble over the weekend, a time when things tended to get lax. It seemed the students hadn't forgotten to maintain a sense of tension.

As was evident from their diligence in their studies and sports, their avoidance of tardiness and absences, and their strict adherence to order and politeness, all four classes were acting with the consideration that their daily conduct would be key to the exam. It seemed Ryuuen's class hadn't been able to grasp that on the first day, but Kondou and the others' actions, while probing, had clearly taken daily conduct into account from the very beginning. I didn't know which student in Ryuuen's class proposed the idea, but in that class, the leader's decision was everything.

The fact that he adopted it meant that, at the very least, Ryuuen himself came to the same conclusion.

Thwip, thwip-thwip!

Just as I was about to get up from my seat, a sharp pain shot through the back of my neck again and again.

"Ow, ow, that hurts. What the...?"

Turning around in response to the unfamiliar sensation, I saw Morishita holding what looked like... a gun, made from disposable chopsticks.

"To think you're still alive. You're quite something."

"Never mind 'quite something'... What is that?"

"It is a gun. A gun."

Thwip!

While I was turned around, she fired a rubber band into the palm of my hand.

The gun was formed from multiple layers of rubber bands wrapped around disposable chopsticks and it seemed to be designed so that pulling the part that resembled a trigger would launch a rubber band.

"That hurts, you know?"

"That's because I'm shooting you with the intent to cause pain."

"Why'd I have to be the one in pain...?"

Still, it was well made... It wasn't just haphazardly assembled into the shape of a gun; it was designed to shoot rubber bands.

"When'd you make something like that?"

"It's a secret weapon I diligently crafted during break time. It's a wonderfully lethal weapon, capable of slipping past even the metal detector gates."

I decided to consider it a small mercy that she hadn't been working on it during class.

"Let's take a drive to the ends of hell together. *Bang*."

"I absolutely don't want to do that."

As we were having this pointless exchange, Satonaka approached us hesitantly.

"Do you have a moment?"

"Yeah. What's up?"

While surprised to be addressed by someone so unexpected, part of me thought it would be funny if Morishita shot Satonaka with a rubber band.

When I glanced over at Morishita, at some point she'd put the gun on her desk and was staring out the window, looking bored. Apparently, I was the only one she wanted to take a drive with to the ends of hell.

"I was wondering if you'd like to hang out with our group this Sunday."

As he said that, Satonaka looked back and a group of a few boys and girls waved in our direction.

There were three of them in total: Yanagibashi and Tsukasaki, with whom I'd had almost no interaction, and a girl named Hoashi.

"I won't force you, but what do you think?"

"I don't have any particular plans, so if you guys don't mind, I'd like to join."

When I answered, Satonaka smiled happily. I wondered if the reason I felt inexplicably happy just seeing that was because of his handsome features, which even a guy could admire.

"If you'd like, how about you, Morishita-san?"

"I'll pass."

Without so much as a glance at Satonaka, she gave her blunt refusal while continuing to stare out the window.

After that, Satonaka said he'd message me the details later and went back to his group.

"Why'd you refuse?"

"For no reason other than I'm simply not interested."

At some point, she shifted her gaze from the window back to me and was now unabashedly gripping the gun in her right hand.

"Don't tell me, Morishita, you have feelings for Satonaka—?"

Thwip!

A rubber band shot mercilessly into my left cheek.

"Too bad for you, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka. Did you think you would get to see me blush and become flustered?"

"The thought crossed my mind, but it seems I was wrong... Besides, that hurt, and it's dangerous."

"I'm simply not interested in him. Besides, faces that are too androgynous are not to my liking. A face as hideously distorted as yours, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka, is better—at least it warrants pity. Are you happy to know that I'm fond of you?"

"There's no doubt that sadness far outweighs happiness. Sorry, but I'm heading home."

I hurried out into the hallway, escaping from Morishita, who kept firing rubber bands at me and asking if I was running away.

I took out my phone and checked the message from Ichinose one more time.

['It looks like Hoshinomiya-sensei wants to see you, Ayanokouji-kun...']

After receiving that message, I headed for the special building she'd designated.

At the time, just after school let out, that special building was always quiet.

Two years ago, there'd been an incident in that very place where Sudou fell into Ryuuen's trap in a security camera blind spot, but since then, more cameras were installed there.

With the exception of spaces where privacy was a consideration, such as the changing rooms and restrooms, it could be said that most of the school was now covered by them.

While a small number of students felt suffocated by the extensive surveillance, the majority likely welcomed it as a means of protecting themselves.

I arrived at the promised location, but Hoshinomiya-sensei was still nowhere in sight.

So, I decided to kill some time by gazing out the window.

Considering I had to go see Hiyori, I didn't want to linger for too long today. The figures of students heading home or off to their club activities began to trickle into view.

"—Club activities, huh?"

In the end, I never joined one, but my mindset changed enough that I thought if I could start over as a first-year, it might be good to try joining one.

Enough that if someone were to ask if I was satisfied with my student life, I could give a hesitant nod.

I averted my gaze from the window and looked down the hall.

Not long after, I heard the sound of high-pitched footsteps echoing all around.

As she came into view, our eyes met, and she approached with a light wave of her hand.

"Sorry for the wait, Ayanokouji-kun. Did you need something from me, calling me out to a place like this?"

"You're the one who called me here, aren't you, Sensei?"

"Whaaat are you talking about~? A teacher would never call a student out to a place like this, you know. I only came because Ichinose-san told me *you* wanted to see *me*, Ayanokouji-kun."

I was in the exact same situation, but I figured it wasn't even worth asking her about it.

Hoshinomiya-sensei's eyes were clearly smiling.

As I was trying to figure out her true intentions, she closed the distance even further, pressing herself against my body.

"What do you think you're doing?"

"What am I doing? Whatever do you mean~?"

She played dumb, refusing to answer my question and instead brought herself closer as if to whisper.

And then, without so much as asking for my permission, she entwined her slender arm with mine.

"I need you to do your best this year, Ayanokouji-kun, so it's fine if I give you a little bit of service, right? Just like this."

To call such a blatant act 'service' was just like her, but for a teacher, it could only be called unbecoming conduct.

That said, I had no intention of lecturing her about it here, nor did I intend to forcibly shake off her slender arm. Either way, the important thing was not to take any action myself.

"You leave no openings, do you, Hoshinomiya-sensei."

I stopped her objective, not with action, but with conversation.

"Eh? What's that supposed to mean, 'leave no openings'?"

"I already had my predictions about the upcoming special exam, but your advances just now have confirmed them. What the school will judge over the course of one week is our 'attitude in our daily school life.' The number of tardies and absences, our general conduct. The factors that usually only cause minor monthly fluctuations will be the main evaluation criteria. The school hallways are lined with countless security cameras, so they can easily assess the students by checking the recordings later. If they see me in close contact with a teacher of the opposite sex, it will inevitably affect my assessment."



A little while ago, Hoshinomiya-sensei had been on the verge of running wild, determined to win even if it meant using her authority as a teacher to ensure her class's victory. To prevent that, I told her the details of my alliance with Ichinose and the arrangements that came with it, so she was now somewhat under control. However, what she truly desired was to return to the upper classes as soon as possible and to see Chabashira-sensei's class fall.

"Ayanokouji-kun, you're being a little too suspicious. We're in this together, aren't we? So there's no way I'd do anything to drag you down, right? Besides, we don't even know if you're right about the exam."

"Of course, I don't have any concrete proof. It's just a feeling I have. But please, rest assured. Even if you were to intentionally act in a way that lowers my evaluation, Hoshinomiya-sensei, it won't affect our alliance."

As I continued to speak in a calm, business-like tone, Hoshinomiya-sensei's smile deepened, perhaps because she understood.

"Oh, that's a relief. Well then, does this mean you'll let my class have the win this time? You'll let the class with fewer Class Points have the glory, won't you?"

"That would be the case if I could completely control the outcome. However, this is a competition between all four classes. If our class receives a negative assessment, we risk placing last. And there's no guarantee that Ichinose's class will be able to take first place."

"But come on, that's where you get to show off your skills, isn't it, Ayanokouji-kun? You just have to arrange things so my class takes first and your class takes second."

"Unfortunately, I have no intention of intervening to make adjustments."

"...But why? Are you just going to ignore the risk of Class A and Class B winning?"

"Frankly, for this particular exam, I don't believe that will be an issue."

"Even if we get them, it's a mere fifty Class Points. Are you saying they're not even worth bothering with? That's—"

"That's incorrect. It's because I've judged that this isn't an exam that warrants demonstrating the true value of our alliance. To begin with, isn't it also necessary to believe in your own class?"

For the past two years, the school saw Ichinose's class as being just as disciplined as Sakayanagi's, if not more so. However, unable to endure their

current circumstances of having fallen to Class D, Hoshinomiya-sensei was always trying to forcibly change the situation by using every trick in the book.

Of course, it would've been understandable if she were acting out of sheer desperation, but in a case like this, her actions could've ended up nullifying her class's greatest strength.

"Remember to watch over them. That's something even Chabashira-sensei is capable of."

"Hk..."

I finally brought up the name of her contemporary rival, Chabashira-sensei.

The moment I did, Hoshinomiya-sensei's demeanor changed in an instant.

Hoshinomiya-sensei stopped, and her arm slipped smoothly away from me.

"I can trust you, right?"

The meaning behind those words was simple. It included the threat that if betrayed, she would go on a rampage at any time.

"Please consider our alliance from a long-term perspective, not a short-term one. That's all I can say for now."

"I see. Well, you certainly did come through for me during the last special exam, so I suppose I'll just wait and see for now."

It was a good thing that Hoshinomiya-sensei was wary and hadn't let her guard down.

But in truth, it was also a fact that we didn't need to force a win in this exam. If our daily conduct was indeed being assessed, intervening carelessly to control it would be a troublesome and high-risk endeavor. For my class and Ichinose's, which had very few behavioral issues to begin with, employing unnecessary measures would only increase the danger. The best strategy was to let them act as they usually did.

Part 1

ONLY ABOUT THIRTY minutes had passed since school let out. I arrived at the library at a relatively early hour.

After many twists and turns, the time had finally come.

The start of a new special exam during Golden Week, repeated after-school invitations, and chance encounters. A considerable amount of time had passed since Ishizaki told me to meet with Hiyori.

As I stepped into the library, its distinctive scent gently drifted into my nostrils.

I wondered if Hiyori was there.

The library at ANHS was so vast that finding a person could be just as difficult as finding a book.

When I happened to glance at the librarian at the entrance, she gave me a warm smile and then pointed a finger without a word.

That direction was the area where the mystery novels were shelved.

Apparently, the person I was looking for was there.

As I slowly approached the spot, which was still some distance away, Hiyori appeared from behind a bookshelf.

Before long, in the sparsely populated library, our eyes met.

But in the next instant, she averted her gaze and disappeared deeper into the shelves.

I thought our eyes met, but could it be that she hadn't noticed me?

Calling out from a distance would be a breach of etiquette, so I headed for the bookshelves.

She was no longer where I'd last seen her, so I began checking the aisles between the shelves.

One, two, three...

Where was she? I couldn't imagine she had gone that far—

Just as I was thinking that, I finally found Hiyori at the end of the aisle, on the opposite side of the bookshelf where I stood.

And our eyes definitely met.

Or so I thought, but she immediately broke her gaze and vanished into another aisle.

She definitely noticed me. If so, does that mean she's avoiding me?

Was it because I was late in coming to see her? Because I didn't transfer to Ryuuen's class?

As I speculated on the reason, I closed the distance to talk to her.

If she continued to run away from me inside the library, then I would have no choice but to give up.

I couldn't bring myself to forcibly corner someone who was clearly reluctant.

Hoping that wouldn't be the case, I walked toward the spot where I'd last seen Hiyori.

Where did she go from there...?

Just as I was thinking that, Hiyori, perhaps wanting to see where I'd gone, peeked out from behind a nearby bookshelf.

The distance was less than two meters. Close enough that if I stepped forward and reached out my arm, I could easily touch her.

"Hiyo—"

I tried to call her name, but she hid her face again.

But she didn't run away again; it seemed she'd only hidden her face.

As proof, her hand rested on the bookshelf and a part of her uniform was visible.

"Was I bothering you?"

When I spoke in a quiet tone, her face slowly emerged after a brief silence.

"Did you come here to look for a book to read...?"

At least she replied. For now, I was relieved about that.



"No, I came to see you today, Hiyori."

"..."

The meaning of my words must have gotten through, but Hiyori still wouldn't come out from behind the bookshelf, keeping half her body hidden. I was reminded of the words of Ishizaki from the other day.

'Make sure you see Shiina soon. She was pretty down, even if not as much as I was.'

And then there was the somewhat awkward atmosphere from when we were in the elevator together a few days ago.

Why hadn't I come to see her sooner?

I now regretted that I'd been running away from the guilt I felt over transferring classes.

"Are you still bothered by the fact that I rejected your class's invitation and transferred to Class C?"

I decided that we would not be able to have a satisfactory conversation without first eliminating any unnecessary distance between us, so I posed the question. Hiyori, who immediately showed her agitation, averted her eyes, which had been trying to meet mine and pressed her lips tightly together.

"I suppose I can't say... that I haven't been concerned. I kept imagining that maybe my invitation was the reason you were keeping your distance, Ayanokouji-kun..."

"That's quite unlike you. You of all people should know that's not possible."

If anything, the Hiyori in my mind was always unhurried and did things at her own pace.

I saw her as a person who could look at matters calmly, with a discerning eye, without ever growing flustered.

I assumed she understood, without me needing to say a word, that my transfer from Class A to Class C had a purpose that could only be attained by joining that class.

There was no way she'd distance herself just because her invitation was rejected.

However, it was an undeniable fact that I'd delayed coming to see her.

"I apologize again for not being able to accept the transfer to Class B. And for taking so long to properly talk about it. That caused the misunderstanding."

In the silence of the library, Hiyori took in my words, then shook her head.

"No... You've done nothing wrong, Ayanokouji-kun. The class transfer... how should I put it... was just me getting my hopes up on my own... And even though I thought there might be a reason on my part for why you weren't visiting, I couldn't bring myself to come see you. Please allow me to apologize for that."

After she said that, the rest of her body, which had been hidden, slowly came into view.

Then she bowed her head, as deeply as she possibly could.

And yet, Hiyori didn't have a single thing to apologize for.

That being said, continuing this apology contest wouldn't lead to anything productive.

"I thought I was prepared..."

"Prepared?"

"We're in different classes now, Ayanokouji-kun. I thought that our relationship, where we could chat so familiarly, had to come to an end... But talking with you like this... I suppose..."

So she'd been trying to sever our friendly relationship and resolve herself to see me as an enemy.

Realizing that, I felt a sense of relief that I made it in time.

"If you don't mind, Hiyori, why don't we talk about this past month we've been apart? We have plenty of time today."

"Is it... really okay?"

"Of course. I came here today because I wanted to see you and talk with you, Hiyori."

As I told her my honest feelings, a smile appeared on Hiyori's face for the first time that day.

Part 2

WE SAT FACING each other in the empty seats of the library.

Then, as if to fill the one-month blank, we began to string together words little by little. At first, Hiyori, who had a somewhat distant atmosphere, gradually returned to her usual smooth and gentle tone.

"So, even after becoming a third-year student, the bookworm remains unchanged."

"Yes. In fact, I just finished reading another one last night."

She looked once at the bookshelf lined with mystery novels and replied that she'd just returned it.

"Ah, actually, I've made one more friend who's a fellow reader."

Hiyori clasped her own hands together and her eyes narrowed with joy.

"Ever since I became a third-year, Kaneda-kun has been visiting me often at this time."

"Kaneda? Well, I can picture him reading a book, so I'm not particularly surprised..."

Still, until the end of the second year, I'd never once seen Kaneda in the library.

If he was considering going to university, the library was also an excellent environment for studying.

"Ah, speak of the devil."

Hiyori, whose back was to the library entrance, noticed Kaneda's arrival before I did and waved.

I also turned around and raised my hand in response to Kaneda, who was looking this way.

Kaneda showed a slightly surprised face but immediately started walking and came to our table.

"...Hello, Shiina-shi. I've come again today."

My guess was correct; along with the library books, he also had academic books in his hand.

"Kaneda-kun, you really do love books, don't you?"

It was clear from Hiyori's words that he was a frequent visitor. When I gestured with my eyes for him to sit in the seat next to me, he gave a slight nod and sat down.

"Yes, well. I've heard that you, Ayanokouji-shi, also used to frequent the library. It seems you haven't shown your face recently, though."

For the past month. It was precisely when Kaneda started coming to the library that I'd been unable to come.

"It seems like we've been swapping places. I think we'll have more chances to meet from now on."

"...I see. As a fellow reader, that's nothing but delightful."

He showed a welcoming stance, but his expression showed no joy. It was no surprise, since my presence had no direct bearing on him. The only one who would be truly happy about gaining another reading companion would probably be Hiyori right in front of me.

"Be that as it may, you seem to have been busy. The matter of your transfer from Class A to Class C surprised me a little—no, quite a bit—hmm?"

A sudden shadow fell over us, its source being the librarian.

"I'm sorry to interrupt your conversation. Shiina-san, this is sudden, but could you lend me a hand? I don't think it will take long—"

"If I'm the one you need, of course I'll help. You two, if you don't mind, please wait just a little. I'll recommend some books to you later."

Leaving us with those words, Hiyori left her seat with the librarian.

Now, just the two of us, Kaneda and I, who were not particularly close, were left behind.

It was often the case that the atmosphere became a little awkward when a mutual acquaintance left. I learned such things through my school life.

I suppose I would try to take the lead in the conversation.

"What kind of books do you usually read, Kaneda?"

"I'm not very good at such meaningless small talk."

A clean rejection. It's like I threw him the conversational ball, and he just chucked it out into left field. I thought I started a natural topic since he liked books, but it seemed to be a question Kaneda disliked. Or perhaps my throw was clumsy.

"My bad. I apologize if my wording offended you."

Was it an unbefitting overestimation to think that I could hold my own in a situation like this?

"...No, my apologies as well. There's no need to be so down about it."

"I was just trying to connect the conversation smoothly. Really."

"I got that sense, somehow."

"If you don't want to talk to me, you don't have to force yourself."

"...This is rather unsettling. It's not that I dislike it, but I don't often have the opportunity to talk with you face-to-face like this, Ayanokouji-shi, so I couldn't help but think about various things. Until Shiina-shi comes back, shall we talk for a bit, if you'd like?"

I was a little happy to see Kaneda showing a positive attitude toward conversing with me.

"If there's anything on your mind, you can ask me. Of course, I can't give unlimited answers regarding class problems."

I thought Kaneda would understand that, but I told him just in case.

Kaneda took off his glasses, breathed on the lenses, and wiped both of them with a cleaning cloth he took from his pocket. Then he slowly put his glasses back on.

"With Shiina-shi—you seem to be on good terms."

"Hm? Oh, it's because she's a fellow bookworm, like you, Kaneda. I have her keep me company."

"A fellow bookworm, you say? That may certainly be true, but the expression I saw on Shiina-shi's face from a distance just now was one I haven't been able to see this past month. When I saw you two from the entrance, I was frankly surprised. It was the first time in a long while I'd seen her genuine smile."

"That might have been my fault. I just apologized to Hiyori and she forgave me. So from now on, I imagine you'll be able to see her smiling in class and in the library, just as she did before."

I kept to myself the part about her inviting me to transfer classes. It wouldn't have been pleasant to tell Kaneda, who was not only from a rival class, but also close to Ryuuen and I had no idea how that information would be interpreted.

"Do you realize just how amazing that is?"

"Amazing?"

"You don't understand? No... are you pretending that you don't? Ayanokouji-shi, have you ever felt like you're blessed?" he asked me as if to test me.

"Blessed? That's far too broad a definition for me to answer."

"My apologies. It seems my words were insufficient. Even from my perspective as a man, your features are quite excellent, Ayanokouji-shi. You're also taller than average and well-built, yet you don't give off a needlessly intimidating air. More than anything, you have an impeccably clean-cut appearance. And on top of that, it seems you were dating Karuizawa-shi until recently and lately, I've even been hearing rumors about you and Ichinose-shi. The more other men learn about you, the more they will look at you with admiration and, at the same time, feel a fierce jealousy at the immense gap between you."

My interest was piqued by Kaneda's unexpected words and I listened intently.

"It's not just your appearance. In terms of academics, you're increasingly being called the number one student in our year by those with high academic ability. I was once proud to think that my own academic ability was not inferior to yours, Ayanokouji-shi, but I'm now ashamed of that and couldn't help but laugh at myself. Furthermore, concerning your physical abilities, it seems you've been achieving excellent results in PE since April. As for me, someone who is poor at sports, I could stand on my head and still not come close to your potential—"

So this was Kaneda Satoru, a student who could speak so eloquently and passionately.

He praised me while simultaneously disparaging himself.

When looking at student values across the entire year, Kaneda was in the top thirty percent. I saw no reason for him to needlessly belittle himself, but...

While forcefully heaping praise upon me, Kaneda continued.

"And now, you've unleashed the true abilities you'd hidden for two years and have even taken up the position of leader to rebuild Class C now that Sakayanagi-shi left. Even that somewhat dangerous mind of yours must surely captivate many. You're the very picture of a hero, are you not? I envy you from the bottom of my heart."

"Envy me? I'm a traitor who abandoned Class A and objectively speaking, not using the power I possessed and hiding my true abilities would more likely be judged as villainous."

"That just makes you an anti-hero, which is still a hero."

With a hint of a dry, exasperated laugh, Kaneda glanced behind him.

My eyes followed his and I saw Hiyori, who seemed to be working on a computer with the librarian. It looked like it would be a while longer before she returned.

One thing I could tell for certain from Kaneda's attitude and words, was that he held feelings for me that were stronger than I'd imagined. I was aware that transferring classes would lead to various opinions being directed at me, but his ranked high among them. At first, I thought his comments were out of consideration for his class leader, Ryuuen, but it didn't seem to be only that.

And one thing was for certain: Kaneda didn't like me.

"Ah... my apologies. It seems I've gotten carried away and talked too much."

It seemed Kaneda realized how his words must have sounded to me.

"There's nothing to apologize for. People are free to think what they want of others."

"Even that part of you is so cool it's infuriating, Ayanokouji-shi. Even if you're prepared to be hated, I'm sure it doesn't feel good to actually be hated by someone. Or is it simply because it's me, you don't care what I think of you?"

"That's not it. I would say the same thing in the same way to anyone."

I'd proceeded this far on the assumption that I would be hated.

"—Then, what if that person were Shiina-shi...?"

And then, Kaneda brought up Hiyori's name.

She was, indeed, one of the most appropriate students to use as an example in that situation.

I intended to reply immediately just as before, but the words caught in the back of my throat.

I didn't mind if Hiyori hated me.

Yes, in essence, that was true.

I knew that was a possibility after I rejected Hiyori's invitation and transferred to Class C.

The reason I hadn't gone to apologize right away was because I needed to prioritize other matters.

What she thought was a secondary, or even tertiary, concern that I placed low on my list of priorities.

"Please, forget I asked. That was an indelicate question."

Without waiting for my reply, Kaneda quietly pulled back his chair and stood up.

"I think I will be leaving for today."

"Are you sure? Hiyori looked like she wanted you to wait."

"It's quite all right. It makes no difference whether someone like me is here or not right now. I apologize for the one-sided conversation."

"No, don't worry about it."

"Is that so? Then I am grateful for your magnanimity."

Leaving behind an air of resolution, Kaneda departed.

A short while later, Hiyori returned, looking around curiously.

"Oh? Are you all alone, Ayanokouji-kun?"

Apparently, he hadn't called out to Hiyori, who was near the entrance, before he left.

"Yeah. He left, apparently on urgent business. He asked me to tell you he'll be back again soon."

"Is that so? That's something to look forward to."

Seeing her gentle smile, it seemed she was genuinely looking forward to his next visit.

I arbitrarily assumed that Hiyori spent the past month all alone.

But in reality, she'd been gradually expanding her circle of friends and found time to spend with Kaneda in the library.

When I thought about it, there was nothing strange about it at all.

Just as I'd changed classes and friends, the number of people I interacted with slightly increased, Hiyori, too, changed since we first met.

She'd met someone new somewhere and was growing closer to that person.

A mere classmate. A mere underclassman, an upperclassman.

From such relationships, they become friends and then best friends.

People much closer to her than I was would appear one after another in Hiyori's future.

Perhaps someone else might be sitting in the empty seat next to her tomorrow—

"..."

Looking at her as she lowered her gaze to her book, I was surprised by my own arbitrary thoughts.

Who was getting close to whom was nothing more than a piece of information.

Something to be judged solely on whether or not it could be used in the future.

And yet, I was indulging in useless and arbitrary speculation.

I was trying to see an invisible someone next to Hiyori.

I didn't know why I'd become unable to see her in the same way I saw other students.

Same sex, opposite sex. Friend, best friend.

I interacted with many students without being bound by things like gender or how close we were.

While there were varying degrees of compatibility, like whether our hobbies matched or if we seemed likely to get along, I basically never accepted or avoided someone for those reasons alone.

However, with this much noise interfering with my thoughts, I had no choice but to admit it.

That Hiyori was perhaps a little different from the frameworks I'd used until then.

It was different from willfully moving a category from right to left.

Something that'd been on the right side until yesterday moved to the left before I knew it.

Just reading books and sharing the same space together filled me with a sense of fulfillment.

If I were to describe it in a word, it was 'happiness'.

That expression was probably the closest fit.

It wasn't as if the time we'd spent together was particularly long, nor had we exchanged many conversations in a short period.

But thinking back, I naturally felt a sense of familiarity with her from early on.

Her name too—it wasn't like I started calling her Hiyori because she asked me to.

In other words, it wasn't a name I used with a purpose.

Before I knew it, I'd been staring intently at Hiyori's face as her gaze fell upon her book.

Hiyori didn't notice my gaze for a while, but in a brief moment, she looked my way and our eyes met as if it were the most natural thing in the world.

"Is something the matter?"

"No..."

Looking at Hiyori's face calmed my heart.

There was no doubt that saying something like that would only make her uncomfortable.

Around just after 6:00 p.m., Hiyori and I left the library and then the school.

"Is it okay if I stop by the library again tomorrow?"

"Of course it is. Besides, you don't need my permission, you know?"

Perhaps finding my attempt to ask for confirmation amusing, she placed a hand to her mouth and chuckled softly.

"Maybe it's because I kind of see the library as your home."

"That's... not entirely wrong, I suppose. I'm here every day unless I have other plans."

I felt like I would mistakenly assume she caught a cold if she wasn't there. After thinking that, I recalled a time when Hiyori had stopped appearing in the library for a while. It was around when the news that Karuizawa and I were dating spread around school. While it was true we were merely reading companions, Hiyori had been considerate by doing things like changing the times she visited.

"Ah—"

At the end of Hiyori's gaze, I found a small pull cart, wheels rattling, slowly making its way toward the main gate.

Many colorful flowers were lined up on its bed, beautiful even from a distance.

As the two of us stood there watching it pass by, the middle-aged woman pulling the cart noticed us and stopped right in front of us.

"I got special permission to sell here today. Would you like to take a look?"

"Is it alright?"

"Of course."

After being spoken to so kindly, Hiyori happily narrowed her eyes and approached the cart's bed. I also stood beside Hiyori and looked down at the flowers.

Keyaki Mall didn't have a flower shop. If you wanted to give flowers for a birthday or the like, you had to get artificial flowers from the general store or order them online. So, it was refreshing to see them being sold like this. From cut flowers like baby's breath to potted hydrangeas. A small number of other assorted plants were also there.

"They're beautiful..."

Hiyori said to the flowers beside me, looking hesitant, as if deciding which one to buy. After waiting a little while, she reached out her hand as though she'd found the one she wanted.

"May I have this one, please?"

What Hiyori pointed to as she spoke was a single, carefully wrapped corn poppy.

"Just one?"

"Yes. I thought it was lovely, precisely because it's a single flower."

"It's not about the number of flowers, young lady."

The clerk said so with a bright smile and explained that it was called a 'single wrap.'

"Then I'll take one of these."

I took out my phone and asked to pay for it.

"Ah, um, no, Ayanokouji-kun. I'll buy it myself—"

"It's fine. I want to give this to you."

I told her that, and just as Hiyori looked up at me, I continued.

"It's an apology for making you wait a month. Though this might not be much of one."

Just a single corn poppy. Price-wise, it didn't even cost 400 points; it was a very cheap purchase.

"That's not true at all. I'm very happy."

After she bowed her head, it seemed to me that her face was slightly flushed when she looked up.

The sky had been dyed by the sunset in an instant; perhaps that was the reason.

"...Then, I gratefully accept."

A voice of gratitude so quiet, one might have missed it if not close by.

After I paid, the clerk handed it to me instead of Hiyori, looking back and forth between us, and then said, "Thank you very much."

We just stood there and quietly watched the pull cart until it was out of sight.

After we were alone again, I handed the single corn poppy I was holding to Hiyori.

"Thank you so much."

"No need to thank me. It's just for my own satisfaction, a selfish apology."

That's how I answered, but the truth was a little different. I simply wanted to give Hiyori a present.

I genuinely want her to be happy.

The corn poppy—a gift given from such an impulsive action.

Clutching that single small flower to her chest, Hiyori stared intently at me.

She was certainly smiling with joy the moment our eyes met.

But as we continued to gaze at each other, her expression gradually began to change.

She showed an unexpected expression.

"Why are you crying?"

Perhaps Hiyori, whose eyes were faintly glistening with tears, hadn't noticed it herself.

She hurriedly wiped at the corners of her eyes with her slender, white fingertips.

"For me, this was supposed to be just another ordinary day until I met you, Ayanokouji-kun. But it's now become such a happy and fulfilling time... it feels like a dream, I can't believe it..."

Her voice, which sounded as if it were squeezed from her very heart, continued.

"I'm so happy... I'm so very happy. That we didn't end up drifting apart, Ayanokouji-kun."

Strangely enough, I was in the exact same state of mind as Hiyori.

"It's much the same for me. This was supposed to end as just another ordinary day. But it's turned into a very fulfilling one—it's true."

If Hiyori's words weren't false, then it meant our feelings were mutual.

For some reason, this supposedly meaningless synchronization felt ticklish and it made me happy.

Beneath the sunset-dyed sky.

I deeply burned the image of her into my mind—clutching the corn poppy, her eyes glistening.

So that, from now on, I could remember it at any time—

Part 3

WHEN I RETURNED to the dorm lobby, Hashimoto, who'd been sitting on a sofa, saw me and stood up.

"Sorry, Shiina. I'm gonna borrow Ayanokouji."

Though he offered a light apology, Hashimoto gave her no room to refuse, but Hiyori showed no sign of displeasure and bowed cheerfully. Then she waved and got on the elevator first.

Hashimoto watched her go with a broad grin, waving back.

"We meet often. Were you waiting for me to come back?"

"Yeah, something like that. Let's take a walk."

He half-forcibly led me out of the lobby and we walked down a path off the school route.

"You're really tolerant of Shiina, or rather, you're pretty close with her, aren't you? You're the one who gave her the flower, right?"

"Why do you think that?"

There was no one else around at the time, so there was no way Hashimoto could've seen me.

"That's not a funny way to play dumb. There's no way it's nothing. Anyone could tell just by seeing how happy she looked holding that flower."

It seemed Hashimoto felt that way after seeing Hiyori and I together.

"You're always going on about 'Shiina, Shiina,' so there's been something on my mind. I figured I had to confirm it today, no matter what."

After a short pause, Hashimoto looked me straight in the eye.

"It'd probably be hard for anyone else to ask, so as the designated bad guy, I'll ask you straight up. Is Shiina someone especially close to you?"

His expression clearly conveyed his seriousness.

"Is it a problem to have a specific person I'm close to?"

"No, I wouldn't go so far as to say it's a problem. But I'm not exactly welcoming it, either."

Hashimoto said, somewhat evasively. When I looked at him, he seemed a bit uncomfortable and averted his gaze.

"It's not just me. Ichinose probably isn't too happy about it either, is she? I've been hearing rumors that Ichinose likes you. The source of the rumor is Class D. In other words, she found out you broke up with Karuizawa and openly declared herself the next girlfriend candidate, right? I thought the way Ichinose looked at you wasn't exactly normal ever since we heard about the alliance together, but...anyway, I was sure you were going to get together with her—or are you dating Ichinose?"

"We're not dating."

This should've been the answer Hashimoto wanted, but instead of being pleased to hear it, he scowled.

"...And why's that? If it's Ichinose, you couldn't ask for a better person to date, right? Honestly, even I, who've barely had any contact with her, would say yes in a heartbeat if she confessed to me. She's on that level, you know? There's no reason to turn her down, is there?"

"Sorry to burst your bubble while you're getting all worked up, but I haven't been confessed to."

"Even so, all you have to do is make a move, right? She already likes you, so you should just go for it without hesitation. Ah, I don't mean that in a weird way."

He hurriedly denied it, but that was a trivial distinction.

"Ichinose and I have an alliance. Nothing more, nothing less."

"So you're saying you're just pragmatic allies? For the foreseeable future, too?"

After asking that, he continued without waiting for my reply.

"So then... does that mean you're going after Shiina right now?"

"I'm surprised. I didn't think you cared so much about other people's love lives."

"To be precise, I'm just worried that those feelings might affect the outcome of the class competition."

It was my business who I dated, but he was worried I might let my personal feelings get in the way.

That seemed to be what he feared.

It was a very Hashimoto-like way of thinking.

"Nah, I don't even need to hear your answer; I already know. You cut ties with Horikita and the others you shared two years of hardship with to join us. I

don't doubt for a second that your actions would change just because you got involved with one or two girls like Ichinose or Shiina."

"And yet, you seem awfully hung up on it. Especially when it comes to Hiyori."

Hashimoto was clearly placing more weight on it versus the situation with Ichinose.

"From an outsider's perspective, it's always felt to me like you treat Shiina differently."

Hashimoto concluded by saying that if it was just a needless worry, then that was great, but it was already certain that I was, in fact, treating Hiyori in an indescribable way.

That said, I wouldn't let her existence affect the class's performance. But speaking purely from personal feelings, I didn't want to treat Hiyori carelessly.

I see.

"So that's what it is."

"What's 'what it is'?"

"Perhaps I'm in love with Hiyori."

"...Huh?"

"I can't say for sure what this feeling is just yet. But I might at least be harboring, or starting to harbor, feelings for Hiyori that I don't have for anyone else."

The unease and errors I'd felt up to that point and their cause.

The reason it hadn't been easy to find was because it was something outside my empirical rules.

"W-Whoa, whoa, are you serious? Nah, what're you talking about, like this is your first time feeling something? You were just dating Karuizawa a little while ago, weren't you?"

If the emotion I just identified is truly budding within me.

I'm even amazed by the strength of this thing called emotion and its unpredictable timing.

A desire to know more began to overflow.

If I traced it back, would I be able to see it?

When did I start to become conscious of Hiyori?

What was different about her compared to other people?

I want to try digging as deep as I can.

—No, for now, I should probably stop these unnecessary delusions.

Coming up with an answer right now, as if deducing a strategy, would've been far too hasty.

No matter how it turned out, that emotion was extremely fascinating as a subject for experimentation.

"Then... depending on the situation, are you planning on dating Shiina?"

"Didn't you believe that my actions wouldn't change? So why are you sticking your nose so deep into someone else's love life?"

"Well, just this once, y'know... It's my view on love, I guess, but it's screaming at me that I absolutely have to check."

"Your view on love, huh? Do you have a corresponding amount of experience with it?"

I asked this while keeping the expelled Maezono in mind.

"Now you're underestimatin' me a bit, Ayanokouji. It's not like I can brag about it, but between middle and high school, I've dated two... no, to be precise, three people."

I surmised that the reason he was cagey about the last one was because he was referring to Maezono.

"So? Are you planning to date Shiina? If you can't answer, that's fine too—"

"Whether we date or not involves the other person. It isn't something I can answer."

"Hah, well, yeah. But from the sound of it... if this is really your first time feeling this way, that'd make it your first love, right?"

"Perhaps."

Right then, I possessed no way to deny it.

"No matter how many people you date, you only get one first love. And what's more, you almost never end up with that person. My own first love was a classmate in elementary school, but I couldn't even talk to her properly. If you treat your first love like that, it might feel romantic, or special, but in reality, it ain't all that. Guys are especially simple, y'know, we've got a tendency to unconditionally fall for any cute girl."

I fully understood that regardless of whether the object of affection was a man or a woman, the majority of people tended to be attracted to those with

superior looks. Even looking at TV or magazines, the proportion of handsome men and beautiful women who caught the eye and gathered attention was overwhelmingly high.

"So just go ahead and ditch that first love stuff. If a reasonably cute girl falls for you, your tenth love or your twentieth love can start just like that."

Despite his roundabout expressions, Hashimoto's way of thinking remained consistent.

"Whether it's really your first love or whatever, stay away from Shiina. This is my strongest advice to you as your strategist, as your friend, and as a comrade aiming for Class A."

Hashimoto was strongly wary of my relationship with Hiyori developing in an unexpected way.

"It's not a difficult concept, is it? You can get back together with Karuizawa, you can date Ichinose. Heck, any other girl would be fine. Just, not Shiina."

It was clear that by deliberately repeating himself, Hashimoto was watching my reaction. It was plain to see that he would take either excessive agreement or denial as an unfavorable sign.

"I understand your concern very well. However, you're counting your chickens before they hatch."

"—I can trust you, right?"

"You probably wouldn't believe me even if I answered, but you can trust me."

For me, Hiyori's existence was becoming indispensable.

An existence that made me learn an unfamiliar emotion.

I couldn't help but want to find out whether or not I could be certain it was what Hashimoto called a first love.

I wanted to experience being swallowed by the irresistible waves of emotion and see how I would be carried away.

I wanted to take both myself and the other person apart and seek the answer to the very end.

It was true that I would remember his warning as a warning, but I had no intention of stopping.

Because I was already getting ready to dive in as deep as I could.

Chapter 7:
The Observer

A WEEK HAD finally passed since the exam announcement and the Thursday of the reveal arrived.

The only slightly worrisome elements were the encounter with Ike and his friends at the cafe and Hoshinomiya-sensei's approach; I received no reports of trouble from any other classmates.

The matter with Hoshinomiya-sensei was unfortunate, as it only served as a disadvantage to the alliance, but it was also a reflection of just how hungry she was for victory.

The exam was truly a neck-and-neck race. In truth, it was completely unclear if any gap had formed at all. The students of Ryuuen's class also had an exemplary week, remaining calm and taking no action to entrap students from other classes. It seemed that the outcome would be decided by a truly trivial difference.

As I waited in the classroom that morning for my classmates to arrive, a bewildered-looking Hashimoto came hurrying in.

"This is a real pain, Ayanokouji. At the eleventh hour, it's confirmed that Rokkaku and Yano will be absent."

"Ryuuen?"

"I suspected that right off the bat, too, but apparently there wasn't any real contact. They're saying they just got sick and have a fever."

According to Hashimoto's explanation, the two of them had an idea what caused the fever; apparently, when Rokkaku and the others were shopping a few days ago, a sick-looking employee at the mall sneezed on them.

From what I heard, it seemed like an unavoidable, unforeseen event.

Rokkaku and the others also understood the cause of their poor health and moreover, they hadn't done anything reckless like forcing themselves to come to school, so there was nothing to blame them for.

"I'd love it if today's tardiness and absences don't affect the exam... but things are never that simple, are they?"

"Probably."

Presumably, the scope of the exam extended right up to that morning's attendance, covering the entire week.

If that was the case, the absences might have dealt a fatal blow in such a neck-and-neck competition.

"At this point, all we can do is hope your 90% prediction is wrong, Ayanokouji, and that this exam has nothing to do with it."

Hashimoto pinned his hopes on the few remaining unknown rules and details of the exam.

"I don't think it's a concern with this class, but make sure to tell everyone not to slander the two who are absent under any circumstances. Even if we lose because of it, it won't affect the general state of the class."

"I figured you'd say that, so I've already sent out the notice."

Phone in hand, Hashimoto showed me the screen, indicating he just sent the message.

After that, the classmates who arrived in the classroom seemed to have learned of the situation; though they appeared slightly disheartened and shaken, they quickly composed themselves and went to their seats with expressions of acceptance.

They understood very well that panicking wouldn't get the class points back.

Furthermore, not abandoning the hope Hashimoto had for an unrelated exam, I could see several students tackling their studies.

Part 1

ICHINOSE INVITED ME to have a little discussion about the exam results after school, so for the first time in a week, I headed to the front of the gym on the second floor of Keyaki Mall. There, I spotted Watanabe from behind, standing near the entrance and looking up at the gym. He then paced back and forth, crossing the gym's entrance over and over again. But he never went inside; I could see him repeat this behavior.

"What are you doing?"

"Wh-whoa, Ayanokouji!? H-hey, long time no see. Wh-what a coincidence... haha."

Showing blatant agitation with slightly broken speech, Watanabe raised his hand and answered.

"I was just thinkin' about maybe joinin' the gym, y'know? Like, I've got this newfound desire to work out and get lean? And I was wonderin' if going to the gym with Amikura would mean we could spend more time together. Well, a mix of things like that?"

Neither was a bad thing, but it was clear that the latter objective was the bigger one.

"If that's your plan, you should just go ahead and join. It'd be nice for me, too, since having you join would mean another person to talk to."

"R-really? In that case, can I just say you were the one who invited me!?"

It seemed he didn't so much want to take the final step himself as he wanted someone to give him a push.

"I have no problem with that at all."

When I readily agreed, Watanabe seemed genuinely happy, his eyes sparkling with delight.

"I'm meeting Ichinose after this, but do you want to join right now, maybe do a trial run? I'm guessing Amikura will probably be there, too."

"A-a trial by fire right off the bat, huh...!?"

For a moment, it crossed my mind that he might flinch, but Watanabe nodded as if he'd made up his mind.

However, as he faced the gym, his brave advance came to a halt.

"...Isn't this a little too obvious?"

"Well, I can't deny that. Girls especially seem to be perceptive when it comes to romance. If you, who's had nothing to do with the gym until now, suddenly joined the group, it's conceivable that Ichinose, or in some cases, Amikura herself, might get suspicious."

I explained this to Watanabe, mixing in my own analysis, which was gradually improving.

"That's no good! S-seriously, I can't have Amikura finding out at this stage!"

After letting his imagination run a little, he seemed to have concluded that he couldn't hide how suspicious he looked.

"Letting her know you like her is also a valid strategy, you know."

"M-maybe, but I'm not a veteran like you, Ayanokouji... I'm like a hero in an RPG who hasn't even left the first village yet, you know? It's impossible at level one..."

I didn't quite understand his analogy, but it seemed he still wanted to avoid letting Amikura know his feelings.

"Should you hold off on joining then?"

"Ugh... If I can, I wanna have as many chances to talk to Amikura as possible... but still..."

"In that case, it's a bit roundabout, but there is a way to camouflage your objective."

"Camouflage?"

"It's an exaggeration to say 'hide a tree in a forest,' but you could just get two or three other people besides yourself to join the gym at the same time. If you're just one of several people who were invited, it'll be harder for her to figure it out."

"Ooh, that's a great idea. Is there anyone from your class you could ask, Ayanokouji?"

"No, it's better to avoid Class C. To join Ichinose and Amikura's circle naturally, it's best to select people from the same class."

Besides, involving Class C would make problems more likely to arise when the framework of the alliance was removed.

"I see... It's true that it's more natural to get close to a classmate... but is there anyone who'd join if I asked..."

This was the first time I'd interacted with Watanabe since my class transfer, but he didn't mention my move from Class A to C at all. It seemed less like he

was deliberately avoiding a sore subject and more like he wasn't that concerned about it.

"I don't know much about Class D, but what about Shibata? As a member of the soccer club, he probably doesn't mind physical activity and at the gym, he could further build up his body—"

"That's absolutely impossible."

Watanabe's eyes flew open as he grabbed both my shoulders, cutting me off as if to say, "Don't say another word."

"It's impossible?"

"That's just cruel, Ayanokouji... The fact that you're sayin' it without even knowing why just makes it more infuriatingly impossible... If Shibata saw you and Ichinose together, he'd cry..."

"Hm...?"

After saying it was impossible, he muttered something in a very quiet voice, but I couldn't quite catch it.

"Look, he could become a rival for Amikura's affection, right? Shibata's surprisingly popular with the girls."

"I see. I hadn't considered that perspective."

I had next to no information on who in Class D was interested in whom.

"But I can't think of anyone else who'd do it. It costs money to join, too."

It was true that joining out of inertia or just to be sociable, without any real interest, carried its own risks.

"In that case, I have a clever idea. Provided he won't be a potential rival for you, of course."

"Who is it?"

"Kanzaki and Himeno. Then Hamaguchi. Should be okay with these three, right?"

"What a mismatched trio, huh? Himeno's a girl, and it's not like Kanzaki and Hamaguchi are the type to be rivals in love. But I can't picture them going to the gym at all."

"It's not as surprising as you might think. Especially if Kanzaki's motivated, there's a chance the negotiation could work out."

"Is that... so?"

Watanabe tilted his head, not quite understanding.

"If it's alright with you, Watanabe, I was thinking of talking to them. Is that okay?"

"Well, sure."

I intended to use Kanzaki and the others to bring about a change in Ichinose, but the fact that she evolved beyond his expectations would surely be a joyous thing for Kanzaki as well, though he probably strongly doubted how genuine that evolution was.

The fact that he hadn't approached me despite hearing about the alliance served as proof of that.

Up until now, we only exchanged occasional pleasantries, but from here on, it would be desirable to get closer and spend as much time as possible talking over the next few months.

No matter how much Ichinose cast aside her hesitation, she couldn't win on her own.

It was essential to raise the level of students like Kanzaki, Himeno, and of course, Watanabe and Amikura.

Using the gym as a meeting place with Class D was an on-the-spot idea, but if it worked out well, it might not be a bad thing.

"For now, hold off on joining today and give me a little time. I'll somehow get Kanzaki and the others to join the gym and try to create an opportunity for you to naturally get closer to Amikura."

"O-oh. Thanks, Ayanokouji. You're a good guy, you know that?"

He tried to suppress his happiness, then went down the stairs from the second floor, where the gym was, to the first floor.

The fact that his steps seemed to have a little skip in them was probably proof of his anticipation.

There was still a little while before Ichinose would arrive, but I decided to change and start my workout.

As I was showing my membership card at the reception to check in, a student came in behind me.

"...Hey..."

It was Utomiya from Class 2-C. I'd never seen him at the gym before, but was he perhaps a member? As if he thought he was being scrutinized, he spoke uncomfortably.

"I was just a little curious, so I came to have a look. Are you... a member here, senpai?"

Was he hoping to join? Perhaps a new breeze was blowing into the sparsely populated gym.

"Yeah. A friend invited me a little while ago and I started coming."

"I see... I get it."

It was painfully obvious from his attitude that he had no interest in the fact that I came here or what impression I had of the gym.

"They offer a free trial, so if you're interested, you should give it a try."

I told him anyway, even though I thought it might be meddling.

"I'll think about it."

And, just as I'd imagined, the reply came back with a cold expression, one that looked like he had no intention of thinking about it at all.

Perhaps he was displeased at being seen considering joining the gym, because he turned right back around and left.

"That was Utomiya-kun, right? Are you two on bad terms? It looked pretty tense."

Akiyama-san, who happened to be passing by, asked me with a wry smile.

"I don't mean for it to be, but I can't say we're on friendly terms, to be polite."

In most cases, when I talked with Utomiya, Tsubaki was often with him and we rarely ever spoke one-on-one.

"But I'm surprised you knew Utomiya's name."

"He's been coming here for the last two days straight, and I've seen him at the reception desk or the entrance like just now, so I've had a few chances to talk to him."

"So he's really considering joining?"

"I wonder. That might be part of it, but I think he's probably more concerned about his kouhai-chan."

"His kouhai?"

"There's a first-year girl who was brought here by Utomiya-kun and joined recently. She just joined two days ago, but they seemed pretty close. Maybe he was worried about her?"

Rather than having met after he became a second-year, perhaps they were acquaintances from before who ended up enrolling at ANHS?

"Looks like she hasn't come yet today, though~"

"I see."

However, if he was acquainted with this kouhai, there was no need to come all the way to the gym to see her.

If he had some business, he could just contact her on his phone. Considering that, it could be that they had only just met and hadn't yet exchanged contact information directly.

"By the way, that girl is an amazing athlete. The first day, a crowd gathered when she was on the treadmill, so I took a look too, and she was maintaining a 20-kilometer pace for several minutes. And she was perfectly fine training after that. Mashima-sensei got really into it, too."

Well, normally, you wouldn't come to a gym and run at 20 kilometers per hour.

If your timing was off by even a single step, there was a risk of falling, and since it didn't stop immediately even when the stop button was pressed, the emergency stop couldn't keep up. It seemed to have limited applications, such as for those with experience in track and field, soccer, or martial arts to use for a moment of intense sprint training.

For a first-year high school student, fifteen or sixteen years old—and a girl at that—to be able to handle it meant she was remarkably talented.

In fact, there'd been children in the White Room who dropped out, unable to achieve that level.

In any case, it probably meant that an interesting talent joined the gym.

But what was Utomiya's reason for taking an interest in that girl?

As I made some unkind speculations about it—

"Perhaps a storm of love is brewing."

Akiyama-san said so and laughed, her eyes narrowing happily.

I see. It might have been another one of those things, like Watanabe's feelings or the boys' maneuvering for Shiraishi.

Romance, something I would never have known about if I hadn't started dating Karuizawa.

And then, the image of Hiyori surfaced in my mind.

Through experience, I was becoming more sensitive to the romantic developments concerning myself and those around me.

"Ah, right... Um, there's just something I wanted to ask, if that's all right?"

"What is it?"

"Um, about Mashima-sensei... How should I put it... Is my impression of him the right one? It's not like he's actually a player, is it?"

"While I cannot definitively deny the possibility that he possesses such a side, I do believe he's a reliable teacher. I don't think he's so different from the impression you have of him."

"I-Is that so? Thank you."

It wasn't as if there'd been any major developments between the two. Rather, Akiyama-san's demeanor was such that it made me think there might be some progress between them in the future.

Inside the gym, there was no sign of Koenji or the notable first-year and the gym was deserted.

Part 2

AFTER WORKING UP a good sweat, I left the gym with Ichinose and Amikura.

"Alright, I'm gonna make a little detour on my way home," Amikura announced as soon as we stepped outside, then promptly put some distance between us, waving as she headed down the escalator.

"She was in quite a hurry. Is she meeting up with someone?"

"Mm, I think she was just being considerate. So that you and I could talk alone, Ayanokouji-kun."

Was it out of concern for the leaders of allied classes to deepen their friendship? Or some other kind of consideration? It wasn't particularly difficult to imagine the real reason.

"If you'd like, how about we walk home together? Ah... saying it like that makes it hard for you to say no, doesn't it?"

"No, it's fine. I was planning on heading straight home today anyway. Besides, we haven't had a chance to talk about the exam."

"Really? That's great, I'm glad."

I left Keyaki Mall with Ichinose, who looked up at me and smiled, her eyes narrowing slightly.

The time was past 6:30 p.m., but it wasn't dark outside.

It was proof that winter's shadow had completely retreated and the daylight had begun to linger, one step at a time.

"The outcome this time was unfortunate, wasn't it?"

"Even if you're thorough about managing your health, some things are just out of your control. It can't be helped."

Just as every class imagined, the recent exam took place over the course of one week.

The evaluation was based on how well we adhered to proper daily conduct and school rules, and although we weren't told the detailed point distribution, we were informed that all four classes were more or less neck and neck.

The results were: Ichinose's class in first place with 50 Class Points. Horikita's and Ryuuen's classes were in second place, each receiving 10 Class

Points. My class, with two absentees, came in last with a deduction of 25 points. It was a relief that Hoshinomiya-sensei's outburst didn't have a negative impact.

Horikita Class 1240 points

Ryuuen Class 1081 points

Ayanokouji Class 867 points

Ichinose Class 864 points

There was no change in the class rankings, and the gap from Class A to Class D remained mostly unchanged.

"It's not a problem in the grand scheme of things. It's a gap we can close if we aim to win the next special exam."

"I see. That's very reassuring. I'll do my best to help out as much as I can, too."

"Of course, I'm counting on you. More importantly, I have something else I'd like to discuss. I'm thinking of getting more people to join the gym. Is it alright if I invite them?"

"I think that's a great idea! I was actually getting a little worried about things like sales, since the number of members is so low."

Ichinose readily expressed her approval, agreeing it was a good plan.

"But you don't need my permission or anything."

"That's not quite right. The students I'm thinking of inviting are from your class, Ichinose."

"Oh, really? Who are they?"



"The three I'm thinking of asking are Watanabe, Kanzaki, and Himeno."

I consciously relayed the names in a natural flow, so as not to hint at any particular intention with the order or combination.

And I deliberately chose not to mention Hamaguchi's name.

However, it was a petty trick at best. Upon hearing the three names, Ichinose smiled.

"That's an interesting trio. Kanzaki-kun has seemed a little distant from me lately, and on the other hand, it seems he's gotten closer with Himeno-san, as the two of them have apparently been seen talking together at times. I'm aware they were trying hard to do something when I was being so unreliable. If we're at the gym together, we might be able to remove that unnecessary barrier, don't you think? But in that case, wouldn't it be better to invite Hamaguchi-kun as well?"

It seemed she completely read my intentions. And she had a magnificent grasp on the state of her own class.

"And Watanabe-kun simply wants to get closer to Mako-chan—I guess that's about it, right?"

"Impressive. I guess it was obvious."

While I was sincere about wanting to liven up the gym, she saw through the reasons for my choices all too easily.

"I can figure that much out. But, yes, I'd totally welcome them. I think Watanabe-kun will be fine as long as we just pretend not to notice his true motives, but... I wonder if Kanzaki-kun and the others will agree to join?"

"They'll join. No, I believe they have to."

"You're right. It doesn't have to be the gym later on, but I've been feeling that we really do need to unite the class in the truest sense, and sooner rather than later."

"In that case, I'll go ahead and ask them without hesitation."

"Okay, thank you. I'm really happy for your support, Ayanokouji-kun."

After Ichinose, standing to my right, gave me an unreserved smile, the back of her left hand brushed against the back of my right for an instant.

Then her hand slowly drew near again and our fingertips touched and intertwined.

However, she reflexively realized it was wrong and hastily pulled away.

Her cheeks reddened, and she averted her gaze. But her eyes slowly returned to me.

"I-I'm sorry... I'm sorry. I just... couldn't help wanting to touch you... even though we're just friends, aren't we."

Even though we knew everything about each other, our relationship was that of friends.

Even though I knew it was only a difference in a single expression, a large, insurmountable wall stood between us.

It was easy enough to take her wavering hand.

I was sure that Ichinose herself wouldn't have minded the action.

I didn't dislike her personality, her body, or her thoughts.

In fact, it was true that she seemed far more charming than some half-assed person.

As I stared at her, Ichinose shyly met my gaze as well.

She also possessed the great capacity to accept me, even knowing a part of my darkness.

And yet—

I would have denied that my heart was being swayed by romance at that very moment.

I recalled the other day: the library after school with Hiyori and the sight of her holding the flower.

A space enveloped in a sense of bliss, a feeling I never experienced before.

I clearly desired what I had felt on that day, at that time—an emotion I had no memory of experiencing.

"—Who are you thinking about?"

As if she slipped into my thoughts through our meeting gaze, her lips moved to form those words.

"What makes you think that?"

"Because you looked so happy, I suppose."

Ichinose had always been skilled at reading the atmosphere and understanding people, but since that night, her perception had sharpened dramatically.

"I'm sorry, you don't have to answer. It's not something a friend should be prying into... right?"

She showed a slightly lonely expression but quickly returned to her usual self.

Eventually, we arrived in front of the dorms, keeping a slight distance between us.

"I'll be waiting for Kanzaki-kun and the others' reply, okay?"

"Yeah—"

After watching her back as she hurried into the dorm ahead of me, I lifted my gaze slightly and stared at the sky, stained by the sunset.

The joy of learning a new emotion.

And what kind of effect that emotion would have on myself, and on others.

Would what came next be prosperity, or ruin?

Or perhaps, something else entirely?

I was, at that moment, living a very fulfilling—contented moment.

For that, I had to be truly, deeply grateful.

Part 3

A LITTLE PAST 4:30 p.m. on Thursday, around the time Ayanokouji met up with Ichinose and the others.

Having received a message from a certain individual, Shiraishi appeared at the restaurant alone.

At that hour, most students gathered at the cafe, so the restaurant, where meals were the main focus, was comparatively less busy, with empty seats always standing out.

She sat alone at a table in the back and ordered a cup of black tea from her tablet.

The flavor was not something one could praise, even out of politeness; it tasted like it'd been brewed from a cheap teabag.

Shiraishi imagined that if it were of the same quality as the cafe, the place would have been bustling at this hour as well. Still, it wasn't that there were no customers at all, just a sparse few. Then, just as her tea was delivered, another student came in and sat down at the table next to Shiraishi's.

From over her shoulder, she could hear the electronic chime of a tablet being operated and an order being placed.

"Have I kept you waiting?"

The charming words came from behind her. A voice, clear and unadulterated, unpolished yet powerful, reached Shiraishi's ears.

"Not at all. I only just arrived myself."

"Are you really sure this was the right place to meet?"

"Yes. It's easy for our voices to carry even when we're back-to-back with the sofa in between, don't you think?"

"It's true that it's easier to talk since there are few customers, but on the flip side, that means we inevitably stand out. Anyone who enters can spot us easily, and it's unavoidable that we'll leave an impression."

There was no panic in her voice, but she gave off a strong sense of caution.

The situation, where she could only hear her companion's voice, worked to Shiraishi's advantage.

There was no way for the person in question to know that she'd been placed in such a unique environment.

"Visually speaking, that may be so. However, it's impossible for anyone to imagine our relationship from this back-to-back situation. The fact that we might catch someone's eye also means that they catch ours. As long as we remain calm, there won't be any problems."

They'd simply come to the unpopular restaurant individually. Seeing two students from different classes—no, different school years—the number of people who could imagine they arranged to meet and were conversing on purpose was extremely limited.

"I think an ordinary student would just assume we're here waiting for two different people. However, there are a few individuals I need to be wary of. If one of them, Ayanokouji-senpai, were to see this..."

"Even if he didn't understand it just from witnessing the situation, he would still unconsciously commit this pairing to memory and likely retrieve it later as needed."

On that day, at that time, Shiraishi and Nanase sat back-to-back in the restaurant. Had they been pretending to be strangers while having a conversation they didn't want overheard? He would begin a line of deduction an ordinary person could never reach.

"If you understood that, may I ask why you still took that risk?"

"The risk you're concerned about, Nanase-san, has already been eliminated. Ayanokouji-kun just entered the gym with Ichinose-san. At the very least, he won't be out for another hour."

"Surely you didn't ask Ayanokouji-senpai directly, or have someone else find out for you, did you? Even that would be cause for suspicion."

Her tone of voice remained the same, but Shiraishi didn't miss the faint anxiety it contained.

"Don't worry. The only words we exchanged today were morning greetings."

"Then how did you ascertain Ayanokouji-senpai's location?"

"How I procured that information is a trade secret."

She used a line she heard from Ayanokouji himself during a previous exchange.

"Forgive my rudeness, but if you used your friend Nishikawa-senpai, I believe she would be ill-suited for the task. There's no way Ayanokouji-senpai wouldn't notice if she carelessly tailed him. It's entirely plausible he would

suspect it was your doing, Shiraishi-senpai, since you two are close. Or does she perhaps possess some hidden talent?"

There was a subtle shift in Nanase's speech that an ordinary person wouldn't have noticed.

Only when she spoke the name Nishikawa was there a truly faint, yet deliberate, emphasis.

"You're aware that she isn't capable of handling such a major role, aren't you? My apologies, but Nishikawa-san is merely a friend. Your attempt to read so deeply into things is meaningless."

"...Is that so?"

"It's all well and good to meticulously check for any missteps on my part, but you've exposed your own foolishness quite spectacularly, Nanase-san. To let an uninvolved student discover the existence of your second phone and then to be overheard speaking with someone who was supposed to have left the school."

"You're right. I was careless in that regard."

"I've taken measures to sufficiently silence Hashimoto-kun and Morishita-san, who happened to witness it. It's possible it may eventually reach Ayanokouji-kun's ears, but for the time being, it should be fine."

"So you took care of it for me. Thank you very much."

Shiraishi picked up the saucer with her left hand, then placed the fingers of her right hand on the handle of the cup.

"Shall we get to the point now? Contacting me is a clear violation of the rules."

"I am fully aware that up until now, you've lived your life at this school as a completely ordinary student. However—I, too, have a job that only I can do, so this was unavoidable. Please, I need your help."

"What is it you want me to do?"

"I want to get Ayanokouji-senpai expelled. As soon as possible, and at a time he can't predict."

Closing her eyes, Shiraishi mulled over Nanase's words, letting them sink in deep.

It was a tone of impatience, not one of deceit. She assessed its credibility within herself.

"I sympathize with your feelings, but I must decline to offer my assistance."

"Why...is that?"

"That's because I am, strictly speaking, an observer. From the very beginning, I was never given any role beyond that. It is precisely because I didn't get involved in anything for these past two years that, from Ayanokouji-kun's perspective, I was nothing more than 'Female Student A' from another class—"

"Then why have you started to close the distance now? Even if he doesn't know who you are, Shiraishi-senpai, he might recognize that you're not an ordinary student."

"I suppose so. But it can't be helped, can it? Through an ironic twist of fate, he and I ended up in the same class. By chance, we ended up in adjacent seats. And by chance, an opportunity arose for the two of us to speak in the classroom one morning... Given all that, there's no way I can possibly suppress this impulse..."

Shiraishi smiled as she recalled that event, the morning they'd spoken alone in the classroom.

"I will spend my days with Ayanokouji-kun as a classmate. For now, I just want to purely enjoy this environment. Nothing more, nothing less, simply as an observer. Besides, that nuisance, Sakayanagi-san, has voluntarily withdrawn from the school."

"Is that so... I understand. It seems it will be difficult to rely on you as things stand, Shiraishi-senpai."

To take a breath, Nanase took a sip of the freshly delivered iced milk through a straw.

"Have your fellow students also been given a similar role, Shiraishi-senpai? That is, the role of an observer?"

"Who knows. The possibility that they've been given the same role as me isn't zero, but I don't know. All that is required of us is to spend three years as ordinary students. It's as simple as that."

"I will take action while Ayanokouji-senpai is still within reach. If I cannot receive your cooperation, Shiraishi-senpai, then I may have to find one of your fellow students who will cooperate."

"Even if you threaten me, cooperation is a difficult matter."

"I am from that side."[1]

"Aren't you leaving a little something out? 'Supposedly,' isn't it?"

"...My apologies. It is true that my position may be rather ambiguous. However, isn't it precisely because my position is different that I'm not in violation of the rules?"

"That's true. The reason I accepted your invitation today, Nanase-san, was because I wanted to reassure you regarding the matter with Hashimoto-kun and Morishita-san. I have no intention of cooperating in any other matter."

"At least give me some information... Please, just disclose the names of your associates. After that, we'll handle—"

"If you wish to know, I suggest you ask your superiors directly. Tsukishiro-san, was it? You have someone reliable you can turn to, don't you? Not that I'm fond of him."

Shiraishi placed her finished cup on its saucer and rose from the sofa.

"I understand that you will not be cooperating for the time being. However, there is just one thing I'd like you to remember. May I state it?"

"What is it?"

"That if I am expelled before Ayanokouji-senpai's fate is decided... things may very well head in a direction that Shirogane-sensei would not desire—I ask that you please bear this in mind."

"Very well. I shall keep it in mind."

Shiraishi answered as such without so much as a nod, and left the restaurant before Nanase.

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[1]: Nanaese's statement "I am from that side" (そちら側の人間です) is her saying she's aligned with the anti-Ayanokoji faction ("superiors", Tsukishiro etc.) Shiraishi responds with 一応 which means "for the time being", "tentatively", or "In principle" she is essentially saying "Your position isn't as strong as you're making it sound", she dismisses Nanase's declaration.

Epilogue:
Another Story Begins

IT WAS JUST before 11:00 a.m. on a Saturday in late May when I left my room for a meeting.

And just as I left the dorm lobby, the person I was there to meet called out to me.

"Good morning, Horikita-san."

Karuizawa-san, who seemed to have arrived a little earlier than planned, was smiling.

"Good morning. I apologize for contacting you so suddenly last night."

As I'd just mentioned, I had sent the message asking to see Karuizawa-san last night. It wouldn't have been surprising if she had plans, given how many friends she had, but she readily agreed to meet.

"It's totally fine! I mean, getting an invitation from you, Horikita-san, was kinda new and exciting, so I was happy."

She was looking forward to it, she added with a smile.

"But...why are you in your uniform?"

"I have a Student Council matter I need to attend to, at two o'clock."

Entering school grounds in casual clothes was prohibited. I explained that it would be a hassle to go out before noon in casual wear, only to have to return to change into my uniform. On days off, some students came to school for club activities, so even though we were a minority, I wasn't worried that I would be the only one standing out.

"Being student council president sounds like a lot of work. I could never do something like that."

She said, "No way, no way," while gazing toward Keyaki Mall.

"So, what's the plan? I'm actually kinda looking forward to you escorting me around, Horikita-san."

"If that's what you were expecting, then I'm afraid I'll have to apologize. I didn't invite you to hang out for fun."

As I offered my light apology, Karuizawa-san's eyes widened, as if she'd just realized something.

"Eh, ah... Don't tell me... you have something you want to know about Ayanokouji-kun?"

"You're sharp. That is one of my objectives."

"Well, the special exam just ended smoothly and all, so I kinda figured that might be it. But even so, there's no guarantee I can actually help, you know?"

"I understand that. But if it's something even you don't know, then I can give up."

After all, among everyone I knew, she was without a doubt the one who knew Ayanokouji-kun best.

"Okay. Then ask me anything. If it's something I know, I'll answer whatever!"

After saying that, she seemed to have second thoughts, scratching her head in a fluster.

"Sorry, maybe 'anything' is a bit much. But I can talk about most things, so, yeah."

Karuizawa-san corrected herself, her face turning red.

It was a slightly curious reaction, but it would be more than enough if she simply told me what she could.



"Thank you."

Karuizawa-san's devoted—no, positive response put my heart at ease.

"I have no intention of keeping secrets or telling you any clumsy lies, either. I'll tell you everything about why I want to know about Ayanokouji-kun and what my thoughts are, so I'd like you to hear me out."

"Of course. I might not look it, but I'm great at keeping secrets, so bring it on!"

Trusting her, I told her that as a first step toward my goal of defeating Ayanokouji-kun, I planned to start by learning more about him, mentioning Kushida-san and Ibuki-san's names as well.

And that to do so, I was also thinking of looking into his roots.

I explained all of this to Karuizawa-san.

"I see. I... Yeah, since before I started dating Kiyotaka, ah—I mean, Ayanokouji-kun, I used to wonder a lot about things like what he was like in middle school, so I get it. Oh, and sorry, I might still slip up and call him by his first name."

"I don't mind that at all. If it's difficult for you to use his surname, you're welcome to do otherwise."

"Nn-nn, this is about setting boundaries. For me... you know?"

"I see—"

"I was dating Ayanokouji-kun, but to be honest, I doubt I have much more information than you do. I tried asking him about his past a few times, but I don't think he ever really gave me a straight answer."

"Things like which prefecture he lived in, or where his middle school was?"

"Yeah. I asked about things like what foods he likes and dislikes, or his taste in clothes, but—"

As she made a gesture of recollection, Karuizawa-san began telling me what she saw and heard for herself.

Part 1

WE ARRIVED AT Keyaki Mall. Continuing our conversation, we strolled idly through the mall. It was just as I was thinking of suggesting we get lunch in a little while.

"Actually, there's one more reason I called you here. And I was lucky enough to find her."

"Huh? Whaddya mean?"

To the head-tilting Karuizawa-san, I simply directed my gaze in that direction and had her follow.

"...Amasawa-san?"

She muttered the name upon spotting the back of a lone student with red twin-tails walking ahead of us.

"Amasawa Ichika-san has a connection to Ayanokouji-kun's past. That's why I'm investigating her right now."

"Ahh... So that's how it is."

Next to me, Karuizawa-san showed no surprise, but rather a look of understanding.

"Did you perhaps know about their relationship?"

"Nah, not at all. But I've seen Ayanokouji-kun and Amasawa-san talking a little bit. I kinda had a feeling it wasn't just some simple senpai-and-kouhai relationship they made at this school."

It didn't seem like there was a difference in the information we had, but her opinion was reassuring.

The fact that we sensed the same thing gave me encouragement to continue with the tedious investigation.

"Are we gonna tail her now? Hey, should we?"

"...You seem awfully excited about this."

"I don't mind doing spy-like stuff. I mean, is there anyone who actually dislikes it?"

Well, if I thought of it as an extension of a game, perhaps it wouldn't be so bad...

Our target likely had a connection to Ayanokouji-kun and moreover, she was considerably skilled.

Knowing that there was a high probability of losing our only lead if we failed, I found it impossible to enjoy.

"For now, I'll tell you what I've gleaned from observing Amasawa-san lately."

It was something I'd noticed from watching Amasawa-san after school over the past few days.

She usually acted alone most of the time, and I never saw her spending time with classmates or friends. Of course, she would respond with a smile if spoken to by anyone, boy or girl, but she would immediately return to being alone and would never join the group that had approached her.

It appeared to be her stance not to form any particularly close relationships.

That preference for solitude seemed somewhat similar to Ayanokouji-kun's, but perhaps that was a stretch. In his case, it wasn't that he didn't make friends; if anything, he was the type who couldn't, even if he wanted to.

"That was an act... No, it couldn't have been, could it? Surely not."

"I don't think that was an act. That similarity seems like another thing they have in common."

Setting aside how pathetic it was that I hadn't known that about him, his way of interacting with people really wasn't very skillful. That was probably his true self.

Time passed as we continued to follow Amasawa-san's back from a distance.

Ideally, I should've spoken with her directly.

But the world wasn't so kind that she would talk honestly just like that.

Another person, this time a male student, called out to Amasawa-san.

They only spoke for about five seconds and it appeared to be little more than a greeting.

Even so, I made a point to remember every student who was on speaking terms with her.

Gathering information indirectly was the only thing I could do at the moment.

Just as I was memorizing his face, the phone I held in my right hand vibrated.

"What's up?"

"Hold on."

['I'm waiting in the Student Council room.']

I took out my phone, looked at the text on the screen and tilted my head in my mind.

"...Who could this be?"

Such a short message, from an unregistered contact.

There was no date or time specified, but did that mean right now...?

If my two o'clock appointment today had been moved up, it wouldn't have been strange to get word from Nanase-san. Was this something else, then? Even as I was lost in thought, Amasawa-san continued to walk through Keyaki Mall.

Though I knew I had to follow her, I blanked my phone's screen and closed my eyes.

"I suppose it can't be helped..."

As long as I'd been entrusted with the position of student council president, I couldn't just act on personal feelings alone.

If someone was waiting in the student council room, I had a duty to respond as best as I could.

Or, even if there was a 99% chance it wasn't, it might have been from Ayanokouji-kun.

As a realistic possibility, it might also have been part of the next special exam.

"I'm sorry. I know it's sudden, but I have to go to the student council."

I apologized for having to cut things short before we could even have lunch, despite being the one who invited her.

"Don't worry about it at all. And hey, I won't go tailing Amasawa-san on my own, so don't you worry."

Realizing on her own what I was about to warn her against, Karuizawa-san replied accordingly.

I apologized to her one more time and then decided to head for school.

Part 2

AFTER ABOUT TEN minutes, I arrived in front of the student council room, but no one was there.

No new messages had arrived on my phone either.

On a holiday at this hour, the unused student council room was locked, as one would expect.

"...A prank?"

Though I was suspicious, I used my key to enter the student council room just in case.

Of course, no one was in the silent room and not a single sound could be heard. After returning to the hallway, I decided to wait there for the person who sent the message, just in case.

But, as I expected, the person I was waiting for never appeared, and time simply passed by.

I wonder if it would've been better to follow Amasawa-san after all. A hint of that regret began to sprout, but since I still had about two hours before my official student council duties, I decided to head back for the time being.

Afterward, I went down the stairs to the first floor. From there, I started walking toward the entrance.

"Student Council President Horikita."

Just as I took a few steps down the hallway, a student suddenly called my name.

But no one was in my line of sight until now. Surprised, I turned to look behind me.

"You're... Ishigami-kun, right? Do you need something from me?"

Ishigami Kyou-kun from Class 2-A stood there, dressed in his school uniform.

As I recalled his name, I wondered why such an unusual person would approach me.

It was Saturday, after all. The chances of running into anyone other than students with club activities should've been extremely low.

"It's been a while. I have something I'd like to discuss, so may I have a moment of your time?"

"Of course. It's been quite a while since we've spoken like this."

"That time, it was you who approached me, President."

"That's right."

I recalled the time I invited Ishigami-kun to join the student council. He turned me down flat, but whether or not someone joined was a personal matter, so naturally, I couldn't blame him.

I was pretty sure Ayanokouji-kun was with me then, too...

"Would you mind if we moved somewhere else?"

"Somewhere else? Is it something... difficult to talk about?"

"I'd prefer if no one saw us. I don't intend to take up much of your time."

He said that and without waiting for my permission, turned his back and started walking.



I didn't have any pressing reason to hurry back, so I didn't mind going along with him, but...

There were no other people wandering around the school on this day off, so it seemed like we could talk anywhere without issue. I wondered if that meant it was something he really didn't want anyone to overhear...

"Were you the one who sent me the message?"

"What makes you think so?"

"So you're not going to start with denial."

When I mentioned the message, he didn't seem puzzled and appeared to know what I was talking about.

Furthermore, his attitude seemed to be a natural admission and it didn't look like he had any intention of hiding it.

"If you have something to discuss, on a holiday like today, I can listen to you anywhere. But you specifically said you didn't want to be seen. If we used the student council room, someone might come by, or I might have to call the other student council members. Plus, you approached me on my way back from the student council room. That way, you could confirm I was acting alone before making contact."

I figured he must have stayed out of my sight, waiting for the opportune moment.

"I admit it. I apologize for the roundabout method."

"I don't particularly mind, but if this is a student council consultation requiring urgency, I may not be able to keep it to myself."

The bigger the problem, the more necessary it became to release the information as the student council.

An obligation to report not only to the students but also to the teachers would likely arise.

"You need not worry on that account."

"That isn't something for you to judge personally, though."

"Regarding my consultation—it seems you've been looking into Amasawa, President."

Ishigami-kun spoke without turning to face me, continuing to walk at a steady pace.

"...What do you mean?"

While I felt a slight sense of unease at his unexpected words, I first feigned ignorance.

I'd never made a connection between Ishigami-kun and Amasawa-san, but perhaps my assessment of him had been too naive. She must have noticed I was tailing her early on and requested Ishigami-kun's cooperation. That was a perfectly plausible scenario, and yet I hadn't considered it.

"You're not going to start with denial, are you?"

He stopped and said so as he turned back, his gaze meeting mine without hesitation.

It was to expose and assess the agitation I was trying to hide.

My belated wariness toward him spiked all at once.

"Amasawa and I are in the same class. If she makes any suspicious moves, it's only natural that I'd be informed."

"...I suppose so."

For the last few days, I'd been under the self-assessed assumption that Amasawa-san was a student who preferred to act alone.

But it seemed that wasn't actually the case.

Did she tell Ishigami-kun that she was troubled by me following her and asked for his help—?

No, but...

"So you're displeased that your classmate is being investigated. Is this a warning?"

"No. However, I need to know why the student council is investigating Amasawa. If she is the source of some problem, we as a class will be forced to respond, you see."

It was a perfectly logical reason. For Class A, which appeared to be managed with stability, it was only right to be sensitive to a classmate's misconduct and it was no wonder they had their feelers out.

"In that case, you can rest assured. She isn't in any kind of trouble."

First, I had to clear up Ishigami-kun's misunderstanding.

And doing so would also naturally lead to my own objective.

"Would you mind telling me the reason?"

"Do you know of a student from third-year Class C named Ayanokouji-kun?"

"I've never spoken to him directly, but he's been the subject of various discussions among the second-years as the student who voluntarily transferred from Class A to Class C."

"I see. So you're aware of him, as I'd expect. When I bring this sort of thing up, most students want to ask me how I feel about it, but you don't seem to be that way."

"Unfortunately, I have no interest in students from other years. With that said, I fail to see what this has to do with you investigating Amasawa."

It seemed Ishigami-kun was, through and through, only interested in his own class's affairs.

That was hardly good news for me... but I continued my explanation anyway.

"I'm searching for any student who might know about his life before he enrolled at this school. And in doing so, the possibility arose that Amasawa-san is an old acquaintance of Ayanokouji-kun. That's why I want to ask her for details, but she and I aren't particularly close. I'm hesitant to ask her directly, so I was in the middle of trying to find some kind of lead."

"Why is the student council president investigating the one who betrayed her class?"

"While it isn't a frequent occurrence at this school, now that a class transfer happened, it must be dealt with. He has now moved to Class C and we're now rivals. Surely it isn't so strange for me to try and gather as much information as I can in order to defeat him in the future, right?"

"To know your enemy, you must get inside their camp. Is that what you're saying?"

"Something like that. I may continue to investigate Amasawa-san, but rest assured, it won't have any negative impact on the second-year Class A."

"I understand. However, there's no telling how others will perceive this. If the student council president has her eyes on Amasawa, it could create the misunderstanding that our class has a problem. I would like you to resolve this as quickly as possible."

It wasn't as if I wanted to take my time either, but if it were that simple, I wouldn't be having such a hard time.

"For now, I don't have any information regarding Ayanokouji-senpai, but I have someone in mind who might know about his past."

"Really? Who is it?"

I asked in response to his intriguing statement, but Ishigami-kun didn't answer immediately.

"I don't mind telling you, but I need you to promise me one thing. You must absolutely keep the identity of the person who gave you this student's name—in other words, me—confidential."

For a moment, the thought that he might ask for Private Points as an information fee crossed my mind, but it seemed I was mistaken.

"If that's what you wish, I promise to protect your anonymity."

"The person in question is a student with fairly sharp intuition. It's to be expected that they'll try to figure out how you found your way to them. You can handle that with pride befitting Class A and the student council president, correct?"

He asked for confirmation, deliberately applying pressure as if to make a point.

Perhaps, from Ishigami-kun's perspective, this person was just that troublesome to deal with.

No, that was something I'd known from the very beginning.

If this was a person who knew Ayanokouji-kun's past, it stood to reason that they would be someone of considerable ability.

"I'll do my best. For now, all I can do is ask you to trust my resolve."

I answered him that way, fully intending to refuse if he asked me to wager something or enter a contract.

"Very well. I will place my trust in you, Student Council President Horikita and provide the information."

"...Thank you."

"She's a female student from second-year Class D named Nanase. As she's a member of the student council, you must know her well."

The name of a person I hadn't considered a possibility, someone who was far too close.

Upon hearing it, my thoughts came to a complete and sudden halt.

"I'm afraid that's not the case. I had the opportunity to have tea with her and asked a similar question. She told me she didn't know."

"Perhaps she simply wasn't telling the truth?"

It wasn't just a passing thought; Ishigami-kun looked at me, his tone of voice hinting at a sliver of confidence.

"...Why do you think that? I can't doubt her without reason."

"I am, after all, a member of Class A, so I'm constantly gathering information on the other classes. And in doing so, I've learned that Nanase was in contact with Ayanokouji-senpai from very early on."

"That's—"

It was because Nanase-san participated in the special exam last year, one revealed to only a portion of the first-years, in which they would receive Private Points if they could expel Ayanokouji-kun. I started to say as much but thought better of it. Not all the current second-years knew of that affair, nor had it spread to the third-years.

I decided no one would gain anything if I made a careless remark and dredged up the past.

"Last year's first special exam that you second-years faced. Our class made contact with Nanase-san's class to coordinate, so perhaps that's the connection?"

"I'm aware of that as well. But can we dismiss the possibility that Nanase orchestrated even that initial alliance for the sake of contacting Ayanokouji-senpai?"

"If they were old friends, she could've just spoken to him openly. There would be no need to go to such lengths—"

"You may be right. If I'm just overthinking it, that's fine. Please forget about it."

At that, Ishigami-kun retracted his statement.

Nanase-san knows about Ayanokouji-kun's past?

The only information to go on was Ishigami-kun's statement, so it wasn't particularly credible. However, now that such a possibility had been suggested, even for a moment, it was etched into a corner of my mind against my will.

I felt it was impossible, but if it were true—that would mean...

"...I wonder, could I ask for your cooperation?"

"Cooperation? What for?"

"I want to investigate Nanase-san, just in case. Though you're in different classes, you're both second-years, so I'm sure you have some contact in your daily lives."

"That may be true, but I think it would be difficult for me to cooperate. That's part of the reason I wished to remain anonymous, as it seems Nanase dislikes me."

"She dislikes you...? From the class competition or something?"

"I've had to intervene in our constant troubles with Housen of Class D, even outside of special exams. While I can't determine the exact reason, I'm certain that she dislikes me."

The OAA confirmed that Ishigami-kun possessed exceptional academic ability. He didn't seem to be his class's leader, but assuming he contributed to his class in a position close to that of a strategist, it was a natural dynamic for him to view Nanase-san—or rather, her entire class—with hostility.

However... she wasn't the type to openly dislike someone on a personal level just because they were class rivals. At least, that was the judgment I made based on the information I had at my disposal.

If Ishigami-kun had no way of knowing that about her, then it was understandable that he'd take it that way. Or perhaps the boy standing before me simply didn't want to get dragged into trouble and was making an excuse not to cooperate.

I didn't know if he was someone I could trust, but right now, I just wanted a collaborator.

"Very well. I cannot act directly, but I'll try to do some probing to an extent that my identity isn't discovered. On the chance that Nanase is unrelated, I'll also check if Amasawa or anyone else seems to know about Ayanokouji-senpai. Student Council President Horikita, you just have to keep your promise to me and move forward with your own investigation as you please."

"Yes, thank you. Even if I'm pressed for information, I'll protect you at all costs."

"I am hoping for positive results. Well then."

With those words, Ishigami-kun turned his back on me and started walking in the opposite direction of the entrance. It was likely a precaution, born from his wariness of being seen with me by Nanase-san.

The more I tried to investigate Ayanokouji-kun, the more I felt like I was sinking into a swamp.

"Ayanokouji-kun, just what are you...?"

Even so, I had no choice but to recklessly push through the mud and continue chasing after him.

However, as I renewed my determination, I was still completely unaware.

Of Ayanokouji-kun's birth.

Of the existence of an education and a facility so unreal and harsh that no one who lived a normal life could ever imagine it.

Of the fact that he was the only one who survived, as other children broke one after another.

Of the cruel fate that awaited him later in life—

That was surely the turning point.

My reunion with him, with Ishigami-kun, was the beginning of a great change in my life.

Becoming deeply involved in the life of the man named Ayanokouji Kiyotaka—

An orchestrated encounter.

Author's Afterword

THE YEAR IS passing by in a flash these days. This is Kinugasa.

I'm getting older, and my hernia is starting to flare up again, so I can't say I'm in perfect shape, but other than that, I'm actually getting healthier every year.

My blood pressure and whatnot—the numbers that were a little bad have all trended toward improvement and are now at a level appropriate for my age. All that's left is, really, the hernia... That's the one thing I can't seem to do anything about. But I'll keep at it.

In the next volume, Volume 3, since we're heading into early summer a bit ahead of schedule, that annual event will be coming up sooner.

Volume 2 was, if anything, a more relaxed and heartwarming installment, but this next one might have a bit more of a bite to it.

But since it's me saying this, you'd best take it with a grain of salt.

While I feel there's still a long way to go until the conclusion, when I think about how the first term is already drawing to a close, perhaps it's going by surprisingly fast. I want to avoid touching too much on the main story or the future in the afterword, so I'll stop here for now, brief as it is.

Now for a bit of pointless talk about my private life. Feel free to skip this. (Just filling pages.)

To put it simply, with games I used to play a lot like Mario Kart or Smash Bros., I've had my fill after just twenty or thirty minutes of playing with my kids, and I don't have a single game app on my phone other than YouMaji. I used to think, 'I can't imagine a time without games, what else is there to do?'... But now, before I know it, the day is just over!

And my kids just keep growing up big and healthy in the blink of an eye...

I'm keenly experiencing Janet's Principle, sensing that from now on, I'll probably feel time accelerate more and more as I get older.

Well then, everyone—

I look forward to the day we can meet again before the year is out.

As long as there aren't any major problems, y'know. Any major problems... y'know

Ichinose Honami's Short Story: To Love Too Much…

(Original translation provided by Drago, edited by LegacyEMTLs)

FROM HOSHINOMIYA-SENSEI'S REMARK, I had sensed the possibility that the rules of the special exam were whether or not we could follow regulations, which were implemented not long after enrollment; combining that with the advice from Ayanokouji-kun, that possibility had gotten higher. From the next day, the first day of the implementation period, our class and Ayanokouji-kun had intentionally kept our distance.

Should Ryuuen-kun use his classmates for sabotage, both classes would simultaneously fall under scrutiny.

Whether this precaution paid off, or Ryuuen-kun had changed his methods, I'm not sure, but we were able to spend a week living a normal school life without incident.

However—that one week had felt incredibly long for me.

The time I couldn't see Ayanokouji-kun. Even though we remained connected through our phones, merely not being able to be face-to-face and feel each other's breaths had my heart crying out in anguish.

That's why today, when the special exam ended, I'd invited him to the gym regardless of the results, and was able to spend time with him.

An event that happened on the way back after recharging myself with such happiness. Though his real reason for inviting new members to the gym was transparent, it wasn't a bad suggestion. If the opportunities to interact with Kanzaki-kun and the others were to increase, the class would surely become even better, after all.

"In that case, I'll go ahead and ask them without hesitation."

As I showed a welcoming demeanor, Ayanokouji-kun replied as such.

"Okay, thank you. I'm really happy for your support, Ayanokouji-kun."

With each and every step forward, the dorms grew closer.

Soon, the time to part ways with Ayanokouji-kun would arrive.

It doesn't have to be a deep connection.

However—

Mixed with nervousness, I let the back of my left hand touch the back of his right hand.

I wasn't rejected. I, yearning for his fingers—

Noticing the surging impulse, I quickly pulled my hand back.

“I-I'm sorry... I'm sorry. I just... couldn't help wanting to touch you... even though we're just friends, aren't we.”

No. I can’t be the only one getting like this.

Until Ayanokouji-kun comes to yearn for me, I have to stay on the same level as him.

I never knew that loving someone too much could be this painful.

Whilst thinking this, I peered into Ayanokouji-kun’s eyes…

Morishita Ai's Short Story: Ear Gun

(Original translation provided by Drago, edited by LegacyEMTLs)

"UM... I-I, THEREFORE..."

Before my very eyes, Yamamura Miki kept fidgeting, whimpering, squirming, and dithering in indecision.

She is utterly incapable of being direct. But what irritates me is that Ayanokouji Kiyotaka is just watching over her quietly, as though fancying himself as a father watching over his child's growth, waiting for her to find her words.

"So... what I want to say is..."

In this world, time is money. I was planning on applying myself to some human-watching among the squirming masses outside after school today, so I'd like to wrap this up quickly.

Merely watching over someone isn't how you raise a child.

As someone who had successfully and splendidly raised a tadpole shrimp, after all, I would know.

I began moving silently and stood right next to Yamamura Miki.

Her eyes were locked only on Ayanokouji Kiyotaka in front of her, so there were no signs of her noticing me at all.

Good grief. How pathetic, for a person who prides herself on her ability to tail others to be so easily approached from the side.

For someone like her, I shall grant her this special move.

"Fwooh!"

I puckered my lips forcefully and blew a puff of my peach-scented breath, aiming for Yamamura Miki's ear canal.

"Wha-a-a-aah!?"

I succeeded in startling her magnificently, causing her to let out a shriek the likes of which I'd never heard before.

"Wh-wh-wh-what are you doing...!?"

"Hmph. That's the *Ear Gun*. All those who're caught unaware are startled, you see."

"You probably based that on 'air gun,' but isn’t that... still just an air gun?"

Indeed, the Ear Gun also uses the power of wind. To think he’d grasp the true principle of this special move in an instant...

"Now that you mention it, that is true indeed. I shall praise you, Ayanokouji Kiyotaka."

However, I did not reveal this special move merely for the sake of showing it off.

It was to give a push to the back of Yamamura Miki, who was too nervous to move forward.

As though to add the finishing touch, I gave her cheek a little pinch.

"Wh-What!?"

"How about it, Yamamura Miki? Don't you feel a little less tense now?"

She should now be able to reflect on her own situation for a moment, and with this, move forward.

And so, today once again, I have helped those around me.

What an outstanding person. What an outstanding genius. My own talent is frightening to behold—.

Shiina Hiyori's Short Story: A Wavering Heart

(Original translation provided by Drago, edited by LegacyEMTLs)

RETURNING TO MY dorm room, I sat on the edge of my bed to rest my body.

In my hand was a single poppy flower.

Simply by gazing at it, I couldn't help but feel my heart being fulfilled.

I simultaneously recalled the sight of Ayanokouji-kun who'd come to see me in the library.

How it happened immediately after I resolved and convinced myself that I'd come to hate him.

How he told me he wanted to see me again tomorrow.

My resolve to break away from him had already flown away somewhere.

"It's frightening to feel so fulfilled…"

A day that had thrown my heart into turmoil, yet one that turned into something truly wonderful.

Even I am deeply shocked myself. That such a large and powerful emotion had been hiding within me.

I understand it now.

That I see Ayanokouji-kun as a man, as a member of the opposite sex, and have fallen in love with him.

—

Spinning the flower gently, I let out a small sigh.

"It's okay, right...? To keep on loving him like this..."

I asked the poppy that would never answer me.

Ayanokouji-kun and Karuizawa-san have broken up.

So, I know that it's not wrong for me to love him.

But I don't have the courage to tell him how I feel, and above all else, we still remain in different classes.

As we continue to compete for Class A, these emotions surely won’t lead to anything good.

Can I really fight against Ayanokouji-kun's class while I'm still in love with him, I wonder…

"I..."

It’d be best if I cast aside such covetous thoughts and be content to remain as his precious friend.

Wanting anything more than that is wrong.

In the first place, there is no guarantee that Ayanokouji-kun even sees me that way.

Remaining as we are right now.

Remaining like this.

Not too close, not too far.

It might be a happier fate for my first love to end while it remains faint and fleeting, I think.

"Surely... that's the correct answer, right?"

I asked the poppy flower one last time.

Shiraishi Asuka's Short Story: The Voice Hidden Within

(Original translation provided by Drago, edited by LegacyEMTLs)

OVER THE COURSE of more than two years of my school life.

I cannot deny that the feeling of *I mustn't hear those words*, and the feeling of *I want to hear those words*, had jumbled up into a confusing mess inside me.

"It may be conceited of me to say, but hadn't you been watching me, to some extent, before I transferred classes?"

His gaze and his voice mercilessly pierced into me.

"Ah..."

I was found out. He found me out.[1]

Conflicting feelings kept flooding my mind simultaneously.

It would be easy to line up excuses, but that would be unforgivable.

"Ahh... that just won't do."

I have a noble cause. A duty as an observer.

To meet the expectations of Shirogane-sensei, I had continued to do the same thing every single day.

That day, when I was called into that room just before graduation.

My mission began ever since the day I learnt about you, and yet…

"'Won't do'? What's wrong?"

There was nothing different from usual in Ayanokouji-kun's voice.

It wasn't that he had arrived at a firm conclusion; rather, my own irrepressible gazes and mannerisms must have given birth to his suspicion, I suppose.

Please, forgive me.

Please, just for this moment, allow me to forget that duty.

"I am Shiraishi Asuka."

Our conversations up until now had been a lie.

That's why, for my self-introduction at the very least, I wanted to speak from the heart, you know...

"And you—who are you?"

Would he answer me, I wonder.

Would he answer this question of mine—the voice of my first true introduction, which I'd kept hidden deep within—.

---

[1]: When Shiraishi says "He found me out" (知ってもらえた, shittemoraeta), she expresses it with a sense of gratitude, as if he did her a favor by noticing or understanding her. It's a nuance that's quite difficult to fully capture in English, so I’m leaving this note for anyone reading to be aware of it.

Special Short Story: The Six First-Year Students

TSUBAKI GAZED OUT the cafe window. Her expression is somewhat serious, somewhat delicate.

In her line of sight, the second-year Ayanokoji Kiyotaka was walking.

"Tsubaki, do you want to move up to Class A?"

"...Not really. They say that's what the goal of the school is, then isn't it something like a mission for the enrolled students to give it their all?"

"Not much time has passed since I met you, but you don't seem like the type to act like she's carrying a mission."

"Maybe. But aren't you the same, Utomiya-kun? You don't seem interested in things like Class A or special privileges."

Averting her gaze from Ayanokouji, Tsubaki turns her eyes to Utomiya, who is sitting next to her.

Seeing this, Utomiya looks somewhat awkward and turns his face away, towards the outside window.

"It's Housen and Nanase."

"Hm...?"

In the line of sight of Utomiya, who was muttering to change the subject, were two first-year Class D students who were about to pass by Ayanokouji.

It looked like there might be some kind of contact, but there was no exchange of words, only Nanase giving a polite nod.

"Coincidence? Or not?"

"I can't say anything just from that. But the bandage on Ayanokouji's left hand—it piques my interest a bit."

"He was wearing something like that?"

Tsubaki, who hadn't noticed, shifted her gaze to Utomiya once again.

"Maybe something had happened. Knowing Housen's personality, it wouldn't be surprising if he started it."

"You mean he injured his hand? Housen-kun looked unharmed, though."

"If they clashed somewhere, Ayanokouji probably chose not to fight back. There's a risk in carelessly injuring your opponent."

"Oh? But for that to happen, wouldn't Ayanokouji-senpai also need a certain level of skill?"

"His actual fighting ability is unknown, but I can't imagine him losing to someone at Housen's level. I can tell that much just by watching his usual demeanor and presence."

"'Housen-kun's level'... Are you serious? He seems to just rampage around as he pleases, though."

What surprised Tsubaki was not the high evaluation of Ayanokouji, but the low estimation of Housen.

"That's just because everyone around him is weak. ——Probably."

Feeling he had said too much, Utomiya trailed off.

Men are creatures who bluff. Most of them inwardly believe they are stronger than whoever they face.

There was a good chance that Utomiya's remark was just a bluff, or that he simply had an abnormally high self-assessment, but he wasn't usually one to behave like that.

For the first time, Tsubaki felt a slight interest in her classmate, Utomiya.

"I think I've become a little interested in getting to know you, Utomiya-kun."

"Stop it. I don't pry into anyone's business, and I don't want anyone prying into mine."

"Ahh~. What a nice atmosphere~. Could it be that you two are dating?"

A shadow fell between the two, and a girl appeared as if to interrupt them. It was Amasawa from first-year Class A.

"We are not dating."

Utomiya denied it instantly. Tsubaki also nodded in agreement, not seeming particularly interested.

"You think so? For that, your sense of distance seemed pretty close, though~"

"It's your imagination. Did you approach us just to say something so stupid? Or did you come over because you wanted to extract some information from us?"

When Utomiya retorted in a harsh tone, Amasawa smiled, her lips curling in delight.

"Oh, come on, I didn't mean it like that. Even if our classes are different, we're still first-years, so let's get along. Right, Tsubaki-chan?"

"Sorry, but I'll pass. I'm not exactly looking for friends."

"So harsh, meow~"

Without looking particularly shocked, Amasawa gave a cute reply.

"Well then, I guess I'll save deepening our friendship for next time. See you later, Tsubaki-chan, Utomiya-kun."

Saying that, Amasawa left behind a blown kiss, turned her back, and walked away.

"Amasawa doesn't know about the special exam, right?"

"She shouldn't. In Class A, only Takahashi and Ishigami know. However, I can't deny the possibility that they asked her to investigate even without knowing the details."

"I see."

"But in any case, it's a baffling exam. To think it's targeting a specific individual, only Ayanokouji."

"It might be something that's normal at this school, and we just don't know about it."

"...If that's the case, it makes the situation even more unsettling."

"Hello, Utomiya-kun. And Tsubaki-san as well."

A voice calls out from a short distance away.

Yagami from first-year Class B, who had come to the cafe, stopped and approached the two.

"Now it's Yagami... He's the type to show up if you talk about the exam."

"Can you blame him? The amount of private points you can get is on a whole other level."

"If you don't mind, could I join your conversation as well?"

"We were just having a boring small talk, that's all."

"It didn't look that way to me. It seemed you were watching Ayanokouji-senpai and Housen-kun's group."

"Oh... So you've been watching us from quite an early stage."

"It was just a coincidence, though."

"Either way, we're enemies."

"It's precisely because we are enemies that there is meaning in talking to each other, don't you think?"

Utomiya, Tsubaki, Housen, Nanase, Yagami.

What they all had in common, Yagami included, was that they were all targeting Ayanokouji Kiyotaka.

Tsubaki and Utomiya had no way of knowing, but Amasawa was also involved in a certain special exam for first-year students.

From this gathering, the story connects to the upcoming special exam on the uninhabited island—.

LegacyEMTLs Afterword

First off I would like to apologize for all the delays with releasing this volume. We certainly felt the impact of missing some staff. Anyways, I would like to thank everyone who helped with translating, editing, and typesetting this volume. It was certainly a beast. I would also like to thank you, the reader, for choosing our translation to read. We certainly wouldn't be here without you. I hope you enjoyed this volume as much as I did. Anyways, peace ✌

- Colibri

LegacyEMTLs Credits

Colibri - Lead / Dev

I dead

FS7 - JE Checker

I miss Arisu

1chi - English Editor

Ah yes, Kinu's masterful baiting shenanigans never end. This time it's Hiyori. Can't wait for Kushida's turn.

Hiyori's Only Lover - English Editor

Hmmmm, I don't know what to say. This volume was decent. But I don't what to feel regarding Hiyori's situation, you never know what kinu will do. Soooo nasty, the King.

Writer - English Editor

Teehee no clue what this is about but yay!!!!!

Life's good teehee

Sky - English Editor

Still waiting for Hiyori to carry the whole novel, any day now...

Axcel - JE Checker

"Farewell, My Lovely"

Stella - JE Checker

I fear for Hiyori's future. Many red flags... But I'm also curious to see Kiyotaka's development!

Kall_tho - English Editor

Still obsessed with Honami-chan iykyk :P

3F - Illustrator

Fnck y3 illustrations and fnck every fncking character who's illustrated as a spaghetti doodle.